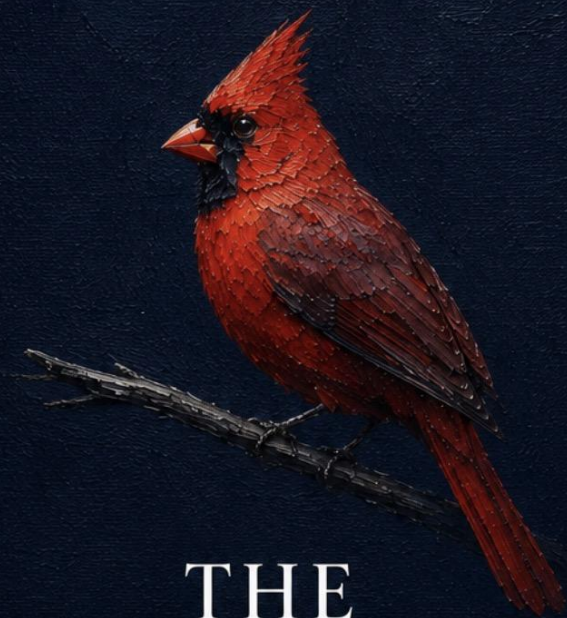


"I've known this man for thirty-five years. You can trust what you're about to read."

— DAVE MEYER, former NFL quarterback



THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

A Memoir of the Father Who Stayed

ROB BRIZZI

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PRAISE FOR THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

*“Thirty-five years of friendship, and I can tell you: you can
trust what you’re about to read.”*

— Dave Meyer, former Virginia Tech captain and NFL quarterback

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This is a work of memoir. It reflects the author's present recollections of experiences over time. Some names and identifying details have been changed, some dialogue has been reconstructed, and some events are rendered as composites, as described in the Author's Note.

*For anyone who has struggled with addiction or loved someone who
has*

*In honor of Lou Brizzi —
the man who kept showing up.*

1941–2025

For Hope, who tilted her head and said “We?”

THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

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PROLOGUE

“He brought me up out of an horrible pit, out of the miry clay, and set my feet upon a rock.” — Psalm 40:2

Tijuana, Mexico, 2005

His hands were already around my throat before I understood he had crossed the cell. Small man. Moving too fast. Wired on meth or something close enough that his whole body carried the unstable energy of someone who might come apart without warning. Somebody in the dark made a snarling sound, low and animal. Somebody else said his name. Rico. Nobody moved to stop him. Even in here, the others feared him. His face came an inch from mine. The only English he had came out in a rasp.

“Gringo. Gringo. Money.”

Of course he knows how to say money.

“No tengo dinero,” I told him. It came out begging — thin and high, a voice I didn’t recognize as mine. It was true. They had already taken everything.

“Money. Money.” One hand came off my throat and he rubbed his fingers against his thumb, the money sign from every movie ever made, while the other hand kept its grip. The fingers pressed. Eased.

Pressed again. His breath was sour and chemical, hot against my mouth. Then the hands dropped. He muttered something, backed to the wall, and the dark took him.

The night had started ordinary. A workday. A Tuesday in my San Diego years. When I was done I crossed into Tijuana the way I always did — for the pharmacies, for the pills my prescriptions back home could no longer keep up with. I wasn't sober that night. I'd been using in Tijuana since I crossed, and I was down to the last of my supply — to an addict, an emptying bottle is the only emergency that counts. I'd crossed enough times that I thought I understood how it worked. That was the problem. Do something dangerous often enough and it stops feeling dangerous. It starts to feel like an errand.

This time a cop saw the watch.

He was on foot, working the strip near the crossing, and he slowed when he passed my window the way they do when they've already decided something. He circled back. Tapped the glass with two fingers. I rolled it down because there was nothing else to do with a tap like that. His eyes went to my wrist before they went to my face. I'd worn the watch because it made me feel like the man I was pretending to be. Now it was the reason a cop in Tijuana had stopped walking. This was not a traffic stop. I hadn't broken a law he cared about. He'd seen something he wanted on the arm of a man nobody would come looking for.

He said something I couldn't understand. He didn't say it loud. He didn't need to. I got out.

He had the watch off my wrist inside a minute. Then the bag. Then everything else in my pockets, one item at a time, no hurry in it anywhere, and the no-hurry was the part that scared me. For a moment I thought that might be the end of it, that I'd be sent back across the line with one more story I'd never tell. Then he took my arm and walked me to a car that wasn't marked like the ones on TV. No lights. A plain sedan with a man in the passenger seat who never

turned around. A hand on my shoulder put me in the back. The car smelled musty, like old smoke had soaked into the seats and stayed. He said things from the front I couldn't understand, and then he stopped saying anything. Some part of me kept running the old math, telling me this was a toll, a cost of doing business, a story I'd never tell. Then I reached for the door and there was no handle on the inside, and the math stopped working.

I don't know how long we drove. Long enough for the streets outside the window to lose their lights. When the car stopped, the door opened from the outside — of course it did — and the hand came back.

It walked me through a metal door and down a hallway that got darker the deeper we went. Voices somewhere ahead of us. No desk. No paperwork. Nobody asked my name, and nobody wrote it down anywhere. That landed one step at a time: there was going to be no record that I was here. At the end of the hall, a man pulled a door open. The hand let go of my arm, and something between a push and a shove put me through.

It wasn't a prison. It was a holding cell in a building I could never have found again. I didn't know where I was, who knew I was there, or how long they meant to keep me.

The smell reached me before the door shut.

Sewer. Vomit. Mold. Sweat over the top of it. Something rotten and sweet underneath that stuck to the back of the throat. I gagged on it, swallowed, gagged again. When the door closed, the dark seemed to move. I stood still and waited for my eyes to adjust. They didn't. Not really. Shapes shifted. Breathing came from every direction — wet, close, uneven. In the corner a cough ran too long and ended in a rattle. A rat crossed the floor, claws on concrete, and was gone.

The men spoke Spanish faster than I could follow. It had been my first language once. Mexico was where I started. By now it was

buried far enough down that I could hear it without holding it, and the words moved past me in pieces.

Some of the men were gone in the head — rocking, laughing, talking to no one. Others sat with their backs to the wall and their eyes empty. A few just watched me. I didn't belong there and they knew it. Rico was one of the ones who watched.

My throat burned. I wanted to put a hand to it and didn't. I wasn't going to let the room see. I slid down the wall instead and sat, knees to my chest, the concrete cold through my clothes, my forehead down. I knew the position. My body found it before my mind caught up. Get small. Stay quiet. Don't hold anyone's eye. Don't give the room a reason to pick you. It was the same shape I'd folded into as a boy when the yelling started.

There was no bedroom this time. No hallway light. And no one on earth knew where I was.

Not my father. Not my brother. Not my mother. No one.

I sat on a concrete floor in Mexico with my head on my knees, and the life I'd been performing was somewhere else. What was left was the smell, the dark, and my own breathing.

The high was wearing off. I could feel the far edge of it, the place where the sick starts, and somewhere underneath the counting had already begun — how long since the last pill, how long until the need got loud. If somebody had opened that door and offered me the outside without my drugs or the pit with them, I would have chosen the pit. That is the truest thing I can tell you about that night.

I lost track of time. The voices flattened into noise. I thought about my mother, her hand around mine in the airport when I was four, the woman who carried me out of this country to give me a life. I'd come back to take myself apart. Then my father, Lou. That was worse. He'd chosen me — a boy from Mexico City who wasn't his — made me his son, gave me his name, sat in the bleachers and paid the bills and handed over money he didn't have, and never once

PROLOGUE

made me feel I had to earn the place. Somewhere back home he was asleep, believing his son was safe. And I'd put myself here.

I wanted to pray and couldn't. I still believed, somewhere under it. Asking for help out of a hole I'd dug myself was more than I could do.

The door opened. Light cut in. I looked up and stayed where I was, afraid it was for someone else, afraid to stand too fast. A man said something and waved me forward. I got up. My legs were wrong under me. I stepped around the wet places and around the men, past Rico, who didn't look at me. Outside the air wasn't clean, but it was air. Someone handed me back a fold of my own money, enough to get across the line and home. Not all of it. Enough.

I came back the next day.

PART ONE

THE ESCAPE

CHAPTER 1 ## Mexico City — The Escape

“The LORD shall preserve thy going out and thy coming in from this time forth, and even for evermore.” — Psalm 121:8

Mexico City, 1982

“Claudio,” my mother said, “you will love this story.”

That summer she was obsessed with *E.T.* The movie wasn’t even out yet, but she’d already tracked down and read the paperback. One afternoon she sat me down to explain it. She told me about an alien left behind by his spaceship, and the boy who hid him in his room to try to get him home.

“What are aliens?” I asked.

She stopped and thought for a second.

“People,” she said. “Just from somewhere so far away you can’t even imagine it.”

I closed my eyes and tried to picture people from that far away. I couldn’t. I couldn’t even picture the people who lived two blocks from our apartment.

The only world I knew was Mexico City. I was four years old.

We lived in Bosques de Aragón, in a two-story brick row house on a dead-end street, the houses wrapped around a patch of grass. The walls were thick and you heard everything anyway. Radios. Fights. The street vendors shouting before sunrise. Music from passing cars and open windows. Overhead, old sneakers hung by their laces from the power lines, swinging in the breeze.

Rosa María and Armando lived next door. A clothesline ran between our balconies, always full of sheets drying stiff under the hot sun. Every morning started the same way: my mother put a pot of beans on the stove, and the whole house filled with the smell. Beans, onions, sugar, and the warm bread she bought from the bakery on the corner.

My mother taught English at a little preschool called Cascabelito. Little Bell. Because she worked there, I got to go for free. In the afternoons she'd put on music and dance around the kitchen while making tacos. She would scoop my little brother, Chris, up on her hip and sing along to "The Loco-Motion," and I'd dance right next to her because she was happy. That was all the reason I needed.

My mother, Becky, had followed my father to Mexico because she loved him. Blonde and American, she stood out on our street, and she stayed anyway. She learned Spanish from soap operas, built a life in the middle of Mexico City, and chose him even when the people who loved her most questioned the decision. She always made her own way. Chris and I were born from that courage. Or stubbornness. She needed both.

I didn't understand the sacrifice. I knew the smell of dinner, the music playing in the kitchen, and her hand reaching down to hold mine.

My papa was a proud man. He worked a government job, and every morning he left the house in pressed clothes. He'd take off running and I'd come after him and we'd race. He always got there first. Then he'd turn around with a grin and say, "Wow, you're fast today." I believed him every time.

He bought me my own record player, a Fisher-Price like the neighbor's. One day he came home excited about a promotion and picked me up. "Claudio," he said, "you are my good luck charm." Olive skin, high cheekbones, a strong jawline, a face built for the grin he was wearing. That was my name then. Claudio Horacio

Balderas — his own name folded into the middle of mine. When my father looked at you, you were the center of the world. He told me he was proud of me and I ran around the house like I owned it.

At night he told me a story, his voice low, like every word mattered. The rabbit in the moon. He said a long time ago a god came down and walked the earth as a tired old man, hungry, and the only one who shared what little he had was a small rabbit. To thank him, the god lifted the rabbit up and pressed his shape into the moon, so anyone who looked up would remember. “Look,” Papa would say, pointing out the window at the moon. “He’s still up there.” I’d beg him to tell it again, and he always would. Just the two of us in the dark, and I never wanted it to end.

I did not know why he sometimes disappeared. I did not know why Mama was afraid. I only knew that when he came home, I wanted him to read me the rabbit story again.

But there was another side to Papa. He’d sit in cafés after work, playing chess, drinking coffee, not coming home. Some weekends he slept straight through, and his own father had to come and wake him. One Thanksgiving my mom cooked the whole dinner, and Papa never got up for it. Other times he left for work and didn’t come back. A day. Then two. Then three. Then he’d walk in worn out, his eyes gone somewhere, go straight to the bedroom, lock the door, and shut the house out.

I’d push the door open a crack and look in. He was always asleep.

Then he’d come out and act as if nothing had happened. We’d have dinner. He’d read to me until I fell asleep.

I never knew which Papa I was going to get. It took me years to understand I’d been watching two different men.

When my mother pushed back, it turned. One night it went physical, a single slap, and that one time told her plainly what the locked doors and the disappearances had only hinted at — that the

drinking had him, and the man it left behind was someone she could no longer predict. His family knew, and they took his side. She had warned them more than once that she was going to leave. They answered that if she did, they would keep one of us. The threat to take a child was the thing she could not live with. In the end, that's why we left.

That's the reason, and I believe it. I'd add one thing that's only my read on her. She wasn't happy in that marriage, and I think she looked around and decided America might be better for her boys. I can't speak for her.

There's a picture of me from back then. A little kid in a Mickey Mouse shirt washed so many times it had gone gray, though Mickey still held his color. I wore it until it fell apart.

After Mama and Papa, I loved Marcelo, my older cousin. A few years ahead of me, which at that age is a whole generation, and I followed him everywhere. One day he took me to the market for gum. He walked me down the rows, naming things, while I looked at all of it. The gum came in big wrappers in every color, and there was one flavor every kid in the neighborhood wanted. Mango. We found it. I walked home with a piece of it in my cheek.

My mom got pregnant with Chris when I was two; he was born just before I turned three. The week before, I wouldn't let my mother put me down. I'd grab her hips while she walked and let her drag me along the floor. "Let go," she kept saying. I didn't want to let go. I wanted to be carried. She told me she couldn't carry me anymore because there was going to be another baby. I asked if the baby could be mine. She said yes.

When she came through the door with him I climbed up on the couch next to her. "Is that my baby? Can I hold him?" She put him in my arms. He let out a thin little cry and I didn't know what to do with it. "Okay," I said. "I'll try again later." And I handed him back.

For years I told Chris he'd been small enough to fit in my pocket when he was born. He believed me. That was the fun part of having a little brother. He believed everything you said.

Chris cried a lot as a baby. His ears, my mother said. She'd hold him for hours. I'd go to my room and play the same record again. But I got used to it. He was mine, after all. I'd asked, and she'd said yes.

I don't remember every detail of those first years in Mexico. Memories from when you are two, three, and four don't come back as whole stories. They come back in pieces. One of them is Marcelo's birthday party, the piñata breaking open, candy spilling everywhere. They must be rich, I remember thinking. Look at all that candy.

Mexico was home.

After several years of marriage my mother had seen enough. Love was never the question. She didn't announce anything. She got our passports quietly and said we were going to New Jersey to visit Grandpa. Two weeks. Like every other trip. I believed her completely.

When we packed for New Jersey, my mama told me I could bring four shirts.

"I want my Mickey Mouse shirt," I said. The one from the picture — gray with a black collar and red and yellow designs on the front, washed soft. Papa had given it to me.

"It's too small," she said.

"No. Now it fits just right."

She let me pack it.

Papa stood in the hallway with a folded newspaper under his arm. "I'll see you in two weeks," he said. He believed it too. My mother kissed him. "I love you," she said. I hugged him goodbye. I think I had the Mickey Mouse shirt on.

Chris was about a year and a half when we left Mexico. Hazel eyes, light skin. Not like me.

Then the airport. My mother carried a suitcase and Chris while I dragged a little red one behind me. I'd flown once before, to Houston, when I was two and a half, the trip to see Aunt Terry when Kevin was born, but I didn't remember any of it. As far as I knew, I'd never seen a plane up close. The engines came up through the floor and the seat and into me. When we started down the runway something pushed me back into my seat. I looked out the window. The houses and the streets slid by, slow and then fast, until they ran together and dropped away under the clouds.

The only world I'd ever known was gone. I didn't know that's what I was watching. I thought I'd see it again in two weeks.

My mom showed me how to pop my ears. I blew too hard and it scared me. Then I put my head on her arm and fell asleep.

She sat awake. The whole flight she was waiting for someone to stop her, at the gate, in the aisle, at the door. She held her breath, ready to be pulled off the plane before it took off. She was leaving the country where she'd tried to build a life with a man she loved and couldn't live with. The school with the little bell. The cul-de-sac, the grass, the thick walls, Rosa María and Armando next door. She was walking away from all of it on purpose, and she couldn't grieve any of it yet — not out loud, not with her son asleep on her arm still believing it was a two-week trip.

We landed in New Jersey at the start of winter. The airport felt like home at first. Same crowds, same noise, everyone rushing. Then I started listening. The words were wrong. Not Spanish. Something else. Everybody around me knew something I didn't.

CHAPTER 2 ## New Jersey: Survival

*“Strength and honour are her clothing; and she shall rejoice
in time to come.” — Proverbs 31:25*

West Paterson, New Jersey, 1983

My aunt Nancey picked us up in her small red Honda Civic and drove us to Cedar Grove, to the house my mother had grown up in. I stepped outside and saw my own breath for the first time. I didn't know that could even happen. I'd only seen smoke like that come off a cigarette. The three of us crowded in there for two or three months before moving to a bigger house in West Paterson.

My Spanish disappeared almost overnight. English was everywhere. I picked it up the way kids do, without deciding to. Back home I'd had a lisp. In New Jersey they sent me to speech therapy twice a week to fix the way I talked. Decades later it still comes out at the worst times.

My grandfather was strict, or so my mother said. He'd never approved of the marriage, but he let us stay with him. We paid him eight hundred a month. Chris and I never saw that side of him. To us he was kind, and he was the one who kept the routine. My nana mostly stayed in the background. My aunts Nancey or Terry, or Grandpa, watched us when my mother had to find work. My mom started over with no degree and nobody to fall back on, and she worked. That's her story to tell, in her own voice, and I hope she

does. This book is here because of her. When it came down to it, she picked us over him.

Still, I missed my papa.

When we first moved, she told me that we'd be back home in two weeks. I believed her. I was four. I don't know if she believed it too.

Crammed inside my tiny red suitcase was everything from my past life. The Mickey Mouse shirt became part of my last memory of home.

Two weeks became the rest of my life.

Compared to Mexico City, West Paterson sounded like a monastery where all the monks had taken a vow of silence. In Mexico City, sound and noise had been the texture of every day. My grandparents' house had none of it. The quiet there was on purpose. The house ran on a schedule: dinner at the same time, lights out at the same time, conversation that never wandered past what could be handled politely. It wasn't unkind, only controlled. After where I'd come from, New Jersey quiet felt close to safe.

Before long I made friends on the street, Frank and Jason, and I'd run to find them and be outside all day.

School confused me. I understood more than I could say, so I watched the other kids for cues, when to talk, when to laugh, how to stand. I quickly learned it was safer to take a room in than to announce myself. With a name like Claudio Horacio Balderas in a class of John Smiths and Erik Thomases, I stuck out. Nobody could pronounce any of it. They landed on Cloudio, which was better than some of the intentional mispronunciations, like Badder-Ass.

"What do you want to be when you grow up?" No grown-up ever asked me that. Which is good, because I would have had no answer. I couldn't have named a job if I'd tried. But I knew what I hoped to do as I got older. One word: survive. Get through the day, stay small, don't give anyone a reason to look twice.

My mother worked all the time, titleless jobs that nobody else wanted. She left early and came home tired. I saw far less of her than I had in Mexico. At night I'd climb into her bed and ask to play with her hair, and some nights she let me. The nights she did, something settled in my chest I couldn't have named. She put food on the table, kept us clean, made us safe. The thing I recall most wasn't the big sacrifices, and there were plenty of those. It was the smaller things, like the long nights she waitressed on her feet for hours, making her the kind of tired that sinks into your back and stays. On her way home, she would call to see if I was still up.

The phone would ring once, maybe twice, and I'd grab it before it woke the house. I could hear the cars around her, the engine, the road.

"You still up?"

"Yeah."

"You want McDonald's?"

I always said yes. She knew the order before I gave it. Two double cheeseburgers, no mustard, no onion, fries, and a vanilla shake. She'd brought it home a hundred times. Then the car door, the bag crinkling, the smell of it before I even saw her, and her face, worn all the way down, watching me eat. A woman who had spent the entire night feeding strangers, coming home to feed her kid one more time before she slept.

That's how I knew my mother loved me.

Chris had left Mexico as a baby, so he took to New Jersey without trouble. I'd left as a four-year-old with a father to miss.

At night I thought about Horacio, not with anger, with confusion, half-expecting him to turn up one day so we could pick things back up. I didn't know how to love a man who was gone but not dead. No funeral, no grave, no explanation a child could hold. Grief has a shape when somebody dies, something to point at, a day people mark on a calendar. What I had instead was a door I kept checking, quietly,

for years, without ever admitting that's what I was doing. The grown-ups rarely spoke of him, and when they did, they mentioned him carefully, the way you handle something that might break if you name it straight.

My grandparents gave me what they had, which was steadiness, a house that stayed where it was, meals that came when they were supposed to. Not the warmth my mother gave, but reliability, and that counts for a lot when the ground has just moved. There's a wedding photograph of them walking down the aisle, Grandpa in a white dinner jacket, dark hair slicked back, grinning like he'd won something; Nana on his arm in satin, red lipstick, an armful of white roses. The two of them could have passed for movie stars. They'd aged into it gracefully — Grandpa bald by then, green-eyed, still a handsome face, a cigarette usually going somewhere in the house; Nana's high cheekbones still carrying the pretty face from that picture.

Grandpa taught high school history. At home he was a simple man, and I loved him for it. He was devoted to Wendy's, the Frosties most of all, and told me once, dead serious, that the one hole in his life was that Wendy's wouldn't sell hot dogs. He and my nana drank port wine every night out of paper cups, from a jug they kept. And ketchup was less a condiment than a way of life. It went on everything — ketchup on the ketchup — a habit I took whole.

While he taught history, he also made me interested in science. Once he took me to the railroad tracks and showed me how to lay a quarter on the rail. Then we ran off and came back after the train passed to find it flattened smooth. My mother didn't agree when she found out, but he never saw the problem.

Their dog, Abbey, became my partner at the dinner table; anything on my plate I didn't like somehow found its way to her. After dinner, we'd often play UNO, War, and checkers. Chris took up chess with him, but chess was never mine. UNO was enough.

Grandpa never talked much about his own hard childhood, but it showed in a certain toughness he expected from everyone around him.

Then there was my nana, Jan, who could catch you off guard with her gentleness. One afternoon, not long after I'd learned about cowboys and Indians in school, she mentioned she had some American Indian in her.

I burst into tears and ran to my mother. "Mom! Nana's an Indian! She's an Indian!"

From an early age, I had strong opinions about the way things should be. In my mind, cowboys were the good guys who'd ride in to save the day; Indians were the bad guys to be feared.

I also had a strong opinion about which colors belonged to Mom and my aunt Nancey. Mom always wore red nail polish, Aunt Nancey always pink. That's just how the world worked. It had always been that way, and it followed that this rule should remain for evermore. I didn't make up those rules. Then one day, Mom and Aunt Nancey broke them. Mom came home with pink nails, and Nancey with red. I lost it. Sobbing, I insisted they had it wrong and had to put it back the way it should be. When they saw my response, they returned to the salon and changed their nails back to the "right" colors just to settle me.

I'd lost a country, a father, and a language.

Nancey, my mother's youngest sister, treated Chris and me as her own from the start. She was at the games and the matches, always in our corner. Nancey was in her early twenties when we arrived from Mexico, years before she met Charlie. She started seeing him when I was eight and married him two years later. He became my uncle. She told me not long ago that no matter how old I get, she'll always see the same little kid, and I know the one she means: the boy in the backseat too scared to get out of the car.

Aunt Terry's family had the house at Pines Lake. We'd flown to see Terry once before, in Houston, when my cousin Kevin was born and my mom was pregnant with Chris. Nancey and my grandparents all crowded into the little two-bedroom with us. The American thread never broke, even from Mexico City.

Once we landed in New Jersey for good, Terry's house was where I made ordinary kid memories. A Halloween with the three of us in costume on the kitchen floor, tearing into the candy, Kevin as He-Man, me as a pumpkin, and Wolfie, their German shepherd, dressed as Battle Cat. Hide-and-seek on the metal railing between the levels, where I was sure I was hidden and laughed until I cried when I sprang out and scared the one who came looking. Kevin glued to his Nintendo while the rest of us ran. A pool where somebody towed me dry while I announced I was cold, and I jumped straight back in.

What I love now is how close my mother and her sisters have become, she and Nancey and Terry, a closeness that deepened after they lost their own mother. Back then, still in those first months in New Jersey, my mom had called Papa when we landed and told him the truth. We weren't coming back. About six months later, he came anyway. He moved in with us at Grandpa and Nana's house. Even though I don't think Grandpa cared for Papa, he helped him find a job at El Torito, a Mexican restaurant. Chris wasn't even two and couldn't say the name of the restaurant. He called it El Dorito and talked about the balloons. For a little while, we were a family again: Mama, Papa, Chris, and me, trying to build a life in a place that still didn't feel like home.

Papa had a way of making an ordinary day feel extraordinary. One afternoon he dressed Chris and me as Batman and Robin, though it wasn't Halloween. Mama was furious. Papa just laughed. To him, we didn't need a holiday to become superheroes. Looking back, I think he was trying to give us something no job, no country,

and no amount of uncertainty could take away: the freedom to be kids.

“Wanna race?” Papa asked me.

Instead of answering, I took off running, taking a healthy lead. I beat him. I remember feeling proud.

He held me for a minute while our breathing came back. Then he sat on the ground and cradled me in his lap.

“Claudio, I need to leave.”

I started crying.

“It will be okay,” he told me.

He looked sad when he said it. The old patterns were still there — different bars in a different country now, the same nights he didn’t come home — and he couldn’t make it work.

He went back to Mexico. It would be years before I saw him again.

A year later, my mother told us there was someone she wanted us to meet.

CHAPTER 3 ## The Man Who Didn't Have To

“A father of the fatherless... is God in his holy habitation.”
— Psalm 68:5

New Jersey, 1984

The first time he asked my mother out, she turned him down. He asked again. She gave him the same answer. But he kept coming back, week after week, until she finally saw his charm and maturity. That was how Lou Brizzi got his foot in the door of my mother's heart.

By the time Lou walked into a bar in West Paterson in 1984 to meet my mother, he was forty-three — he looked like De Niro — and had already lived a complicated life. He wanted to get the next chapter right. Mom was thirty-one, back from Mexico with two small boys and not much else, staying with her parents and taking whatever work she could find. She'd learned to be careful about who she let near her children. No charming man in a bar was going to be the exception. That's why she'd said no, and why his coming back meant he was looking for something longer than a night or two.

I was six the first time I met him. He came over to my grandparents' place, where we were living, when Nana and Grandpa invited him to dinner. Tootsie Rolls. That's all I remember about that night. Lou brought Chris and me Tootsie Rolls. A stranger walked into the house with something in his pocket for two boys who weren't even

his. This small act — treating us like we were already his own — won over our father-starved hearts.

I liked Lou. But Mom never knew how I'd stand at the window most nights watching the street, hoping Papa would come back.

It wasn't until much later that I learned the rest of Horacio's story. He'd hit a breaking point and gone back to Mexico because he couldn't carry his own life and ours at the same time. I've come to believe he left so we could have something he couldn't give us. That's the generous version. It's the one I keep.

Lou was no saint, and I won't pretend he was. He had a temper that showed up at the wrong moments, and he knew that about himself. Most of it wasn't even anger; it was how he processed things he didn't like, out loud and with heat. Once a mood had him, it was hard to pull him out of it. Then he could turn around and produce a warmth so unexpected it changed the temperature of a room. Some moments were hard. He was worth it.

Once he decided you were his, that settled it. Lou was there early mornings and late nights, school conferences, wrestling matches, hospital waiting rooms, and church basements. He never kept a ledger of it, and he never talked about sacrifice. He just lived it.

Lou's upbringing explained some of it. His father sold produce. When men in suits walked into his market, his father went out back to discuss things in private. When relatives came over from Italy, Lou was the boy who lost his bed to them and slept in the attic. He carried that longer than anybody knew. Years later, during a stretch when he was going to therapy, he recalled a family Christmas and an old man yelling at his uncle about a boy who had to sleep in the attic. The temper was the Italian kind you see in the movies. It was older than any of us, and it was never about us.

He had three kids before he was twenty-five. His first wife, Judy, was a couple of years younger and fighting postpartum depression in an era that had no name for it and no help. To avoid her moods, he

stayed out late some nights, partying. The marriage couldn't hold, and the kids spent most of their time with his mother, Mag.

"No excuses," he confided in me years later. "I wasn't the best dad. My kids deserved a better one than the one they got."

Then there was Mag, who babysat Chris and me when we were boys. I saw her as the goddess of comfort. Friendly's when she was watching us. TV together on the couch. Some nights she'd fry hamburgers in butter in a pan, and I can still taste them. Whenever I lobbied for White Castle, she waved off my suggestion — she didn't like driving on the highway, and that was that. "You telling me I can't make a better hamburger right here?" she'd ask in mock offense.

A die-hard Yankees fan, she passed that passion on to Lou. If the games weren't televised, she'd listen on the radio. When she got tired, she'd take the radio to bed and listen until she fell asleep.

Lou worked IT most of his life, a lot of it on the help desk, the guy you call when the thing won't work. He didn't stop until he was eighty-two. Never wealthy, Lou always angled for a second income to help pay the bills. For a while he had a booth at the Union Flea Market, called Lew's, a different spelling of his own name. I hated every Saturday I spent working it, but nobody asked. Left alone on Sundays, he watched his games: the Yankees in the summer, the Giants in the fall. That was the whole vice.

People asked Lou why he decided to take on somebody else's two boys. He never dressed up the answer.

"Have you seen their mother? She's drop-dead gorgeous. Beautiful and ten years younger than me. You do the math."

That was the honest start of it. The staying part he never explained.

Lou and Mom married at Pines Lake, in Wayne, New Jersey, where Aunt Terry's family lived, the same place the Halloween candy hit the kitchen floor. Around the time Lou came into our lives,

we left West Paterson for a house of our own in Woodridge. That was the home of my grade-school years, before Ramsey.

He adopted us when I was eight. The paperwork had taken years. International adoption in the eighties crawled and required everything in triplicate. Lou wasn't a patient man by nature, but he was patient in practice. He made the trips, sat in the offices, signed what they put in front of him, and waited for the next form.

When the time came to change our names, my mother told me Grandpa wanted to ask me something. We went down to the basement of the Woodridge house, surrounded by wood paneling, brown shag carpet, and the cool stale smell of basement air. Grandpa Bob sat me down and got to the point the way he always did.

"Change your first name to Robert," he said. "Rob. And I'll give you a hundred dollars."

I was eight. A hundred dollars was a fortune. I didn't even have to think about it.

"Okay," I said.

Then I asked him something he hadn't planned for.

"Can my middle name be Lou?"

Nobody had suggested it. I just wanted to carry it. That day Claudio Horacio Balderas became Robert Louis Brizzi. I had carried one father's name in the middle of mine my whole life. Now I would carry the other's. I've never once wished it back.

When I was six, Lou taught me to swim by carrying me to the edge of the pool and throwing me in. I came up coughing and furious, my arms going the way arms go when a body fights drowning. I reached the wall and pulled myself out. Lou stood there watching, not laughing, just paying attention the way a man does when he's handed his kid something he'll need. He didn't make a speech. I got back in the water the next time, and the time after that.

Some dads spend their weekends chasing hobbies like golf, manicuring their lawns, or sleeping on the couch. Not Lou. His

whole hobby was us. Saturday mornings at the batting cages in Woodridge, his hands on my shoulders fixing my stance, not because I was ever going to play ball but because he believed doing a thing right was a habit worth building. Soccer fields in the New Jersey cold, Lou on the sideline in a coat he didn't need to be wearing, watching me play a sport I was actually pretty good at. I took it all for granted, the way a child is supposed to do with childhood.

Lou and my mother decided early that Chris and I would be raised in church. It wasn't up for discussion. Sunday mornings, confirmation, and at thirteen I chose God and accepted Him into my heart. That part wasn't handed to me by the adults around me. It was mine — the first real decision I ever made for myself besides taking Lou as my middle name. My decision to follow Christ was real. I meant it. I'd lose the thread of it for a long time, the drinking years, California, the stretch when I was too busy performing life to remember what mine was built on. I left my faith, but it waited for me to return.

We moved to Ramsey when I was in sixth grade. Bigger house, new school, a town where the kids had known each other since before I showed up, and I came in as the new boy with dark olive skin and features that didn't match the rest of Bergen County.

At lunch I sat at the end of the table, in the back corner, trying to be invisible and still wanting to be let in. It wasn't long before they started in on me.

But I had Lou, who understood that a boy who comes home quiet in the wrong way doesn't need to be interrogated; he needs someone there. He couldn't fix school for me. He was just home when I got there, and that turned out to be enough.

The school paired me with a buddy to show me around those first weeks, a kid everybody called Whitey. We didn't get close then — that year I was mostly on my own. But by high school, Whitey had become one of my best friends, and all these years later, he still is.

When I got into Miami of Ohio, part of me hoped Whitey would land there too, an easy way to carry the friendship forward. He chose Bates College, up in Maine. I'd wanted a next chapter; what we got was a fork in the road.

And there was my neighbor Rich, a fellow member of the school's wrestling team. We were always into something together. In high school he turned himself into an overachiever at it — the way he was at everything he touched.

The year I left for college my mother told Lou she was done. He didn't take it well. He wanted the unit held together — that was the thing he had built, and he wasn't ready to watch it come apart.

My mother and Lou divorced in 1996, the year I turned eighteen. The divorce handed him an easy way out and every social permission to take it. We were grown, or close to it, and the marriage that had tied him to us was finished. He could have put the frustration and the guilt on Chris and me and gone. He never did. We were never in question, a plain fact he never bothered to announce: we were his, and that didn't come undone because the marriage had. The first time he chose us, it was a handful of Tootsie Rolls at my grandparents' dinner table. This time it was a divorce he could have walked away from clean, yet he stayed. The same decision, made twelve years apart.

I get it now. I didn't back then. For me, it started on a Saturday. With a bucket of baseballs.

CHAPTER 4 ## Chosen

*“I have called thee by thy name; thou art mine.” — Isaiah
43:1*

New Jersey, 1986

Overnight, I gained a big sister and two big brothers I hadn't even known to hope for. Lou had three children of his own long before he ever met my mother: Jon, Lisa, and Joel, thirteen to seventeen years older than me and grown or nearly grown by the time he met her. When he chose us, we inherited his existing family. Chris and I were thrilled. We felt blessed. His other children didn't have to accept us, though. They already had their own lives and never expected they'd need to make room for two boys from Mexico City who showed up attached to their father's new marriage. But they did. They treated us like brothers.

It could not have been easy for them. Their dad spent Saturdays hitting fly balls to me and driving me to every wrestling match. They hadn't grown up with an attentive, hands-on dad, so they had every reason to resent this new version of their father who seemed to be doing it all right. Instead of punishing me or Chris, they folded us in.

Lisa served as our babysitter when we were not the easiest to look after. She did it without making it out to be a sacrifice. She still hosts Thanksgiving every year, and keeps the table set the way our nana did. You'll meet her again later, at that table.

Joel treated us well from the start. Steady. He was there, and didn't need credit for it. Whatever Chris and I needed growing up, Joel jumped in to help. The jokester of the family, Joel's the class clown who never really grew out of it. And I hope he never does.

He's also the family's historian, the one who remembers all the stories about me, from when I spoke little English and my mom started dating Lou. He still tells them. There's the night at a Chinese restaurant when somebody asked what I wanted to eat and I said, with total confidence, "Taco." On the ferry from New Jersey to New York, the family car already rolling up the ramp onto the boat, and me asking hopefully whether we could put the car on the boat. All these years later Joel will still drop either one into a conversation just to watch me brace for it. That's its own kind of love, the teasing you only get once you're truly in.

Jon was already out of the house by the time Chris and I arrived, so he wasn't around much in those early years. He and I found each other later, through wrestling. He married Holly, her kids wrestled, I had wrestled, and that was the bridge. There is a shorthand between wrestling people. You don't have to explain the weight cuts, or the losing, or what it takes to walk back out for the next period. Jon understood it without my having to say it. He is also one of the quietest overachievers I know. He started out at Juniata College getting C's and finished as a partner at a major software company. More reserved than the rest of us, Jon is kind all the way through. His story rhymes with Chris's, the underdog who becomes the success. Lou's people don't stay down.

I remember the three of us driving down to Philadelphia for a Giants game once, all of us grown men by then. No occasion, just an excuse to be together. That was Lou's way, even beyond childhood: make a regular Sunday feel like it mattered.

The moment I felt closest to Jon came years later, both of us grown. He was successful by then, getting close to retirement. I was

up in New Jersey for a work training, and I took an hour-and-a-half Uber ride just to go see him. We ended up walking, the two of us, and he told me about a guy he'd mentored at his company, how grateful the man was for the chance, and what it had done for his whole family. The way Jon told it, the thing he was proud of wasn't the success. It was having been of use to somebody. That was a side of him I'd only seen in pieces. That day I got the whole of it.

That's the part that still gets me. Jon, Lisa, and Joel could have kept us at the edge of the family, at a small distance that never quite closes. They never drew that line. We were siblings. We still are.

We lived on Woodridge Street, and Domino's was our pizza. Back then they ran the promise: thirty minutes or it's free. What they didn't account for was that our town had a Woodridge Street and a Woodridge Avenue, and the driver went to the Avenue every single time. He'd turn up at our door late and apologizing, and he'd hand us the pizza and our money back. Free Domino's, over and over, because a guy couldn't tell a street from an avenue. Chris and I were sure we'd beaten the system.

Claudio and Rob

I wasn't given to Lou. I chose him.

It happened at night, when he was tucking me in. He'd pulled the blanket up to my chin the way he always did, his hand still resting on it, about to say goodnight. The room was dark except for the hall light coming through the cracked door. I'd been holding the question all day, and in the dark it finally came loose.

"Can I call you Dad?"

For a second he didn't say anything. Then I watched his eyes fill. I had never seen him tear up, not once. But there it was.

"Yes," he said. "Of course, son."

He didn't make a thing of it. He finished tucking me in the way he had every other night, except now I had a word for him I hadn't had a minute before.

Choosing one father didn't erase the other. A parent who loses a child can't set another one in the empty spot and call it even. It doesn't run the other way either. I had chosen Lou, and I meant it. But I still had room inside my heart with Horacio's name on the door.

For years I felt guilty about Horacio. I knew, the way a kid knows things without being told, what losing me had done to him. Some part of me decided it was my fault, as if I were the one who had done the leaving. I was four. Nothing about the decision to leave had been mine. The guilt didn't care. It stayed anyway.

When they changed my name, that one landed harder. Claudio became Robert Brizzi. On paper it was clean and it was right. I know that now. Back then it felt like a correction, like the old name had been a mistake somebody was fixing, and I was the mistake.

School was where I felt it the most. Second grade, Woodridge. I'd write Claudio at the top of my homework without thinking, my hand moving the way it always had, and Mrs. Locke would catch it. She was kind about it, every time.

"Honey," she'd say, setting the paper back on my desk, tapping the top corner with one finger. "Remember? We write Robert now."

I'd take my eraser and rub the name out until the paper went soft and gray, and print the new one in the bald spot I'd left. Robert. Then I'd hand it back, and she'd smile like we'd fixed something together. It didn't feel fixed. It felt like erasing me.

Years later, I went out for the football team. Trying out meant a physical, and the physical meant turning in a copy of my birth certificate. I hadn't looked at mine in years.

It was the end of summer. We were lined up waiting our turn, and I was still the shy one. The kid next to me reached over and took the paper out of my hand.

“Let me see that.”

He read it. Then he said the word out loud, printed plain for anyone standing close enough to hear. “Adopted.”

He had questions after that. “So you don’t have a real dad?”

“Yes, I do,” I said.

I went home wrecked and told my father.

He didn’t give me a speech. He got the white-out and painted over the word, let it dry, and ran a fresh photocopy, and the thing they’d been using on me was gone. He wasn’t hiding the truth — everyone who mattered already knew it. He was lifting a weight off a kid who wasn’t ready to carry it. That was how my parents handled the adoption all along. Not a secret. A shield. Somebody was hurting their son, and Lou fixed the part he could reach.

There was one thing they couldn’t change, and I held onto it. Brizzi still started with a B. When the teacher lined us up alphabetically, I landed near the front, right about where Balderas used to put me. My country was gone. My first father was gone. My name was gone. But I still stood in the same place in that line, and some mornings that one small thing was the only proof I had that any part of the old me had made the trip.

CHAPTER 5 ## The Man Who Raised Me

“Let us not love in word, neither in tongue; but in deed and in truth.” — 1 John 3:18

New Jersey, 1986–2000

I carried his name before I understood what was behind it. What Lou taught me about being a man came down to a few things, none of them speeches.

Don’t complain. Don’t play the victim. Show up.

He never sat me down and said those words. Instead, he lived them out loud in front of me every day until they became part of who I am.

Where I saw it most was the wrestling tournaments upstate. Dad drove me up into New York weekend after weekend, however far the bracket took us. He didn’t talk about the miles, the early start, or that he had worked the night before. He just got in the car, because his kid was wrestling and that was where he was supposed to be.

The drives were endless, even for me, and I wasn’t driving. Cooperstown. New York City. Albany, to see the Double-A Yankees. Lehigh, out in Pennsylvania. Philadelphia, where he took Jon and me to a Giants–Eagles game. Somebody in the rows below us had a sign: LT CHOOSES COKE OVER PEPSI. Lawrence Taylor was the best defensive player in football and by then everyone knew about the cocaine, so his addiction had become public sport. Lou went down and took the sign, and it almost started a fight. I was a kid; I

thought it was about football. It took me years to wonder whether it was about something else — whether some part of him just couldn't watch a stadium laugh at a man for the thing that was eating him.

When he coached baseball, the Foxes and the Falcons, he was harder on me than anyone else. He'd take me to the field where he would hit me a hundred balls, then a hundred more. At the batting cages, he fed the machine until my hands were raw from gripping the bat. He never let me quit because it hurt. *Stay in the box. Take the next pitch.* That was the lesson under the lesson.

Chris and Dad shared a phrase between them. After the big moments, like something at school, a hard-won wrestling match, or a new job, they would whisper to each other: *Hey Dad, we made it.*

I had my own version of that feeling in that car coming home from upstate, the quiet after a long day, the two of us, the feeling that we had done the thing together. And when he was proud of me, he rarely said so. He'd give me a small smile and a look. His expression said all of it.

He didn't connect with me only on the big things. One time I asked for White Castle, and the nearest one was an hour away. He drove me. An hour there for a sack of little burgers, because his kid had a taste for them. When I needed a root canal out at college in Ohio, he drove ten hours to take me to the dentist and ten hours back. A full day of driving, for a dentist's chair. In both pleasure and pain, Dad was there.

And once, it was far bigger than a tournament, a sack of burgers, or a dentist's chair. In college in Ohio I went down into something I couldn't explain, and he drove ten hours to sit across a table from me. He came the way he always had, except this time it wasn't for a game. He came because he loved me.

Somewhere on that drive, just the two of us in the car, I said it for the first time.

"Dad, thank you for saving my life."

“You saved mine.”

Neither of us said anything else. We would trade those same two lines maybe ten more times over the years. His answer never changed.

I broke down in front of him once. I don’t remember anymore what had pushed me there. I let him see me like that because I trusted him. He didn’t tell me to pull it together. He let me get it out, and then he looked at me and said it plain.

“I love you as much as I love my own kids.”

For as long as I could remember I’d carried a quiet question, whether I was really his, whether being chosen was the same as belonging. He answered it in one sentence. As much as his own. He didn’t soften it. I believed him.

PART TWO

THE MAT

Love came free at home. Everywhere else, I thought you had to win it.

CHAPTER 6 ## The Wrestler

“And Jacob was left alone; and there wrestled a man with him until the breaking of the day.” — Genesis 32:24

Before the mat, there was the lunch table. Sixth grade in Ramsey, and I was the new kid with the wrong name and dark skin in a town that had almost none of either. The classroom was one room, and the cafeteria was another, and the cafeteria I could not win.

There was a table I sat at every day, and the kids at it had a thing they said about me. “Brizzi beats off.” They’d say it and squirt mayonnaise across the table — their regular little performance — every day, for the rest of the table to laugh at. I didn’t even know what it meant. I knew it was about me. I knew it was filthy. And I knew the laughing was at me. That was enough.

Yet I kept sitting with them. That’s the part I sit with now. Every day they did it, and every day I carried my tray back to the same seat. I didn’t move tables. I didn’t eat alone. Getting picked on by them felt better than having no one, and in a town where friends didn’t come easy, that was the table. So I sat down and took it.

Kris and Kyle were twin brothers, the most popular kids in the grade, and they sat there too, and they never once joined in. They didn’t stop it. They just left me alone, and being left alone by the

popular kids was as close to safe as that room got. I remembered their names for thirty years. I never remembered the ones who did it.

It went on the rest of middle school. By the end the joke had moved into ink. Somebody wrote “have fun chokin’ the chicken” in my yearbook, the book you’re supposed to keep.

I crossed it out before my mom could see it. That is the part that tells you who I already was. She had carried two boys out of one country and built us a life in another with no degree and no one to catch her. I wasn’t going to hand her this too. So I took a pen to my own yearbook and scratched the line out, alone, so she would never have to feel it. I was fourteen. I didn’t have the word for it yet. I was already a caretaker.

I couldn’t fix the cafeteria. But there was one place in that town where nobody got to rank me, where there was no table and no lineup and no committee deciding what I was worth. One body against one body, and whatever I’d been handed, I got to settle it myself.

The first place I had to learn to show up for myself, with Lou watching from the stands, was a wrestling mat. I was twelve when wrestling first came up, and it came up between Charlie and my dad. The two of them talked it over before anybody said a word to me. It wasn’t a read on any talent. I didn’t have any. I was awkward, undersized, the kid picked somewhere in the middle in gym class, not last, which would’ve been a story, just middle. It was a hunch, the way people point a kid at something because nothing else has stuck.

Charlie was Aunt Nancey’s husband, and a room got lighter the moment he walked into it. He laughed easily. He looked at you, even when you were a kid, like what you were saying was the most interesting thing he’d heard all day. He loved my aunt, and she loved him. I talked to Nancey recently and she didn’t dress it up: there will never be another man like Charlie. She hasn’t dated in years.

Charlie was the one who came into our basement and taught us the beginning: stance, balance, top, bottom, how to keep moving when another person was trying to hold you down.

Before Charlie ever came over to make his case to Chris and me, my dad sat me down and asked if it was something I wanted to do. He didn't sign me up. He asked. Then he said, we'll try it, the way he said that about a lot of things, not with any heat, just the quiet of a man who figured most things give way to persistence. So I went.

While Charlie introduced us to wrestling, Lou made sure we stayed with it. Four nights a week he drove an hour each way to The Edge Wrestling Club so Chris and I could get extra practice. He never complained about the miles, the gas, or the late nights. He simply believed we were worth the investment.

Before any championships or newspaper headlines, he took me to the Bergen County Tournament. Forty-eight teams filled the gym, and he was thrilled when a Ramsey wrestler made it into the second round.

"Maybe someday you could win a match here," he told me.

That was Lou. He didn't make grand speeches. He showed his love in carpools, tournament weekends, church on Sundays, and thousands of hours sitting beside wrestling mats.

Years later, I returned to that same tournament and left as Bergen County champion.

The wrestling room ran warmer than the rest of the building. Years of work had soaked into the mats and the walls, and it hit me at the door, rubber and sweat and something dingy underneath. I loved that room. Not because it was comfortable. Because it was the one place I didn't have to figure out who to be. I just had to work, and work I understood.

Wrestling is the loneliest sport there is. Once you step on that mat, nobody can help you. No subs, no timeouts that matter. You, your opponent, six minutes, and whatever you brought with you that

week. If you hadn't put the work in, it showed. If you were afraid, it showed.

Practice was the same every day. Running first, then drills, shots, sprawls, stand-ups, until the moves lived below thinking. My legs knew when to change levels; my hands knew where to find a wrist. Then Coach called live and it was full speed. Drop into stance, knees bent, hands out, eyes between his shoulders and hips. The whistle, and we'd close, foreheads together, hands fighting for position, the work happening in adjustments too small to read from the bleachers. On the mat, you felt all of it, every shift of weight, every half-second of hesitation. You couldn't hide. Everywhere else I could build the version of myself the room wanted. Not there.

The mental game was the real opponent. Six minutes stretched forever while your lungs burned and your mind offered every excuse to quit. Fear rode right there with you, fear of getting taken down in front of everyone, fear of gassing out. The fear didn't go anywhere. I breathed, changed levels, kept my hands ready. When my body wanted to quit, I told it no. Stay. Fight the wrist. Explode up. The mat didn't care about my story or the questions inside me. It only cared that I kept showing up.

Making weight was its own war inside the bigger one. I dropped pounds fast, sweating in trash bags, spitting into cups, skipping meals, anything to hit the number. The scale ruled everything. Mornings I stepped on it with my heart in my throat, willing it down. Hunger gnawed at me all the time. My head went foggy, my temper short, my thoughts mean. One extra bite and I'd feel I had failed the team, failed myself, failed the work we all put in. Part of me was proud of the discipline. Part of me was ashamed of what I'd do to my body to prove I belonged. After weigh-ins the relief crashed in and I'd binge hard, then hate myself for it. Cutting weight taught me I could choose the harder thing. It also showed me a line I would cross years later with worse things than food.

My first varsity match, freshman year, didn't go how I'd planned. The whistle blew and the kid shot a double-leg before I'd finished setting my feet: dropped his level, got in under my hips, wrapped both my legs and locked his hands. There's no style to it. It just takes your legs out from under you. I saw it coming and couldn't stop it. He drove through me, my back hit the mat, and his weight came down across my chest. I heard the ref's hand slap the mat once. Then it was over. Nineteen seconds, start to finish.

I lay there for a second, looking up at the gym lights in the rafters, the crowd noise coming back in around me, something flat settling in my stomach. I got up. Shook his hand. Walked back to the corner. Lou was in the stands. He said nothing. He just held my eyes and gave me the smallest nod, the one that meant we would go back to work.

Lou was always in the stands. He almost never missed a match in four years of high school, not that nineteen-second one, not the close ones that went wrong, not the good ones once the work started showing. Third row, usually. Arms crossed, not in judgment, but in attention. Sometimes he'd have the camcorder up and running. Wrestling was the only thing he ever taped, the only reason he owned the thing. My mother and Aunt Nancey came too. Every match. And after every weigh-in, when I had starved myself down to the number for days, my mom was there with Wendy's chicken sandwiches, ready the second I made weight. She always seemed to know what a thing had cost me, and she always had the food waiting. That was how she loved me. She fed me.

Freshman year I finished two and four. That nineteen-second pin was one of the losses.

The victories came later, and they were never only about wrestling. Somewhere along the way I had learned that success was how I gained acceptance. If I kept winning, people would value me. If I stopped, I feared they might not.

For years I thought wrestling turned me into someone. Looking back, I see it taught me something dangerous. It made me think that winning was my identity.

Cooperstown

Cooperstown, New York, 1991

I was twelve. A quarter to eight on a Saturday morning, and Dad was in my doorway, already dressed, keys in his hand.

“You want to take a ride?”

“Where are we going?”

“It’s a surprise.”

I rubbed my eyes and said yes.

We got in the car and he drove. An hour in, I didn’t ask. Two hours in, I did.

“Dad. Where are we going?”

He looked over, smiling a little. “Cooperstown.”

It was five hours from our house, the Baseball Hall of Fame, and he kept driving like it was nothing.

We got there a little after one and walked up together. Inside it was dim and cool, glass cases everywhere, bats and gloves and jerseys worn by men I’d only ever seen on television. Dad walked me through it case by case, in no hurry. He stopped at a baseball.

“That’s a ball from Babe Ruth.”

We stood there a long time, both of us looking at it.

We got back in the car a little before five, and I was asleep before long. When I woke up we were home. Ten hours of driving for a building full of gloves and a ball Babe Ruth once touched. He never said why.

Dave Meyer

The projections had Dave Meyer at quarterback, until a kid named Michael Vick showed up.

But Dave's story began for me at church, the other place, besides wrestling, where Lou made sure Chris and I went. Lou believed boys needed structure. Church taught us who we were supposed to become. Wrestling taught us what it would cost.

That was where I met Dave.

Dave seemed to possess naturally what I was fighting to earn. He was confident, athletic, grounded in his faith, and accepted wherever he went. Yet he never made me prove I belonged beside him.

Junior prom was the first warning. Someone asked what I wanted to drink. I knew my parents drank Absolut Citron, so I answered confidently. "Don't mix it. Just bring the fifth."

Two hours later, I was throwing up in the limousine. Four hours later, my friends carried me into prom like *Weekend at Bernie's*.

The principal called my mother. I was suspended, and my first concern was whether I would remain captain of the wrestling team.

Even then, I cared more about protecting the image than understanding what had happened.

Dave's football plans eventually changed. His character did not. Mine was beginning to.

Dave went on to play in the NFL, then became a missionary in China, and years later we found our way back to each other. He's the one who wrote the afterword to this book.

CHAPTER 7 ## What the Mat Left

“And every man that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things.” — 1 Corinthians 9:25

Ramsey, New Jersey, 1993

Sophomore Year: The Turn

Freshman year I lost more than I won. Early sophomore season I drew the top seed in a tournament, a kid everyone knew would win, the kid I was supposed to be a warm-up for. Something happened I still can't fully explain. I wasn't afraid of him. The fear that had been the ground note of every match since that first pin just wasn't there. What was there was anger, not at him, at the idea that I was supposed to lose. I beat him. Ugly, grinding, the full three periods. But I won it. Afterward Lou didn't say much. A hand on my shoulder. In his language it meant: I always knew this was in you.

I won the District at 119 in 1994, seeded fifth of the eight in the bracket, expected to place nowhere near the top. The recognition came fast after that. One afternoon Mr. Molino pulled me out of class, and I walked down the hall sure I was in trouble, running through everything I might have done. Instead he told me I'd been named Athlete of the Month for Ramsey High School. They put my name on the billboard in front of the school for the whole month, where the entire town of Ramsey could read it. They painted it on the

wall in the old gym too, and I was the first sophomore they had ever done that for.

I couldn't take any of it in. The gap between who everyone suddenly said I was and who I knew myself to be was too wide to cross. The achievement was real. The sense that I had earned it wasn't there, and it wouldn't be for years. It would take a long time, and losing nearly everything, before I could stand in a room and believe I belonged in it.

Junior Year

Junior year I cut nineteen pounds the week of the tournament, then binged so hard after weigh-ins that I threw up twice on the mat during a match against a guy who had two wins over me. The ref stopped it. Greeny, Coach Greenshields, got a towel, cleaned me up, sent me back out. I won the match and the tournament — my second straight District title.

That season in Regions I drew a kid who almost never lost, a Bergen County name everyone knew, dominant and smart, the kind who wins because he rarely makes a mistake. Quarterfinals, he was the two seed, I was the seven. Six minutes. Ten seconds left, I was down 6–5. He let me up, experienced guys do that with a lead, sure they can ride it out on their feet. He shouldn't have. Three seconds on the clock, I shot a single-leg, dropped low and took his lead leg and pulled it tight to my chest, my arms there before my brain caught up. He was standing on one foot. His balance was gone. Takedown, 7–6, final. The paper the next day: "Late Takedown Keeps Ramsey's Brizzi Going."

I won my semi, lost a close one in the finals, still went to States. Finished 18–4. After that match Lou sat with me while I caught my breath and the bracket moved on without us.

"I'm proud of you, son."

He knew what it had taken to get there. He wasn't making it into anything bigger than it was; he was just enjoying it with me. I nodded. That was enough for both of us.

Charlie

I was in middle school when I got the news about Charlie. He and Nancey had separated and he'd drifted somewhere harder to reach. The disease had him, the same one that had Papa, and the same one that came for me a decade later, though I didn't know that yet. My dad was the one who went and got him, found him alone in his apartment the way you find someone who's stopped being able to take care of himself. Charlie died about four years after that. I never knew if he got sober in there. He felt sober to me when I saw him — but a kid reads what he wants to read, and to this day I can't tell you whether those last years were clean or whether the disease had just gone quiet.

I loved him, and that's hard to explain to people who think grief needs proximity. I hadn't talked to him in years. I was sixteen, buried in wrestling and school. But I'd loved him, and when he died something opened in me I didn't have a name for. Nobody validated it. He was the first person I loved who died. I'd lost Papa years before, but there was no funeral, nothing to stand in front of. Papa was gone and still alive somewhere. Charlie was gone.

What stays with me now: my dad was the one who went in. He walked into a room where someone he loved was losing, knowing it might not be enough. He went anyway.

Senior Year: County Champion

Senior year I won the District again, three straight years on that wall, and came into the Counties as the top seed at 130. My brother Chris was a freshman at 103. In the sauna, cutting weight together, we'd

said it would be something if we ever shared an article. Chris upset the number-one seed to make the semis. The paper ran it: “Ramsey’s Brizzi Brothers Are Double Trouble.” Dad was beaming.

I won the semis and the final 15–7, county champion at seventeen. My name on the wall again.

I hurt my ankle in Regions, wasn’t myself in the semis, lost. I wrestled through it for third, won that match, and advanced to States. I finished high school 81–18. From two wins and four losses as a freshman to a school record.

Chris is more than his records. He went 120–4, three county titles, two region titles, three district titles, placed at States three times, took second at freestyle nationals in Fargo. The kid the school wanted to hold back in third grade rewrote every record at Ramsey High I’d set. Every one.

The hazel-eyed baby my mother carried out of Mexico is silver-haired now, a father himself, the light skin and the easy grin still intact. He’s complicated. Smart. Polished and strategic, an over-achiever in the true sense. And still, the first thing anyone says about him is that he’s kind. Quietly, consistently kind. He’s my best friend. We took different paths and processed the same childhood differently, but there’s nobody I’d rather have call me on Christmas morning, nobody I’d rather have beside me at a graveside. Lou built us both, differently, and never compared us. He showed up for Chris’s records and my county title with the same pride.

The Lesson and the Exception

Coach Albersi met me before school to run the track. He invested in me. At the year-end gathering he said, Brizzi went down a legend. But when I was struggling, he wasn’t around much. When I excelled, everyone wanted to be attached to it.

Lou was the exception. Through all of it, the nineteen seconds, the weight cuts, the throwing up, the bad ankle, the losses that hurt more than the wins, he was there. Not because I was becoming a legend. Because I was his son.

One moment at the Counties: I was about to wrestle for the title and my Walkman got stolen. I needed it to warm up. Lou didn't lecture me. He drove to Best Buy and bought me a new one. Years later I said, "Dad, you always did whatever I asked." He paused the way he paused before something true. "Rob. There were times that was the last twenty dollars I had in my pocket. And I gave it to you." No resentment. Just a fact. I didn't know what to say. I still don't.

When I threw up in a match, he didn't see weakness. When I got pinned in nineteen seconds, he didn't see failure. He saw his kid. He was in the third row for all of it, and I never once asked what it had cost him to be there.

The Marks

The wrestling years left marks I still feel. For a long time my body didn't feel like my own. It was something to manage, a number to beat, proof I deserved my place. Food stayed complicated: some meals were cheat meals, others I ate lean. When life felt out of control, drop the pounds was still the first thought that came back. The same drive that cut nineteen pounds to make weight later went looking for other ways to numb everything. It took years to make peace with my body, and it wasn't discipline that got me there. It was my mother's quiet meals. Some days I still have to choose that peace on purpose. It gets easier every year.

CHAPTER 8 ## The Suit

*“Drudgery is the touchstone of character.” — Oswald
Chambers*

Ramsey, New Jersey, 1993

A recruiter looked at my father across a desk and told him to dye the gray out of his hair. Nobody would hire him otherwise. He went home and did it and never said a word about it. I understood the cost only later, when money got tight. By then he was in his early fifties, and we were living in Ramsey. I was in high school — old enough to notice tension, too young to know its price.

From the outside, our life looked stable. A house. Cars in the driveway. Dinner on the table, wrestling practice, the bills paid, the routine holding. I didn’t see how much of it was held up by him getting out of bed every morning.

He had a good job, meaning the lights stayed on, the mortgage got paid, and we had the things kids never stop to think about — shoes, gas, food, wrestling lessons. Then he got laid off.

Nobody sat me down and explained it. No family meeting, no speech, no panic I can remember. That wasn’t him. But I felt it. The house got quieter. My mother’s voice got softer. Adults paused half a second too long before answering simple questions. My dad got more focused, not less. Deliberate. Like a switch had been thrown and every move mattered now.

He'd taken on a family that didn't start with him. A wife who waited tables. Two boys who weren't his by blood. Endless bills. He never acted like any of it was somebody else's problem. He owned all of it.

The recruiter had put it to him straight, the way you tell a man something for his own good. You want a real shot, he said, you've got to dye the gray. They're going to look at you and see an old man. A grown man, a husband, a father, told he had to look younger than his years to be deemed worthy of a chance. That detail has never left me.

Every day he put on a suit. Every single day, even when there was no interview on the calendar, nowhere definite to go. He shaved, tied the tie, polished his shoes, and walked out the door like a man with somewhere to be. He treated looking for work as work.

I don't know how many interviews there were. In my memory it felt endless — double digits at least. Enough that rejection could have turned personal. Enough that another man might have come home bitter, or loud, or ashamed. He never did. The mortgage still came due. So did the credit cards. But he never made us feel like we were too expensive to raise. Wrestling lessons never felt selfish. We never felt guilty for needing rides, or food, or hope.

They told him no, and the next morning he knotted the tie again. He wasn't loud about what he carried. He carried it. Eventually, he found work. No one could keep a man like Lou down.

I can still see him at the front door. Dyed hair, pressed shirt, tie pulled tight, shoes shined. That's what he did while he waited. He kept showing up.

CHAPTER 9 ## They'll Teach You

*“A good name is rather to be chosen than great riches.” —
Proverbs 22:1*

New York, summer 1997

The summer I was nineteen, between semesters at Miami and working construction, my dad called and said he got me a job. Auditing. I said, auditing? Dad, I haven't taken an accounting class yet. He said, they'll teach you.

I won't use the name of the guy who hired me. Very Italian name, one of those guys with a nickname like Mickey Marbles or Paulie the Piece. Bad toupee, drove a Buick. The office wasn't an office, it was a back room with one other person in it, an Italian girl named Felicia. He told me I'd be driving the five boroughs auditing the books for a trade union. Nineteen years old, fake glasses, a suit that didn't quite fit, about to walk into union offices in Harlem, Brooklyn, and Manhattan pretending to know what I was looking at.

First they sent me out with a guy named Sal to train me. Everywhere we went, people knew him. Hey Sal, what's up Sal, big handshakes, big smiles. Three days of that, and in three days Sal didn't teach me one thing. Not what to look for, not what auditing even meant, not a single page. Then he told me he had to get out of the area. His exact words. I was nineteen. I didn't know what that meant. I still don't. But Sal was gone, and now it was just me.

They'd sit me down with these giant ledgers and I'd flip pages like I knew what I was doing. They were always nice about it. You want coffee, cake, donuts? I'd say no, flip pages for an hour, leave.

After a few weeks the boss called and said I was leaving too early. I said, I don't know what I'm doing, I don't know what I'm looking at. He said — I'll never forget it — it doesn't matter, I get paid by the hour, just sit in there and punch numbers into the calculator. That's when it landed. Whatever this was, it wasn't accounting. I left him a note and went back to construction. Didn't even quit in person.

That job came out of my dad's world — a conversation at a bar in Mahwah, a handshake, a phone call. He had no idea what the job actually was. Neither did I, until I was inside it: his nineteen-year-old son on somebody's payroll, driving the five boroughs in fake glasses, pretending to audit books nobody wanted audited.

After the divorce, he lived in Mahwah. He'd go out, have a drink, talk to people. He could sit next to a stranger and walk out with a new friend and a business opportunity. Not scheming. Just how he worked.

That was the world I grew up in. Dad knew everybody, and in a deeper way than people who meet at networking events. He actually did — the people you'd expect and the ones you wouldn't. His world had more layers than I understood as a kid. Lou didn't explain himself. He just lived it, and every so often you'd catch a glimpse and think: who is my father?

When I was about seven he took me to visit friends of his somewhere in Jersey. Nice house. Long hair, laid-back, growing what they called funny tobacco out back. Inside, one of them stood at the wall polishing something — a round flat thing in a frame — working a cloth over it slow and careful, proud of it. I just knew it was shiny and gold.

Home that night, my mom asked how it went. I told her about the nice guys shining their gold records.

She stopped what she was doing and looked at me. “You know who that is, right?”

I shook my head.

“That’s the Rascals.” When that didn’t land, she tried again. “You know ‘It’s a Beautiful Morning’? ‘Groovin’?”

I had no idea. I was seven. They were my dad’s friends with shiny things on the wall.

But that was Lou. The Rascals — Rock and Roll Hall of Famers, one of the biggest bands of the sixties — were his buddies. They came to his eightieth birthday.

Years later we’re at my sister Lisa’s place in Sarasota, walking into breakfast at Another Broken Egg, and my dad spots a guy outside. His face lights up. Dickie V! The guy turns, and it’s Dick Vitale — the actual Dick Vitale. They’d gone to high school together in Jersey, and my dad had been telling me about it for years. Me and Dickie V. I’d nod the way you nod at a man who also swore the lawn was being handled by a goat. Then one morning there’s Dickie V himself, turning around at the sound of my father’s voice and lighting up right back at him.

That was Lou. He could not help mentioning the people he knew — the Rascals, Dickie V, a guy from the union hall — all in the same breath and the same easy tone. It should have been insufferable. It wasn’t, and the reason is simple: every name was true. He never inflated a thing, and that was the funny part. He’d really been there for all of it, and he name-dropped the way a kid spreads out his baseball cards — not to impress you, just tickled you were finally looking.

There’s one story I only heard a couple of years ago, from someone close to the family I won’t name. He was a teenager then, and my dad used to put odd jobs his way, errands, cash in his pocket.

One day an acquaintance of my dad's pulled up outside his house and told him to get in the car. A kid at school had been picking on the man's daughter, calling her fat. He drove him there and told him to handle it. The kid found the boy, told him to stop, got mouthed off at, and dropped him with one punch. Told him he'd better apologize, or he'd be back tomorrow and it would be worse. The boy apologized. A few days later the man came back with a tailor, took measurements right there in the driveway, and within the week five custom suits showed up at the door. No invoice, no explanation. You did somebody a favor, and a tailor showed up at your house.

My dad didn't live that life. He lived next to it. Close enough to know the rules, close enough to know when to say something and when to keep his mouth shut. As a kid I just thought my dad knew a lot of interesting people. He did. Some of them were more interesting than a seven-year-old needed to know about.

The Most Interesting Man in the World

If you only knew the gold records and the union halls, you'd miss the half of him I loved most — the one at home, running little cons on his own kid for the pleasure of it. He looked like Robert De Niro, my dad. Same build, same face, the man central casting sends over when the part calls for somebody you don't want to cross. Then he'd open his mouth and tell you the grass was being handled by a goat.

He had lines, and he didn't know they were lines. He'd bring home bagels, and you'd say, Dad, these are the best bagels I've ever had. And he'd look at you, dead serious: what's a matta you, you don't like 'em? You couldn't win, and that was the point. He could turn a compliment into a bit without cracking a smile. My friends and I still say it. What's a matta you, you don't like it? What's a matta you, you do? We say it to each other and we know exactly where it came from. That's the thing about a man like Lou. He leaves

you his lines, and you keep saying them, and a little of him keeps showing up in your kitchen years after he's gone.

The same mouth had no filter when he'd decided something was true. A friend of my mother's married a much older man, and Lou told her, to her face, that she had father issues. Nobody had asked.

He met Donna, the woman he would marry after the divorce, with one line too. A bar and restaurant in New Jersey, Lou sitting by himself. Donna and her friends went over to grab a chair from his table, and she asked him, is anyone sitting there? "You are," he said with his winning smile. That was their whole courtship, right there in two words. He could end a joke with a straight face and start a marriage the same way. They remained together nearly twenty-five years.

Some afternoons he'd tape a Yankee game that had already played, then put it on for me like it was live. Rickey Henderson's gonna hit a home run here, he'd say. And Henderson would go deep. I was a little kid. I thought my father could see the future. He let me believe it for years before he told me he'd already watched the whole thing.

He got a goat. Somebody was hauling it off to the slaughterhouse, and my dad told him that if he was going to kill it, he'd take it. No discussion, no warning. One day there was a goat back there eating the grass. The man cut fifty lawns a week for a living, and his own backyard was being handled by an animal he'd talked somebody out of killing.

And everything was a surprise. "What are we watching, Dad?" It's a surprise. Where are we going? It's a surprise. It was usually Clint Eastwood on the screen. He loved Eastwood — the squint, the quiet, the man who didn't say much and didn't have to. That was Lou's hero, and a fair description of Lou himself. He got more joy out of the not-telling than the telling.

My brother and I called him the most interesting man in the world. It started as a joke, the guy from the Dos Equis commercials. Stay thirsty, my friends. Then we realized we weren't joking. He really was. Not for the people he knew, but for who he'd be in a kitchen on an ordinary night, keeping a straight face, waiting for you to fall for it.

CHAPTER 10 ## Oxford

“The LORD is nigh unto them that are of a broken heart.” —

Psalm 34:18

Oxford, Ohio, 1996–2000

Lou’s world had made me. Then it sent me off to build one of my own.

The first time I saw it, my dad drove me out for a wrestling visit. We came off the highway and the world turned to corn — stalks in every direction, mile after flat mile, the kind of empty a Jersey kid has no category for. It looked like we’d taken a wrong turn into Iowa. Where are we even going, I kept thinking, out here in the middle of nowhere. Then the fields gave way and there it was: red brick and old trees, one of the most beautiful campuses I’d ever seen, set down in the middle of all that farmland.

Before I ever set foot on campus, there was a party in New Jersey. Tricia Hart hosted it, a mixer for kids heading to Miami that fall. That night I met Dean Ferrera from Hawthorne and people who’d matter for years. I liked going to a school in Ohio, already knowing a few faces. Dean became one of my best friends.

My mom and dad dropped me off in the fall of 1996. Partial wrestling scholarship, financial aid, Lou covering the rest. That was how it got paid for. My mom cried when she left me there. The woman who had moved two kids across a border without flinching stood in a dorm parking lot in Ohio and couldn’t stop the tears. I

didn't feel like I'd chosen Miami so much as it had chosen me first — a letter from a coach with my name on it. Later I saw it in *Newsweek*, "best schools for your money," number four. The Ivy of the Midwest.

My dorm was Stanton Hall, my roommate a good-natured Packers fan from Wisconsin with a cheesehead on his shelf and the accent to prove it. I didn't know what a cheesehead was. I'm from New Jersey. Next door was Jason Huet, six-five, a high school basketball player who'd wanted Chapel Hill and was sore his parents made him come to Miami. Hard shell, didn't let everybody in, but once he did, he didn't take it lightly. He teased me constantly — swore he couldn't understand a word I said. He texted recently: you want to come see me for Memorial Day? That's a friendship that just holds. The twins from Ramsey were there too, Kris and Kyle, the two who'd kept their hands clean at the lunch table. They became good friends too.

That was the version of me I cultivated at Miami. Not Claudio. Rob — county wrestling champion, Miami student, American. Nobody here knew who I'd been before I arrived. Being the darker-skinned kid on a mostly white-bread campus gave me something, and I connected in ways that hadn't come as easily in high school.

The wrestling room was in the Athletic Center, a building that smelled like liniment and decades of somebody's suffering. Chuck Angelo rarely raised his voice. He didn't need to. The expectation lived in the silence.

College wrestling isn't high school wrestling scaled up. It's a different sport under similar rules. The men I faced had been doing this since before I could read English, and they had the cheerful brutality of experienced guys who enjoy working on beginners. I got thrown. A lot. Practice was 6 a.m. and 4 p.m. You cut weight. You drilled until the moves stopped needing thought. I wasn't the most

talented wrestler on the team. What I had was what I always had: I showed up, and when it got hard, I showed up harder.

Sophomore year the program got cut. Title IX. No discussion, no warning, just over. I'd like to say I was devastated — better story. What I felt was relief, the clean kind. For the first time since I was twelve, no scoreboard, no coach, no bracket. Just time.

So I had to figure out what I was doing there. I transferred into the Richard T. Farmer School of Business and declared marketing. Why marketing? Because I was bad at everything else and I could talk. People ask why I went into sales and that's the answer.

Kappa Sigma did something I didn't expect. After the standard rush, they came back for me. Not a form letter — a specific ask. I knew the feeling. The thin envelope from the coach. Lou walking into my mother's life and not leaving. I joined. For the first time I wasn't the wrestler. I was just Rob, still working out what that meant.

I was still my mother's kid underneath it. One Sunday I ended up at a church across the Indiana line, driven there at a hundred miles an hour by a man who read scripture off the steering wheel and then stood up front yelling at us like John the Baptist.

I drank. Everybody drank; that was the cover. It would be years before I understood that not everyone drank the way I did. I won't glamorize it, but the parties were great — the fun you know won't last, which is part of why it mattered. Junior year I lived in the fraternity house. Underneath it all was an insecurity I couldn't shake. The wrestling, the fraternity, the friends, and still some part of me didn't believe any of it was real.

This is the part I've never told, and without it the rest is just a list of wreckage. It was a love story. The longest, most consuming affair of my life was the one I had with my addiction. It was the kind of love that made me feel like I didn't need anyone else, and that was

the cruelest trick in it. It filled the space other people were meant to fill, and for a long time I didn't even notice they were gone.

It started at a bar in Oxford, in 1999. Justin held one out and asked if I wanted one. No, I said. I don't do drugs. It's a prescription, he said. Oh. Okay. That was the whole negotiation — the entire distance between the man I was and the man I'd become was one word, prescription, and one shrug.

The first time I took an Adderall and put alcohol on top of it, something in me went quiet that had never been quiet before. I was free of the inhibition I'd carried since I was the dark-skinned kid who didn't match the rest of the room. I was articulate without reaching for it. I was funny without trying to be funny. The part of me that stood outside every conversation, watching, grading how I was doing, finally sat down. I wasn't performing being Rob. I just was him, the version I'd always believed was in there and could never reach.

That's what nobody warns you about the beginning: it works. That first night I felt precisely how I'd always wanted to feel. And once you've felt that, once the noise stops and you meet the man you thought you were supposed to be, you'll do almost anything to get back to him.

But the freedom only came in the pills and the alcohol. The cost hid inside the gift. Without them, I felt naked. Not shy. Naked. Like I'd been dressed my whole life in borrowed confidence and now everyone could see there was nothing underneath. The inhibition came back the moment the chemicals wore off, and it came back worse, because now I knew exactly what I was missing. So I stopped letting them wear off. The thing that let me be myself was the thing I could no longer be myself without.

It split me in two. When it was good, I felt invincible, untouchable, the sharpest and funniest man in any room, certain the feeling would last forever. I could walk into a bar feeling four feet tall, and

three drinks later I'd be on the couch dancing, kissing a girl, and some sober sliver of me would watch it happen and wonder how the same person could do both. When it was bad, I was a stick of dynamite waiting to explode. The middle disappeared. The same thing that made me a god by midnight left me a live wire by morning, and the people who loved me never knew which one would walk through the door.

Someone told me once about a line in the sand at the ocean. You draw it and tell yourself, I will never go past this. Then the water comes in and washes the line away, and you draw a new one a little farther back, and you tell yourself the same thing, and mean it the same amount. That was my whole life in addiction. "This far, never farther." Then the tide came in. I kept redrawing the line farther up the beach until there was no beach left, until I didn't recognize the man standing where the line used to be.

Everything that came after, the DUIs, the balcony, my mother's money turning into pills, a floor in Tijuana, was me chasing one feeling from one night. Not the high. The relief. I wasn't trying to escape myself. I was trying to get back to the only version of myself I was ever comfortable inside.

I have never been as committed to anything in my life as I was to using. It trumped the district titles, the county championship I won at seventeen, the career, MTV, the Abercrombie shoots, every accolade I ever collected trying to prove I was somebody. It beat out the people I loved. It got a devotion out of me that nothing else ever came close to, and it took everything in return.

I understand addiction now in a way I can finally explain. It doesn't mean you're using all the time. It means you want to use all the time. You can't wait for the next pill, the next drink, and some part of you is already counting down to it no matter how good the day is going.

Getting sober was not relief. It was grief. Learning to stop using meant giving up my best friend — the one who was always there when I felt four feet tall, the one who never left until it had taken everything from me. I had to mourn it. You can grieve the thing that was killing you. I did, and some days I still do.

And I won't tell you it's gone. I still carry the pattern. The substance left; the wiring didn't. These days I'm addicted to more — more work, more winning, more of whatever will fill the same hole. Recovery, for me, isn't the pattern disappearing. It's knowing it by name, and choosing every day not to feed it the one thing that almost killed me.

And some days sobriety feels like that same nakedness I used to run from. No clothing, no armor, every nerve exposed to the air. The difference now is that I stay in it. I let myself be seen with nothing on, and I don't reach for something to take the edge off.

Jason still tells one on me. We ran a case race one night — you pair off, a case of beer to a team, and whoever puts theirs down first wins. I hated losing at anything, and a case of beer was no exception. Somebody had a camera going when it caught up with me afterward: me on the bathroom floor, sick as a dog, looking up at the lens and saying, this is what I do to win. It got a big laugh. It should have gotten a second look. I could turn getting sick on a tile floor into something I'd won. They say there are always signs. That was one I wasn't ready to read.

I fell into a depression that nothing had caused. Nothing had happened to me. Everything went gray. I called my mother and she went looking for the reason — what happened, was it a girl. It wasn't a girl. I still can't explain it.

Then I called Lou. He heard it in my voice. He didn't ask follow-up questions. He said, how about I take a ride there tomorrow.

New Jersey to Ohio, ten hours, no call ahead to confirm I needed him. He took me to a doctor, got me seen, then to a chain restaurant.

Laminated menus, free refills, nothing to it but food and a booth and him across from me.

On the way out, a waitress ran into the parking lot after us and handed me her phone number. I looked at Lou. He kept walking, eyes straight ahead. I asked if he'd said something, left a big tip, set the whole thing up. He denied it flat. Didn't miss a beat. I never believed him. He took it to the grave. That might be my favorite thing about him.

CHAPTER 11 ## MTV

“All is vanity and vexation of spirit.” — Ecclesiastes 1:14

Cancun, spring 1999

I still don’t entirely know how MTV ended up putting my face on national television. Junior year Dave Nesser, a college buddy, said we were going to Cancun for spring break. Three hundred people from Miami. MTV. The beach. Ten days at the center of the known universe. A scout stopped me with a Polaroid, took my picture, said stay near your phone. That night the hotel phone rang. Dave answered, then handed it to me with a look I’d never seen on his face. It’s MTV.

The lineup was NSYNC, 98 Degrees, Busta Rhymes, Eminem, and for ten days I carried the same VIP pass they did.

The show aired eight times a day for three months. Back in Oxford, cars slowed, people pointed, strangers at parties turned toward us with a warmth I hadn’t been on the receiving end of before. I got the reach of it through Chris: a girl in his high school was watching one night, called him over, said, “There’s someone on here who looks exactly like your brother.” “That is my brother!” Chris confirmed. She looked at the screen, looked at Chris, and said, “Yeah, right!”

Senior year I lived with Dave Nesser, Dean Ferrera, and Jason Huet in a condo downtown. We were absolute pigs, and we des-

troyed that place. Graduation was coming and we were all about to scatter.

That feeling, the one that hadn't come after the county championship, or the wrestling room, or Kappa Sig, came in Cancun, ten feet from Timberlake with cameras pointed my way. I'd finally found the feeling. From then on I knew exactly what I was chasing.

Lou could have sent me to community college, a local school, a hundred cheaper options. Instead he let me go to Miami and took out loans to do it. He was splitting a rental house in Mahwah with his friend Roger, who'd been through a divorce of his own, and Lou's room was the small one upstairs. Chris and I would visit and you could read it in his body when things were weighing on him. He never put it on us. He carried it, quietly, the way he carried everything.

He worked two jobs in those years, and one of them was at a garden center, planting trees, a man in his fifties down on his knees in the dirt. And I was selfish with it. I'd call him for more money, not for books or rent but for drinking and going out, and he sent it every time. I didn't think twice about where it came from or what it cost him. It was the first time in my life I'd felt accepted by people my own age, and next to that, nothing else registered.

If he was in pain he wouldn't use the word.

The man who made it possible was sharing a rental in Mahwah, paying back loans for years, never once making the cost feel like something I owed him. I graduated in May 2000, Lou and my mom in the crowd, tracking the sea of identical caps until they found mine. I pointed my car west. California beckoned.

PART THREE

THE FALL

Everything I'd built was borrowed. This is what the repo man looks like.

CHAPTER 12

The Performance Trap

“Selfishness — self-centeredness! That, we think, is the root of our troubles.” — Bill Wilson, Alcoholics Anonymous

San Diego, 2002–2006

My friend Angela called from Chicago. You're not going to believe this, she said. I'm standing in the Abercrombie & Fitch on Michigan Avenue, I looked up at the screen, and there you are. Your commercial. For about a minute, it felt like arriving. Then the feeling passed, and the hunger underneath was still there.

After Oxford, I drove straight at the only thing I knew how to do: win. My first real job was managing an Abercrombie & Fitch in San Diego. I brought the same speed I had taken into weight cuts and 6 a.m. practices. I outworked everyone, learned the inventory cold, found problems before anyone asked me to. Put up a scoreboard and I wanted my name at the top.

Nesser filmed a bio of me wakeboarding in Islamorada, Florida. The tape brought an A&F talent scout to the store, and I got picked for Abercrombie & Fitch TV, the in-store channel playing across the country. That was the commercial Angela had seen. The kid from

Mexico City who had needed speech therapy for a lisp was now on a loop in one of the biggest retail brands in America.

The hunger stayed. I transferred to the highest-grossing Abercrombie in the country, in Newport Beach. Then came sales. Then medical devices. By twenty-four, I was clearing six figures.

The Fraud Feeling

The screen couldn't show what was underneath. I walked into every room certain everyone else was the real thing and I was the only fake. They belonged. I was getting away with something. I spent more energy guarding that secret than living my life.

The secret was older than California. It went back to a four-year-old carried out of one country and set down in another — the new name at the top of my homework, the dark skin that didn't match the other kids, the lisp they sent me to therapy to fix. Somewhere along the way I reached a conclusion I couldn't yet name: this part of me is not welcome here. Claudio went quiet.

People sometimes ask why the disease took me and not Chris. I've asked it too. Same blood, same two fathers, same kitchen. Chris left Mexico at a year and a half. I was four. I had a papa who raced me to the corner and called me his good luck charm, and then I didn't. Chris grew up with one father. I grew up with one father and one ghost.

I built a character in that empty space, and I built him well. Smoother. Funnier. More needed. The hard part is that it worked. People responded to him. Every time they did, the real one underneath got quieter.

Then it stacked — performance on performance, year after year — until I forgot there was anyone underneath the costume.

Sales

I took a sales job in 2002. For a while it felt like proof California hadn't broken me. The salary was fifty thousand dollars, and at twenty-three it felt like solid ground for the first time in years.

The job was selling uniform services to businesses: cold calls, presentations, lunches in parking lots while I ran the next hour in my head. The quota was real. Your manager knew your numbers before breakfast. I loved the structure — clear rules, clear targets, a scoreboard that updated every day. Lou had raised me in that language: do the work and let the result speak.

For the first six months I wasn't using. I called Lou on Sundays and gave him the numbers. He never sounded as impressed as I wanted him to. You doing okay out there? he'd ask. I'm doing great, Dad. Making more than I ever thought I would. That's good, he'd say. But are you happy? Happy felt like the wrong question. I was successful. I was winning. I told myself those were the same thing.

Started Using

The pills came slowly. There was no single decision, just a long week, a rough stretch of no's, a body tired of being on all day and a brain that didn't know how to shut off at night. Once I started, I didn't stop.

I already knew the feeling. I had met it in Oxford in 1999 and spent the years since telling myself that was college. San Diego was different because I stopped waiting for the feeling to find me. Now there was a bottle, a reason, and a workday attached. The part of me always checking the room, always reading faces to know who to be, could be switched off on schedule. That was the change: not discovering the drug, but deciding to live there.

The pills were Adderall and Ritalin. Before a workday, I told myself they were practical. The noise went quiet. The static of self-

doubt dropped a few decibels. I could hear the customer instead of pretending to listen while rehearsing my next line. I closed deals. I walked into rooms that scared me and stopped feeling scared. My numbers went up.

That was the trap. The pills didn't just feel good; they made me better at the thing I most needed to be good at, with money attached. I didn't see it as using. I saw it as competing.

By then I had my own prescription in California. Easy access didn't satisfy the chase; it amplified it. The arithmetic was simple: more to get the same effect, then more again. When California ran dry, I crossed into Tijuana to resupply. One of those runs ended on the concrete floor where this book began. I crossed again the next day. Six figures a year, crossing a border for pills because the machine I had built couldn't run without fuel.

Alcohol came alongside it. Pills to ramp up, drinks to come down. I wasn't a two-beer, loosen-up drinker. I blacked out. Four nights a week, I'd wake up piecing the night together from other people's faces. Outside, the confidence read as arrogance. Inside, I was still the scared kid trying to prove he belonged.

The Wreckage

By then, the thing I was feeding had swallowed most of me. I lied with my own face. I hurt people who loved me and still found ways to explain it away.

There's one moment from California I can't shake. On a work-day, I went to see a fortune teller. I don't even believe in them. She looked at me and said my mother cried herself to sleep worrying about me and my father was sick with concern. I sat there stunned. How could she know? Maybe it was written plainly enough on me for a stranger to read.

Because it was true. While I chased a feeling, the people who loved me lay awake. My mother. Nancey. Lou. Chris. I lied to them. Manipulated them. Stole. I turned their trust into fuel and left them carrying a wreckage I barely looked back at.

Some of it I would make right later. Some of it I still carry.

The First DUI

The first DUI came in 2002, and it should have stopped me. I was driving toward San Diego to see an ex-girlfriend I wasn't even in love with, holding on because letting go felt like defeat. I had been drinking. I was exhausted, strung out from work, running on momentum.

I got so tired I pulled onto the shoulder near Camp Pendleton and fell asleep with the car running. Military police found me and called the cops. I tried the old pennies-in-the-mouth trick. It doesn't work.

I woke up in handcuffs. The car was impounded. I spent the night in jail.

The next morning I called my boss from a payphone, my hands still shaking. I'm going to lose my job, I said. Bravo — that was my nickname at work — I don't know yet, he said. I'm not sure. I started sobbing into the receiver. I had built everything on sand.

He kept me. A good attorney and ten thousand dollars got the DUI pled down to a wet reckless, with one condition: another DUI within ten years and the wet reckless would count as the first. The next arrest would be treated as my second. I should have heard the warning. Instead, I kept going.

The Second DUI

Four years sat between the arrests, and on paper they were the best four years of my life: rankings, president's clubs, money, my face on

screens across the country. I needed ten clean years for the wet reckless to stay a wet reckless. I gave it four.

The second DUI came in 2006, inside the ten-year window. The plan was to sleep on a friend's couch after a night out in Newport Beach and drive home sober in the morning. That was the deal I made before the first drink. But the man who makes the plan isn't always the man who reaches last call. The one who was left got hungry and got in the car.

At Del Taco, the line wasn't moving. I threw the car in reverse and backed into the car behind me — a real hit, metal on metal — then drove away. I made it to a 7-Eleven in Costa Mesa and sat in the dark eating nachos from a plastic tray. That's the picture I keep: a man with a career and a face on screens across the country, alone in a parking lot at almost two in the morning, eating nachos after a hit-and-run.

The lights came on after I pulled out, swerving. The officer knew nothing about Del Taco. I was simply driving that badly. During the field sobriety test, fear got ahead of the arrest. I can't get a second DUI, I told him. I'll lose my license. I'll lose my job. Please. He had heard versions of that speech before. It changed nothing.

When the cuffs went on, I folded forward in the back seat. No fight left. I thought about my mother and Lou — the adoption, the bleachers, the money he didn't have — and watched the life they had helped build start disappearing in a parking lot.

They held me until I was sober enough to leave. There was no pleading this one down. The ten years weren't up, so the wet reckless counted as my first DUI and this one was sentenced as my second. Eighteen months without a license. You can't do medical device sales from the passenger seat. The six figures, the trajectory, the identity — gone. I lied to my boss about why I couldn't drive and carried that lie into every call I still managed to make.

For years I told the story as a joke — the nachos, the parking lot, the absurdity. The joke was armor. The truth was two DUIs and a Tijuana jail in four years. That was the real scorecard.

The elevator was still going down.

CHAPTER 13

My Brother's Keeper

“Am I my brother’s keeper?” — Genesis 4:9

Correcting a man’s faults and telling him the truth about himself is the deepest compassion, and the first duty of anyone who serves him. But he will only hear it from someone who has earned the right. — after Yamamoto Tsunetomo, Hagakure (c. 1716)

California, 2006

Chris is three years younger than me. He wrestled at the University of Pennsylvania and had always been one of the steadiest people in my life. By 2006, I was supposed to be the older brother, but somewhere along the way he had taken over that role without ever asking for it.

There was a night before detox when I stayed at Chris’s place and I was pretty messed up. I came out of the shower too fast and ran straight into the glass bathroom door, shattering the whole thing. I stood there looking at the mess, expecting a reaction. Chris looked at it and said, “Oh, that happens.” That was the kind of grace he gave me during those years.

The detox in Anaheim was not something I chose because I had finally accepted that I was an addict. I hadn't. In my mind, my career was ending because I had made a mistake. My driver's license was gone, I needed money, and the alternative to doing what the court required was prison. I remember being told that because I was taking Xanax, three days of detox were facility protocol before I could go to the rehab in Laguna Beach. My mom, my dad, and Chris were all involved in getting me there, but I don't remember who made which call.

Chris drove. He had a way of keeping things normal even when the situation was anything but normal. He put on regular music and drove while I leaned the passenger seat back and tried to sleep. I had a little flip phone then, so there was nothing to stare at or scroll through. Mostly I closed my eyes and tried to detach. I wasn't thinking about recovery or what the next year of my life might look like. I was getting through the drive.

The detox house was a small square place on a corner near a little cul-de-sac, ordinary enough that you could have passed it without noticing anything different about it. Chris pulled up close enough that he didn't really have to park. I got out with an Abercrombie & Fitch backpack that had my things in it, including the pills.

Inside, an intake kid went through the backpack while Chris sat there. He found the Flintstones vitamin bottle I had used to hide pills. The whole thing was humiliating, but humiliation was low on the list of what I could process by then. I was dealing with the loss of my license, the possible end of my career, coming off drugs, and the fact that I was sitting in detox because prison was the other option. I was mostly numb.

Chris did not make a scene. He didn't lecture me or turn the bottle into some bigger moment than it already was. He sat there and stayed calm, which was what he had been doing through a period of

my life when he had his own problems and very little room to express them because mine had become so large.

I remember Chris leaving and watching him pull away. I felt grateful for him, and I also remember thinking that nobody was going to have much sympathy for me for what I was about to go through. I had gotten myself there. There wasn't much more thought behind it than that.

The three days themselves are mostly a blur. I remember bunk beds and having the top bunk. The house felt crowded, maybe a dozen people in what seemed like a three-bedroom place. The other guys were polite. The staff treated me respectfully. We ate regular meals. Since I was coming off Xanax, they checked on me periodically because of the risk of seizures. I never had one.

I wasn't sitting there analyzing my addiction or thinking about what sobriety would mean. I was numb and trying to get by minute by minute. The pills wearing off were part of it, but there was also the life waiting for me when I got out — no license, a career I didn't know how to save, and a need to make money. I had no room for some bigger realization.

At some point in that stretch, after years of barely leaning on my faith at all, I remember saying to God, "Please, finish me off." It wasn't a polished prayer and I wasn't trying to understand what it meant. It was where I was.

CHAPTER 14

Checking Boxes

*“Man looketh on the outward appearance, but the LORD
looketh on the heart.” — 1 Samuel 16:7*

Pensacola, 2007

That’s when Lou stepped in. He and Donna had just bought a house in Pensacola and offered me a place to land. I knew what it was: a rescue mission disguised as a move. “Come down here,” he said. “Stay at home. Figure it out.”

I moved to Pensacola in 2007 with no active license, still drinking, still convinced I could outwork the damage. My mother drove my car from California because I couldn’t legally drive it myself. I let her. Before Lou and Donna arrived, I slept on the couch and chased job leads that disappeared the moment employers saw my driving record.

Florida gave me a loophole. The systems didn’t seem to talk to California, so I passed the test and walked out with a clean license. Laminated proof, I thought, that I had beaten the system. Same man, new license. One night I drove home drunk. At a red light, a cop sat on my left and another on my right. I held my breath until the light changed. They drove on. I didn’t get sober. I barely slowed down.

When Pensacola failed to become the fresh start I had promised myself, Aunt Nancey told me to come to Boca Raton. She had always shown up for me, and she did it again. She kept banana cream pie and chicken parm in the house because they were my favorites. For a stretch, I stopped drinking. The pills never stopped.

From the outside, I could almost pass for stable. I found some work. I sat on Nancey's couch at night. I told myself I was getting my feet under me. I had changed addresses, not direction.

Then I moved to West Palm Beach. I called it another fresh start. The drinking came back. I added cocaine. I almost stopped eating. My body started failing while I kept telling anyone who asked that I was fine. Boca was the last soft place. West Palm Beach was where the disease finally got me alone.

CHAPTER 15

West Palm Beach

*“His father saw him, and had compassion, and ran.” —
Luke 15:20*

West Palm Beach, November 2008

My father flew to West Palm Beach and rented a U-Haul to bring home a dead man. The dead man was me. I just hadn’t finished the job yet. Before I tell you about the morning he showed up, I have to show you the room he found.

The apartment was about six hundred and fifty square feet on a high floor in CityPlace, with a balcony over West Palm Beach. From up there, the city looked like something I belonged to. P.F. Chang’s and the Cheesecake Factory were downstairs. I almost never went to either. I almost never went anywhere.

The walls were covered in Post-it notes — ideas, plans, schemes, businesses I was going to start, money I was going to make. The whole next version of my life mapped in ballpoint on yellow squares. It wasn’t genius. It was a man who couldn’t finish a thought papering a room with the evidence.

I had stopped paying for things. Condo fees. Utilities. The power went off, so I ran an extension cord from the refrigerator to an outlet in the building hallway and stole electricity from the common area.

There were maybe two yogurts in the fridge. That was the food. What money came in went to pills. When it ran out, I shoplifted electronics and turned them into more.

My mother sent me money. She told herself it was for rent, food, getting back on my feet. I used it for drugs and alcohol. Some of it went to a strip club. I can barely stand to write that. The lie I told her was that I wasn't abusing my medication. The lie I lived was letting her believe her money was keeping her son fed.

She kept sending it. Hope can look a lot like enabling from the outside. From inside a mother, I think it looked like keeping her son alive.

I was down to about a hundred and forty-five pounds. I hadn't eaten in days. I wasn't drinking water. I wasn't sleeping in any way that counted. I had stopped looking in mirrors. I had stopped answering most calls.

By then I was doing things that made no sense even to me — writing checks to myself I knew would bounce, floating money I didn't have just to get through another night. One morning I came back to the apartment as the sun was rising and got down on my knees. I didn't pray for help. I asked God to end it. God, please, end this for me. I wanted to die. There was no plan, no method. I had nothing left even for that. I was on the floor at dawn asking to be let out of my own life.

Then Lou was at the door.

I don't remember deciding to tell Lou how bad it had gotten. Maybe Chris called him. Maybe my mother did. Maybe he simply knew. What I remember is opening the door and watching him take in the notes, the extension cord, the weight gone off me, the smell of a place where someone had stopped taking care of himself. No lecture. No what did you do to yourself. He looked around once and understood.

Then he said it the way he said things that weren't up for discussion: "We're gonna rent a truck in the morning and we're gonna take off."

A king-size memory-foam mattress on the floor was about the only real furniture I had left. Lou stayed beside it that night, a man in his sixties sleeping on the carpet of his son's wrecked apartment because he wasn't going to leave me alone.

By the time I woke up, he had already been out and back. A sesame bagel with butter and strawberry jelly sat waiting beside a glass of orange juice. My favorite. He had rented the U-Haul and found a man named Marcus to help us move. The two of them did most of the work while I moved slowly. We left almost nothing behind.

When we pulled out, a red cardinal landed on the U-Haul.

Lou saw it first. "Grandma's looking out for us," he said. He meant his mother, Mag. He said it lightly, as if that were simply how the world worked. I was too far down to make much of it.

I slept most of the drive. When I was awake, we talked baseball — the Yankees, who was hitting. He didn't bring up the pills. He didn't ask me to explain the apartment, the weight, or the cord in the hallway. That wasn't the job of that drive. The job was to get me out alive.

The U-Haul wasn't the turn. Lou got me back to Pensacola, and I kept using. The rescue didn't get me sober. It kept me alive.

CHAPTER 16

New Orleans

“Out of the belly of hell cried I, and thou heardest my voice.” — Jonah 2:2

New Orleans, Christmas 2008

There was a night I almost slept under a bridge.

The rescue had bought me time, and I used it to get worse. Christmas 2008, I went to New Orleans to spend the holiday with my mother.

Before I went out, she gave me maybe five hundred dollars. I told her I was going to have a good time.

I burned through all of it that night.

At some point I looked around and had no idea where I was. No idea how to get back to the hotel. No money for a cab. Nothing.

I kept walking until the neighborhood changed. Dark streets. Nobody around. The kind of place where, even drunk, you know you shouldn't be.

I found a bridge and thought, maybe I'll sleep here. Five hundred dollars gone in a few hours, and the underside of a bridge looked like my best option.

I tried to find a cab. Tried to talk somebody into a ride. Nothing worked.

So I ran. Back through the neighborhood, in the dark, sprinting until I saw something I recognized.

I made it back to the hotel around four or five in the morning.

My mother was awake. She looked at me and knew. My eyes gave me away. They always did.

“Something is very wrong with you,” she said.

I tried to brush it off. Change the subject. But she saw it. I could still lie with my mouth. My eyes had stopped lying for me.

The next two weeks were pure panic. Not fear of dying — fear of being caught. I moved through the days certain people were talking about me in rooms I wasn’t in. They were. My mother and Lou, divorced twelve years, were coordinating a rehab intervention because their son was dying and that outranked everything.

Then Chris called. I was on the couch at my dad’s house, the house the U-Haul had brought me back to. It started as an ordinary call — small talk, a lot of it, the way we always talked. He was calm. Somewhere in the small talk I got up and took the phone into the bedroom. Then, in the same even voice, he said it: “Admit you’re addicted to drugs, or admit you have a mental-health problem that needs treatment. Pick one. No third door.”

What I remember most is that I didn’t feel judged. My brother had just handed me the two hardest sentences of my life, and there wasn’t an ounce of verdict in either one. That’s what left me nowhere to stand. Anger I could have fought.

My surrender wasn’t clean. Before I walked in to give up, I filled one last Adderall prescription. Then I handed the bottle to Lou and said the words: “I surrender. I’m gonna go.”

THE DRIVES · I

November 2008. A rented U-Haul pointed north out of West Palm Beach, my father at the wheel, sixty-seven years old, driving his son home from the dead. A cardinal landed on the hood as we pulled out, and he had a word for what that meant, the same word he always had for the people he'd lost. He drove.

PART FOUR

GETTING SQUARE

You can't pay back a man who never sent a bill. You can pass it on.

CHAPTER 17

Chumuckla

"Half measures availed us nothing. We stood at the turning point." — Bill Wilson, Alcoholics Anonymous

January 8, 2009

I am powerless. Powerless over alcohol, over the pills, over the man I became when I had either one in me. They are the hardest words I have ever said out loud. The first time I meant them was at a farmhouse called Chumuckla.

January 9, 2009. That's the date I count from. The night before, Lou took me to Carrabba's. My last meal as a drinking man. One glass of wine. He didn't make a ceremony of it or say a word against it. He sat across from me the way he had sat across from every hard thing in my life.

People imagine the last drink as something cinematic, savored slowly, every note memorized. Mine was disappointing. I never drank for taste. One glass only woke the machine and made it ask where the rest was. My last drink didn't even work.

The next morning we drove to a farmhouse in the Panhandle. Chumuckla. The name sounded made up. The place didn't look anything like Laguna Beach — no ocean, no manicured grounds.

Just a farmhouse down a dirt road, fields around it, run by a man named Ron. Lou walked me in, signed the paperwork, hugged me, and left.

Ron saw through me quickly. I walked in leading with my career, talking business to men who were there to stay alive. By the first day they had named me Corporate Rob. Slacks, polo, haircut — the costume I had assembled to convince the world I was fine. Ron wasn't impressed. I needed that.

Underneath the costume, one thing had survived. Wrestling had taught me that humiliation didn't have to be the ending. I had been pinned in nineteen seconds, gone 2–4 as a freshman, and still left high school with a county title. Somewhere under the pills and the pressed polo, that kid was still there.

About a dozen of us lived in the house. Dan was one of the therapists, a man who had been where I was and come out the other side. There was a nineteen-year-old gymnast, Olympic-level before addiction pulled him off course. There was Mike, quiet and steady, the kind of man who looked out for you without announcing it. And there was Chad — forty-three, bodybuilder, chef, crack addict, funny as hell. Chad was the one who told me the truth.

It came in the first seventy-two hours. By the time you get out of here, Chad told me, you'll be doing meth and knowing it's better than Adderall. He wasn't being cruel. He was drawing me a map. I had walked in believing my addiction still had a collar on it — pills, prescriptions, a pharmacy label, nothing like the men shooting heroin. Chad took the collar off.

For the first time, I could see where the road went.

The first week I couldn't look at myself in the bathroom mirror. I brushed my teeth staring at the faucet because I knew if I raised my head and caught my own eyes, I'd break.

One night we stood around a bonfire outside, stars overhead, the air cold the way North Florida can surprise you in January. I wasn't

performing recovery. I was just standing in a dirt yard with men who had ended up there for the same reason. Inside, I prayed: God, if you're real, give me a sign. I don't know what I'm doing. Show me something. The sky was clear. I remember that.

Then it started raining. Not a storm. Rain from a clear sky, on the fire, on my face, on the other men. It lasted maybe a minute. Something sealed shut in me broke open. That was the first night I believed God was there with me — not in theory, not in a Sunday-morning way. In a muddy field in Chumuckla.

Jane, the other therapist, was tougher than Dan and didn't let me slide. One day she handed me a sheet of paper and told me to write a letter to myself from five years in the future. I sat with it because I wasn't sure there would be a man five years out. I wrote anyway — about sobriety, work I was proud of, people who could trust me, Lou, becoming someone he could be proud of. Jane read it, handed it back, and said, hold on to this.

Ninety days later, I walked out different. Not fixed. Different. Cliff, a volunteer with more sober time, pulled me aside on my last day. "Three things," he said. "Go to the noon meeting every day. Find somewhere to volunteer. Sign up for a 5K." I wrote them down.

I didn't want to leave. That surprised me. Ninety days earlier I couldn't meet my own eyes in a mirror. Now the farmhouse was the one place where everyone knew exactly what I was and stayed anyway. I wasn't in love with the walls. I was afraid of who I would be without them.

Lou picked me up. Same truck, same calm. He didn't ask me to prove anything or explain what I had learned. He drove. Somewhere between the farmhouse and Pensacola, he said: "You get to start over, Rob." Thirty years old, ninety days sober, the man who had driven me in now driving me out. Whatever came next was on me.

What came next was a long line of ordinary mornings I had to learn how to fill.

CHAPTER 18 ## The Quiet Years

*“Prayer changes me, and I change things.” — Oswald
Chambers*

Pensacola, 2009

Nothing happened. That’s what made it hard.

After the second rehab there was no turnaround, no doors swinging open. Just time, without applause, without shortcuts. I stayed in Pensacola, close to Lou and Donna, in the same routines long enough that they stopped feeling temporary.

I walked into my first meeting and sat down among the people I had spent years judging. That was the part nobody warned me about. I’d had a whole theory about rooms like that, back when I was still drinking: they were for the weak, for people who lacked willpower, for people with a character problem I didn’t have. Then the door closed behind me and I was one of them. Every idea I had ever used to hold myself above people like that, I now had to eat, one meeting at a time.

I was thirty-one, no job, living at home under a thermostat that wasn’t mine to touch, in a room that ran hotter than the rest of the house. I lay up there at night adding up how my life looked from the outside. I paid for everything in cash. I bought a Grand Cherokee for four thousand dollars, and a phone from Walmart on the forty-five-dollar-a-month plan, and when everybody around me pulled out iPhones I answered mine under the table where no one could see it.

Small things. But when your confidence is gone, there are no small things. Instead of a gym I did P90X on the floor of that hot room and banked the difference.

The steps stripped me before they rebuilt me. The program is like the military that way; it breaks the ego down so it can build something that holds. What I hadn't expected was how much of what I'd been calling my personality turned out to be defense. The character defects I was supposed to surrender were the exact things I had been hiding behind for twenty years, and handing them over didn't feel like growth at first. It felt like standing in a room with nothing on.

Asking a man to sponsor me was one of the hardest things I had ever done, and on paper it's nothing. You pick someone whose sobriety you respect and you ask. But I had no padding left. If he had hesitated, not even said no, just paused, it would have confirmed everything I already believed about myself at three in the morning. The man I asked said yes, and the relief told me exactly how much I'd had riding on the question.

That year I understood why people go back out. It isn't weakness. It isn't wanting it any less. The first year asked the most of me when I had the least. They say it takes about a year for the brain to learn to make its own reward again, and I believe it, because mine wasn't making any. Nothing felt good on its own yet. And that is precisely when the program hands you a pen and asks you to take an honest inventory of the wreckage, the people you owe, the trust you burned, the years you can't give back, and start walking toward all of it. You're asked to clean up after the flood while the water is still going down. Some mornings the meeting, the phone call, the amends I wasn't ready to make felt like climbing a hill with nothing in the tank. I watched good people go back out that year, and I never once called it weakness. I knew exactly how far over their heads the water was.

Somewhere in that year I learned what sobriety was actually asking of me. It was not about feeling better. I had spent twenty years chasing feeling better, relief, escape, approval, the next thing that would make the pressure quiet down, and feelings move around like weather. Sobriety was about learning to function differently. Going when I did not feel like it. Telling the truth when hiding would have been easier. Calling someone instead of isolating. Making the apology. Going to the meeting. Staying useful while I was hurting. Living by values instead of moods. I could function anyway. That was the discovery that carried me through the year the feelings couldn't.

Who you stand next to decides more than people admit. The rooms have their own pecking order, old-timers, big personalities, sponsors who collect sponsees like merit badges, and if you attach yourself to the wrong people, the rooms themselves can walk you back out the door. I got lucky, or I got guided. The handful I stood next to wanted me sober more than they wanted an audience.

I worked as a lifeguard, watching the water at the UWF pool. I was thirty-two on a stand where everyone else working was nineteen. I felt old. I also felt good. Three rounds of P90X had me in the best shape I'd been in years. The job was simple. Scan faces, count heads, make sure everyone got home safe. Stop paying attention and someone could die. I liked that. Lifeguarding was presence. You stood watch, shift after shift, and most days nothing happened. That was the point. One day a mom asked if I'd give her kid swimming lessons. I'm pretty sure the lessons weren't about the kid. I said maybe and went back to watching the water. The old me would have turned it into something. The new me could let a moment stay small.

For a stretch in those years, I trained MMA in a garage, thirty-two years old and grappling with guys ten years younger. The wrestling came right back. Nobody in that garage could stop the takedown, and for a few months I got to feel seventeen again. Then

an opponent kneed me in the ribs in the middle of a front headlock and broke two of them, and a sparring round with a guy named Tyrone jarred a back tooth loose; the tooth ended in an implant. I never took an official fight. The garage sessions ended the way garage sessions should, with a body politely informing a man in his thirties that the mat had already taught him everything he needed.

The confidence came back too, the real kind this time, not the chemical kind. Years before I met Hope, I went to an Auburn game with a friend and said out loud, that's the best-looking girl in the stadium. An hour later I had her number and an invitation to come visit. Not long before, I'd been brushing my teeth staring at the faucet. Now I could walk across a room again.

Cliff's three things came with me out of Chumuckla, and I did all three. I went to Courage at Noon every single day for the first year, a room on church property, the same handful of people learning to live again on their lunch break. I didn't always feel courageous walking in. I went anyway. I volunteered at that same church twice a week for a year. And the 5K turned into a marathon, which I ran the way I did most things that year, on nerve and repetition. The longest I had ever run in my life was nine miles. At signup, the full marathon cost ten dollars more than the half, so I took the full. That was the reasoning, start to finish. I walked parts of it. I finished all of it. Lou was waiting at the finish line with Subway, because of course he was. Hundreds of meetings became thousands. Tuesday nights it was the round table in a Methodist church basement, a table with no head and no foot, the newcomer sitting level with the thirty-year man. Same folding chairs, same bad coffee, same stories told by different people at different stages of ruin and repair. I listened more than I talked, and when I talked I didn't tie it up neatly. I told the truth. Nobody writes a book about the four hundredth meeting. But the four hundredth meeting is the one that keeps you sober, because you walked in the same as the first.

Somewhere in there I went from the man who needed saving to the man another man called at midnight. I sponsored eleven people. Some of them really wanted it. Some just needed a sponsor's name on paper, a box to check for a court or a program, and we both knew it. Some made it. Some didn't. Of the eleven, one that I know of is still sober today. One. You answer the phone every time anyway, because someone answered it for you, and because you never know which one is going to be the one. That one did the work and moved away. A year later he called me out of nowhere, just to say thank you. He was sponsoring three people of his own now. You get it for free, you give it away, and one day a man you'll never meet stays sober because somebody once stayed with you.

I sat beside a lot of unwell people in those years, many of them still in rehab. People mid-collapse, people barely hanging on, people who said things in those rooms you don't forget. I learned to be with someone who wasn't okay and not flinch, not rush to fix it, just stay.

The shape of those years was small on purpose. Up at five thirty. Coffee. A little notebook by the bed where I wrote down whatever was in my head, sometimes a sentence, sometimes just a list of things I was grateful for. A walk along the bay in Gulf Breeze before the sun came up. Breakfast at home, and the morning news with the sound off and the captions on. Nobody would make a movie out of it.

CHAPTER 19 ## The People You Meet When You Stop Drinking

*“Two are better than one... for if they fall, the one will lift up
his fellow.” — Ecclesiastes 4:9–10*

Pensacola, 2009–present

One of the men I got sober alongside had been homeless with a tenth-grade education, and a few years later he had a Hollywood actor sleeping in his guest room. His name is Matt. The men God put in front of me weren't the ones I would have picked, and the first of them came early, when I couldn't yet see any of it.

Early in sobriety, your brain is rewiring itself. You walk around in a fog, not drunk, not high, just flat. I was depressed, living with my parents, going to meetings, trying to figure out what came next, and I kept landing on the same thought: I'd never build something real again. Not somebody like me. Somewhere in there I heard people say how few stay sober. I never looked it up. When you're new, you don't hear that as information. You look around the room and wonder which one of you it's going to be. I was a long shot.

I needed a sponsor. So I picked a guy named Andy. Andy's whole vibe was Eeyore, a low-grade heaviness over him like a cloud that never moved. Not angry, just down, like the world had worn him out long ago and he'd made peace with being tired. I'm looking at my sponsor thinking: is this what the long term looks like? If this is sober after fifteen years, I don't know what I signed up for.

But I came to know Andy. Behind the Eeyore was a guy who'd rebuilt himself piece by piece and wasn't interested in making it look pretty. When you're newly sober, everything is a five-alarm fire, and I'd call him spinning out about whatever felt like the end of the world that Tuesday. Andy would listen. Wouldn't interrupt, wouldn't match my energy, just let me run out of gas. Then, when I'd laid out the whole catastrophe, he'd say the same thing every time. "You prayed about it?" The answer was always no. I'd called Andy before I'd called God. He sponsored me a year or two, and he's still a friend. I hear his voice every time I reach for the phone to complain about something before I've gotten on my knees.

Mager was about ten years older than me. I met him at a meeting called Harbor Town in Gulf Breeze and knew within thirty seconds he was different. If I'm a five on the energy scale, Mager is a twelve. No off switch. He walked up like he'd known me his whole life, big smile, firm handshake, a close talker, growling in your face like every conversation is the most important one he's ever had. I looked at him and thought: this guy has it going on. Wife, three kids, life dialed in. And sober. It was the first time I looked at someone in recovery and thought maybe this could be more than survival. Maybe you can thrive.

Mager became my sponsor and taught me more than I could list, but one thing stuck hardest. You want to know what kind of program somebody's working? Don't listen to them at the podium. Talk to the people in their life. Their wife, their kids, their boss. The person at the podium is performing. The people at home are telling the truth. Mager and I talk on the phone every morning. Every single one. We do a short prayer together, a way to start the day right. Going on fifteen years of that.

And there's Matt Campbell, the man from the top of this chapter. When I met him he was at Jason's Deli making ten dollars an hour, calling me about life on ten dollars an hour, the same calls I'd made

to Andy. He had nothing but the program, and I think that's exactly what he needed. You already know where it went. We all went to church together on Sundays, a pew full of lives rebuilt from wreckage, sitting there like the most normal thing in the world.

And then there was Quint Studer. I was thirty-three, sober long enough to know I wasn't going back, and I couldn't shake the feeling there was something left in the tank. Not ego. A quiet sense that maybe God hadn't kept me alive just to sit in meetings the rest of my life trying not to mess up again. I wanted to do more. I just hadn't seen many examples of what that looked like.

Quint had run Baptist Hospital, the same hospital where my dad worked, and gone on to build things half of Pensacola walks past every day. A man like that could sit anywhere he wanted. He sat with us. What struck me was how he carried himself, a steadiness that didn't feel like ego. Over time he'd talk with me after meetings, look me directly in the eye, and encourage me with the kind of quiet belief that says, I see something in you.

I had one of his books, and one day I asked him to sign it. He wrote four words. "You make people better." I've thought about that line more than he could know. It stopped being a compliment and turned into an assignment. He made me want to do more than stay sober. He made me want to become the thing he'd written down.

Years into the friendship, at the business conference he built for the city, he was speaking, and he paused and looked out into the crowd. Lou Brizzi, great guy. Chris and Rob, you know them? Hearing my father's name in a room like that stopped me. My dad worked at Baptist Hospital for years, showed up, did the job well, treated people right, stayed until he was eighty-two. Quint saying his name in a room full of leaders honored the life my father believed in.

The morning after my father died, all these years later, Quint was the first person to reach me. "Your dad was a great man," his text said. Of everyone who would reach out in those days, he got there

first, and he said the truest thing. God didn't put Quint in my life to rescue me. He put him there to show me what was possible. For the first time since getting sober, I believed there was more for me to do than stay alive.

The best one didn't come from a meeting at all. You'll meet her soon.

CHAPTER 20 ## The Line

“Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.” — Proverbs 4:23

Pensacola, 2010

“Rob, if you relapse, I’m going to have to wash my hands of you.” No emotion. No threat. My father said it the way he stated facts, and it was the kindest hard thing anyone ever told me. It only worked coming from him. He had spent my whole life proving he would never actually leave. Sobriety didn’t erase desire. That surprised me. What sobriety gave me was time. What it took away was the anesthesia, and without it I could feel everything, the hunger included. The disease didn’t leave when I put the drink down. It got quiet and waited.

By late 2010, I was restless in a way I couldn’t name. Sober, working, going to meetings, living clean, and underneath it something in me still wanted out. An opportunity came across my radar, medical device sales, Stryker. Big money, fast track. My first thought was: this is how I get back. My second: I don’t know if I can stay sober there.

That scared me. I drove to see Lou. He didn’t ask why I’d come; he rarely did. He listened while I talked in circles, opportunity, timing, readiness, fear. Eventually the truth slipped out. “I still want to drink,” I said. The words just hung there. Accurate.

He didn't react the way I expected. No anger, no speech, no disappointment. He looked at me the way he had when I was losing badly on a mat and he was deciding whether I could recover. Then he said it. Just a boundary. It landed harder than any consequence I'd faced, not because it was cruel but because it was clean. He'd done what he could do, and he wasn't going to stand by and watch me die slowly while pretending that watching helped.

I left shaken. That line forced a choice I couldn't hand off. Go back to that world too soon and I wouldn't be returning, I'd be relapsing with a résumé. I didn't take the job. It didn't feel brave. It felt like staying alive.

The payoff came quietly, months later. A Tuesday morning in 2011, on my walk along the bay, coffee in a paper cup, the sun just coming up over the water. I wasn't thinking about anything in particular, and then I knew, the way you know your own name. I didn't want a drink. I hadn't wanted one in a long time, and it wasn't a fight anymore. I took another sip of coffee and kept walking.

CHAPTER 21 ## They Gave Me a Chance

“Old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.” — 2 Corinthians 5:17

Pensacola, 2011

When the recruiter asked what I’d been doing for the last five years, I didn’t open up about everything. The call came on an ordinary day. By 2011, ordinary days were the whole texture of my life. The sharp edges were gone. Work, meetings, lifeguard shifts, dinners with Lou and Donna, early mornings that looked exactly like the ones before. When the phone rang that afternoon I almost let it go to voicemail.

A recruiter. Someone who knew someone, the way it happens in a town like Pensacola. We’re looking for someone to build relationships for a home health company, nursing, PT, OT, patients who can’t get to clinics. We need someone who can develop referral sources. Healthcare. The word landed with weight. Not excitement. Something quieter.

“I have medical sales experience,” I said. “But it’s been a while.” How long?” “About five years.” “And what have you been doing since? There it was. I didn’t spin it, and I didn’t tell the whole story either.” Some bumps in the road,” I said. “I’ve been rebuilding.” Silence, not uncomfortable, just space. “Can you come in for an interview?”

Caroline, the home health leader who would hire me, didn't waste time. She read my résumé the way people do when they're not looking to be impressed, following the rise all the way to where it stopped. She didn't ask about the gaps. She asked about trust. How do you build it with people who don't know you? What do you do when the territory's cold and the numbers aren't there? How do you stay consistent when results don't come? I talked about discipline without ego, doing the work because it's right, not because someone's watching. Rejection as information, not a verdict. I talked about the pool, scanning the water when nothing was happening, how the job was the same whether anyone needed saving or not. She listened. Wrote. Looked up only when something mattered.

"The position pays sixty thousand a year," she said finally. "Plus commission. But it's a slow build." Once, I'd made five times that and felt hollow. This felt honest. "I can do this," I said, and for once in an interview I wasn't performing belief. I was stating it.

She called three days later. "I need to talk to you about something from your background check." I knew. "It shows two DUIs. Those weren't disclosed." "You're right," I said. "I should have disclosed it. I'm sorry." A pause. "Can you tell me what happened?" So I did. Not the polished version. What it had been, what it cost, what had changed. When I finished, the line stayed quiet. "Okay," she said. "I appreciate your honesty. Let me talk to HR."

Four days. I went to work, went to meetings, had dinner, slept, did it again. On the fifth day Caroline called. "How does a November first start date sound?" I didn't answer right away. I sat in my car in Lou's driveway and let it settle. Not adrenaline. Gratitude. Someone had looked at who I was and decided it was enough. I called Lou. "I got the job. She knew about the DUIs. HR wanted to pull the offer. She fought for me." A pause. "That's a blessing," he said. "I'm proud of you." After we hung up I sat there a long time.

The work didn't feel heroic, which surprised me. I half-expected the new job to arrive with meaning baked in. Day one was paper-work. Compliance modules. Acronyms I barely remembered from a former life, HIPAA, OASIS. Caroline didn't give me a speech. She showed me how things worked. "This is a long game," she said. "You don't force referrals. You earn trust."

Home health wasn't selling, not the way I'd done it. It was assisted livings and living rooms, oxygen tanks humming in the corner, family members exhausted in ways sleep doesn't fix. I walked into homes where time had slowed down.

Miss Jane was seventy-eight, recovering from hip surgery, and she apologized for the mess in a spotless house. She told me she used to dance, every Friday night for forty years, like it was a confession, and she was terrified she'd never walk without a walker again. I didn't rush past it. I asked about the dancing, and her face changed when she talked about it. That was the job.

Mr. Joe was newly diabetic, embarrassed he needed a nurse to teach him insulin. His hands shook as he practiced. "I'm sorry," he kept saying. "I should have this by now." "You have it," I told him. "You've done it right three times in a row." He looked up like he hadn't thought to count the successes.

It was familiar. I knew what it was like to need help and not want it, to be ashamed of dependence, to apologize for taking up space when you're the one suffering. So when families talked I didn't rush them, didn't fill the silence, didn't pitch. I listened. Caroline noticed. "You're different with people," she said one afternoon. "You don't talk at them." "I know what it feels like to be scared," I said. She nodded. No follow-up. She'd already decided to trust me, and I understood what that trust meant in a way I wouldn't have before.

The days were long, doctors' offices, nursing homes, assisted livings, back roads. At night I still went to meetings, still called my sponsor. There was a moment, small and almost forgettable, when I

was sitting in my car after a visit with paperwork on the steering wheel and realized I wasn't waiting for something else anymore. This was enough. They gave me a chance, and I stayed ten years.

CHAPTER 22 ## Making Amends

“First be reconciled to thy brother, and then come and offer thy gift.” — Matthew 5:24

Pensacola, 2012

\$113,000. That was the number when I finally added it up in ink, every credit card and collection account and legal fee, no rounding. I’d spent years not looking at it. Steady work meant I could finally face the wreckage I’d been outrunning, and my sponsor Mager was the one who walked me into it. He didn’t rush me. He was patient, but he wasn’t buying the act. I could make my recovery sound like a success story, still controlling the version of me in the room. Mager didn’t interrupt. He listened in a way that made clear he was hearing more than I was saying, and eventually, with nowhere for the story to land, it fell apart on its own.

I got stuck on the amends step. Not in theory. In the concrete requirement to account for everything, without narrative, without softening. One night after a meeting, Mager slid a yellow legal pad across the table. “Write it down,” he said. I knew what he meant.

I had never been honest with myself about money. I used it to keep score. This was about what it had cost. I started listing. Credit cards, multiple, run up over years of buying the appearance of success with borrowed money. Medical bills. Legal fees. Collection accounts I hadn’t looked at directly in months. When I finished I added it up slowly. \$113,000. I waited for the spiral. It didn’t come.

What came was clarity. The real number doesn't move. It just sits there, and because it sits there, you can work with it.

Mager looked at the pad. Didn't soften it, didn't minimize it. "Okay," he said. "Now we know." We kept it basic: pay what you can, don't borrow, don't hide, open the envelopes, answer the calls, always know where you stand. At one point I reached for the future. "Once I make more." Mager stopped me. "Use the money you actually have. That's how trust gets rebuilt."

My mother's money never went on that legal pad. What I owed her had no number on it. The lies I'd told her went into my fourth step and my fifth, and for years I told myself the rest was paid in the only currency she ever wanted — her son, alive and honest. Writing this book made me stop on that sentence. Sober and alive is a start. It isn't a settlement. She's the last parent I have, down in South Florida, and I am not there enough. I've come to think this isn't an amends you finish — not a letter, not a line in a book. It's the trips. More of my time, which is the one thing she always wanted and the one thing I kept for myself. I love her, and I haven't shown it the way she showed me. I'm booking a trip to South Florida to see her — to start being a better son while I still have the time to be one. The debt on the pad didn't disappear fast. But I stopped flinching when bills came. I started answering calls from numbers I didn't recognize. My past stopped feeling like it was following me, not because it was gone, but because it was being addressed. Not redemption. Nothing was being erased. Responsibility. One payment, one opened envelope, one answered call at a time.

One amends I owed Chris had nothing to do with money. I'm the older brother. On paper the job was mine, look out for him, go first, take the hit. My addiction handed that job to him instead. He drove me to detox. He called me with the ultimatum. He watched the whole family bend around a crisis I kept making, and somewhere in it he became the big brother, a promotion he never asked for. When I

made my amends to him, I said it plain. “I’m sorry you had to be the older one.” He waved it off the way he waves off everything. But I needed to say it, and I needed him to hear it. He carried a weight that should have been mine, and he never once made me feel like the weight.

The courts came last. In 2013, four years sober, I wrote to the court myself and petitioned to have the cases dismissed. No lawyer this time. In 2002 that work had taken a good attorney and ten thousand dollars. In 2013 it took a letter from a sober man who had done everything the court asked. The dismissals came through.

CHAPTER 23 ## The Salmon Palace

“Except the LORD build the house, they labour in vain that build it.” — Psalm 127:1

Pensacola, 2014

I didn’t buy it because it made sense. On paper it didn’t. An association fee. Seven hundred and sixty-five square feet, one bedroom, one bath, but it was all I needed. It was a condo carved out of a building called the Mirador, Spanish stucco with a Spanish tile roof, a place that looked like it belonged in Southern California or Mexico and somehow held its ground in Pensacola. My unit had its own balcony over the pool. To this day it’s the proudest I have ever been of a place I lived.

The color was impossible to ignore. Salmon. Warm and defiant. It sat up off the road like a little castle on a hill, and that is exactly why my friends named it the Salmon Palace. They said it proud. The deed said the Mirador. Both were true. For years I drove past it on my way home from meetings. At first I barely noticed it. Then I noticed it every time. Then I was slowing down, then parking across the street to sit and stare. I couldn’t imagine ever living there. So I did the thing they teach you. I pictured it anyway, owning it one day, a kind of prayer I didn’t have the nerve to say out loud. Something in me recognized the place.

By then I was doing well again, quietly. Home health had stabilized my life. Sober, paying bills, still carrying debt but no

longer running from it. I wasn't after something bigger. I wanted something that was mine. The realtor showed me the sensible options first, places near the railroad tracks, starter homes with neutral paint, the kind that say be grateful this is all you can afford. None of them felt right. When I asked about the Mirador she raised an eyebrow. "That one's different," she said. "I know," I said.

The unit was small but solid. Thick walls, high ceilings, construction that survives hurricanes and decades and neglect. It felt anchored. I didn't need to impress anymore. I needed something permanent.

Prices in Pensacola were still down in 2014, which is the only reason a place like that ever came within reach. It was listed at a hundred and thirty thousand. I offered a hundred and nine, and they accepted. The only thing between me and the keys was the down payment, and I was short. Not dramatically. Enough to matter. So I called my brother, and I hated every second of it. Chris had done everything right, watched Lou rescue me, watched me fall and climb and wobble. He loved me, but love isn't unlimited credit. "I need to borrow ten thousand dollars," I said. He didn't make me sweat it. "Rob," he said, "I'll loan it to you and I won't ask you a dollar for it. But if you don't pay it back, it'll affect our relationship." He wasn't threatening me. He was trusting me, conditionally. "I understand," I said. He sent it. I set up an automatic payment that day, two hundred a month, and paid extra when I could. It took four years. I never missed one.

When I got the keys, I stood in the middle of that small living room longer than I expected. Nothing about it was impressive, and that was the point. I'd earned it through doing the next right thing. For five years the Mirador was my world. I woke up there, prayed there, paid down debt there, stayed sober there. Went to work, came home, did it again. Nobody applauded, and that was the miracle.

Years later, when Hope walked through that door the first time, she didn't say a word about the size. She noticed how it felt. We'd take a devotional out to the pool, or down to the dock, and read it together. The habit we still fall back into, the one that's just part of the house now, started there. We sold it in 2019, a hundred thousand in equity, and put it down on the home Hope and I built together in East Hill, the kind I'd never let myself imagine from across the street. From a one-bedroom salmon castle to a house we built from the ground up.

CHAPTER 24 ## Horacio

“For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you.” — Matthew 6:14

Pensacola, 2015

He never remarried. No second family, no one after my mother.

When I was small, he called me his good luck charm. I think about that now. Whatever luck I was, it got on a plane when I was four, and he stayed where it left him.

The first time I heard from him after Mexico, I was fifteen. The phone rang at the house and it was him, the first contact since I was barely school age. Just his voice undid me, tears before I could get a word out. He was gentle about it. “It’s okay,” he said. “Don’t cry. Be happy.” There was a hole in me where he had been, an ache carried so long I’d stopped noticing it, and his voice opened it right back up. Years of something close to hatred had grown in that empty space, and even so, looking back, I can’t lay it at anyone’s feet. It was nobody’s fault.

The next time I saw him in person was in Ensenada, in 2006, right after the first rehab. I was in active addiction myself by then, though I wouldn’t have said those words. I went back to the man who had been at the center of my first life, and I wasn’t a boy looking up at him anymore. I could see him as he was, his circumstance, the things that had made him the father who locked the door. Maybe I saw it so clearly because I was closer to it than I wanted to

know. Up close, the anger I had carried for so long began to turn into something quieter.

What I couldn't do was become the son he wanted. He was looking for a relationship I didn't have in me to give. What took me longest was seeing those as two separate things — that you can forgive a man completely and still not be able to hand him your life.

In 2015, I reached for him again. I was thirty-six and sober, and part of the reaching was amends, my side of the street, the years of anger, the silence. I made them. And I called him Horacio. Not Papa. Not Dad. Dad was a word that belonged to someone else by then. Horacio never said anything about it. We talked every week for a couple of months.

He had no long-distance service on his phone. So every Wednesday he would go out to a place that had a VoIP line, and at seven o'clock my phone would ring. He had to leave his home just to hear my voice.

Mostly we talked about sports. That was the easy ground between us. He loved baseball, so we would go back and forth about games and players, who was hot and who was washed up. Soccer was his real love, though. He would get going on it and the stories would come, matches he had seen, players he swore by, games that had meant something to him long before I was born.

For a couple of months it was easy. Two men on the phone, talking about games.

Then one call, it turned. He told me he had never moved on after my mother left. He said he was still in love with her, all these years later.

I sat with that. In a way, I felt sorry for him. I couldn't imagine what it must have done to him to lose his children and the woman he loved in the same leaving, and then to just stay there, in that spot, all these years. I had built a whole life since Mexico. He had stayed where we left him.

Then life got busy. That's the honest, ordinary way it happened, no blowup, no slammed door. I let the calls slip. He kept going out to that VoIP line. I was the one who stopped picking up the other end. He wanted to come to Pensacola, and I felt my boundaries start to bend, and I pulled back. Pensacola was Lou's. I couldn't do that to him. I told myself I'd pick it up again when things settled down. I didn't. We haven't spoken in years.

He called again in 2019, before my wedding. I didn't answer. Then he went around me. He found Lou's family and mine on Facebook, friend requests going out to people in my life he had never met. I understood the loneliness underneath it. It was still a boundary, and he had crossed it.

I felt bad about it. I still do, a little.

And there is an apology I owe him too. For most of my life the distance was something done to me. I see now it ran both ways. My silence on the other end of that line, the calls I let ring out, those hurt him the way his leaving once hurt me. I'm sorry for that. And I'm grateful I got healthy enough to feel it at all instead of only carrying the ache.

He called every Wednesday at seven, right on time, until I stopped answering.

And every Fourth of July — my birthday — since that first call, the phone has rung with him on the other end. It rang through the using years and the sober years, whether I picked up or not. I was born on the Fourth of July, the immigrant kid with the most American birthday there is, and the one person who never once forgot it was the father I left in Mexico. It took me until this page to notice that. A while ago I changed my number. He doesn't have the new one. Somewhere in Mexico City this July, a man will dial a number I chose not to give him, because that is what he does with the day his first son was born.

It took me a long time to understand that all of it, the Wednesday calls at seven from a borrowed line, the birthday calls, even the friend requests to people he had never met, was the love. I understood it. I still couldn't answer it. It hasn't stopped him from trying. There was never anyone else to try for. Chris and me. That's what he has. Do I have closure? I don't know. It's complicated, and I've stopped needing it not to be. What's simple is this: I honor Lou. One father kept calling. The other one kept coming.

THE DRIVES · II

New York State, weekend after weekend, however far the bracket went. He'd worked the night before and never talked about the miles. It was the rides home I kept: the dark, the quiet, two people who had spent the day at the same thing. Love he never announced. Earned, both of us. He drove.

PART FIVE

HOPE

She said, I will love you no matter what. I'd heard that sentence once before — proved, not spoken.

CHAPTER 25 ## Sobriety Meets Hospice

“I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith.” — 2 Timothy 4:7

Pensacola, 2015

I saw things in the rooms that never leave you. Young people dying from drugs and alcohol. Not old men at the end of long lives, young people with everything ahead of them. I sponsored people who went back out. Many of them died. Some went to jail. You pour yourself into someone, walk alongside them, answer the phone at midnight, and then one day you get the call that they didn't make it.

I was that person once. I know what the disease does from the inside. Losing people in those rooms prepared me for something I didn't know I was being prepared for. Nothing in hospice is harder than a parent losing a child. The only reason I can stay in that room without flinching is that I've already sat with losses like that in recovery. Hospice just gave me a new room to bring it to.

The very first time I was in a room with someone dying, I was too small to know that was what it was. My grandfather's mother was in a nursing home, near the end. I was a little boy, barely talking, and the only language I had yet was Spanish. She lay against the pillows, white-haired and round-faced, and to me she looked like exactly one thing. Santa Claus. So I told her so. Ho, ho, ho. My

mother said, Stop. I didn't understand the hush in the room, or that the woman in the bed was leaving, or that I would spend my life walking into rooms just like it. I only remember her face, and my mother's hand steering me out.

The first death that stayed with me wasn't a patient, and it came years before hospice was ever my job. It was Detroit Bob.

I met him at Courage at Noon in my first year sober. About eighty, bald, a scratchy voice, a face that looked permanently annoyed, like the world had let him down personally and he hadn't decided yet whether to forgive it. He smelled like Old Spice, just enough, never too much. His favorite line, and I heard it a hundred times: I'm not here to help any of you. I'm here to save my own butt. And you're listening to me? That's just a fringe benefit. People figured he was cynical. Not Bob. Bob had done the work. He just wasn't going to perform it for an audience. And he had the one thing I could not stop staring at: decades sober, old, and at peace with all of it. I needed to understand how a person did that.

So we got close. We'd go to the diner together after meetings, me at thirty-one, him at eighty, the most unlikely pair in the place, and crack up. He'd tell stories that had no business being that funny, and whatever mess I was in he'd make smaller just by laughing at it. Not at me. With me. Bob knew the difference. Then, years into the friendship, the cancer came. He knew it was going to take him, and he stayed sober anyway, a man at the very end of his life with every excuse in the world to pick up, choosing not to. He fought it for about six months, and somewhere in there he went on hospice, the first time that word ever meant someone I loved instead of a thing I would one day do for a living.

One afternoon he looked at me and said it straight out, the way he said everything. "I am so proud of the man I have seen you grow into over the past seven years. You have really blossomed. And sober

looks good on you.” Bob did not hand out lines like that. I have carried it ever since.

Near the end, I went to see him, and it was nothing like the nursing-home room of my boyhood — this was a grown man actively dying, and everyone in the house knew it. The place was full. People he’d carried in the rooms, people who’d carried him, a steady stream coming to sit with him and say what they needed to say while he could still hear it. My first thought was a small, honest panic: how was I supposed to feel all of this without anything to take the edge off? I had never done grief without a buffer. The panic didn’t last, and what replaced it wasn’t sadness. It was gratitude, and a level calm, the plain fact of being there and not needing to be anywhere else. He told me once that sobriety wasn’t something he fought every morning; it was a decision he had made a single time and never went back to revisit, and he carried it all the way to the edge of his life. Decades older than me, and still showing me how it was done.

I was in the room when he passed, in 2016. I had been around a lot by then, but not that, not the actual leaving. I watched it happen, and afterward I stayed for his wife, a woman I loved, because there was nothing left to do but be there and not go. That was when it finally landed. Bob was gone. There was no fixing it, no deal to close, no right answer that would have bought him one more minute.

Around that same stretch, the recognition I’d chased my whole life finally showed up at work, and it barely registered. Someone forwarded an internal article. A colleague congratulated me in passing. I skimmed it once and closed the screen. Lou noticed, the way he noticed everything. “You’re successful again,” he said. “I guess,” I said. “You don’t sound like it matters.” “That’s because it doesn’t,” I said. “Not the way it used to.” He nodded.

I talked to Lou about Bob one evening. “I don’t know why this is hitting me so hard,” I said. “I did everything right.” He didn’t hesitate. “That’s not why it’s bothering you.” He was right. Bob

hadn't needed me to fix anything. He'd needed me in the room. I was being let into places where presence was the only thing left to offer, and something in me already knew how to do that. Years later, that became the whole job.

CHAPTER 26 ## Hope for Rob

“Hope deferred maketh the heart sick: but when the desire cometh, it is a tree of life.” — Proverbs 13:12

Pensacola, 2017

The most important person I would meet sober didn’t come from a meeting room. She came from a dating profile that told me not to write to her. By the time I opened Match.com I wasn’t looking for anything. I’d been single a while, settled into my little life, my little condo, okay with it. I got on anyway. And there was this profile. The name on it: Read My Profile. She was tired of guys messaging without reading a word she wrote. Blonde, beautiful, a pharmacist. Nine and a half years younger than me, right at the edge of what I’d consider. The profile said she was studying for the boards and planning to move to Colorado. Don’t message me if you’re local in Pensacola.

I messaged her anyway. “I know you’re leaving,” I said, “but would you be interested in just getting coffee?” She wrote back: “How about you take me to dinner?” This girl is something. I tried calling. She didn’t answer, said we’d talk at dinner. So I made a plan. Called Global Grill, one of our favorites, my dad’s spot, booked 6:45. Then texted her: “Hope, I’ll pick you up at 6:15. Reservations are 6:45. See you then.” I found out later she was floored. She was used to guys who wouldn’t make a plan, wouldn’t pick her up, just “meet me somewhere.” The whole first year was like that for her, she

said, a quiet shock that a man this thoughtful and considerate actually existed. None of it bought me any mercy on the age gap. She was calling me a forty-year-old before I'd even turned thirty-nine. "You will have your turn," I'd tell her. We laughed at everything.

She got in the car shier than I expected, hair half over her face. Five foot nothing. Quiet at first. But we hit it off, both at places in our lives where we weren't playing games. At Global Grill I handed the hostess twenty bucks and she said, "I know your dad, you can sit wherever you want." The table by the window. The conversation flowed. She noticed early I didn't order a drink, so that came up, and I told her I didn't drink. She had a glass of wine. She got the filet, which I'd learn is what she always orders. I was sitting across from her, and somewhere between the ordering and the check the rest of the room went quiet for me. It was the first date in my life that didn't feel like a performance.

She told me about Eclectic, Alabama. Small town, good parents, divorced when she was in middle school. Her dad Jeff is one of the gentlest people I've ever met. The way she loves him, the easy, unbroken thing between them, makes me thankful every time I'm near it. I know what a father is worth. I had to learn it twice. I say the same thing to Jeff every time I see him: thank you for raising her the way you did. Her mom Rhonda is a free spirit, warm, would do anything for her kids. We got into my story, and when I told her about the addiction she said she'd dated a guy with a problem before and that it was impressive I'd stayed sober. She didn't flinch.

Her people flinched for her. When friends heard she was dating a man in recovery, the question was always the same one, said or unsaid: what happens if he relapses? Rhonda carried it too. Nobody was wrong to ask. They loved her, and they knew the odds the same as anyone. She heard all of it and stayed anyway.

By the end of dinner I couldn't wait to kiss her. I walked her to the car, opened the door, leaned in. First kiss. Worth every wrong turn that led to it. Took her back to my place, no intentions, just to show her where I lived, and we talked until it got late, the easy kind of talk that doesn't check the clock. I drove her home and could have kept driving all night.

The next morning was the McGuire's 5K, eight thousand people. I felt a pull to find her in the crowd, and we made our way to each other. She arrived in a little green outfit, adorable. A friend from the gym had a bulldog puppy, and I carried it over and said, "That's the kind of dog we need to get." She looked at me. "We?" It just came out. Sudden, and right. One dinner in, and some part of me had already decided.

After that, fast. My mom couldn't believe how quickly Hope moved in. Hope grew up simple, Eclectic, Auburn Montgomery for undergrad, barely getting C's at first. Then she decided she wanted to be a pharmacist and that changed everything. Head down, all A's by the end. That got her into Auburn's pharmacy school, one of the best in the country. She was beautiful, smart, and kind, and the kindness mattered most. I'd dated impressive women. Hope was good. There's a difference. With her I showed things I'd never shown anyone, the real inventory, the shame, the fear under the confidence, Claudio, the kid from Mexico City who still sometimes wondered if he was worth choosing. She didn't look away. For the first time, being known didn't feel like a threat. It felt like relief.

The moment I knew came quietly. I was wrestling an old insecurity, the kind I had always managed alone, and instead of managing it I said it out loud. She said, "I will love you no matter what." People say those words. I could feel that she meant them, all the way down. My father spent a lifetime proving that sentence without ever needing to say it. Hearing it said to me, and believing it, was the

moment I knew I would marry her. Falling in love with her was the easiest thing I'd ever done.

Are You Saved?

The drive from Pensacola to Scottsboro took six and a half hours. I was thirty-nine, driving to ask a man I'd never met for permission to marry his daughter, the way men used to, the way Lou would expect. Jeff Middleton answered the door. Not tall, but he had presence, and a stillness that isn't distance, it's peace. "You must be the one," he said. "Yes sir." "Come in. Hope, go help Roseanne in the kitchen." Roseanne is her stepmom.

We sat in the living room. No small talk. I had the whole confession loaded and ready, the résumé of my wreckage, born in Mexico City, adopted at eight, the wrestling, the money I made and lost, the addiction, the two DUIs, how Lou had to come and rescue me. I figured a father would want all of it before he handed over his daughter. He didn't ask for any of it. He looked at me and asked one thing. "Are you saved?" "Yes sir." "Can you tell me about that experience?" So I told him about my faith. Where it started, the church my mother and Lou made non-negotiable, how I'd lost the thread of it for years, and how it had come back and held. The wreckage stayed in my pocket. I never got into any of it, and he never asked.

He nodded slowly. He didn't follow up. He had heard the one thing he wanted to hear. "That father of yours sounds like a good man," he said. "Best man I've ever known," I told him. Jeff smiled for the first time, stood, and put out his hand. "You have my blessing." Then his eyes filled and he didn't look away. "I could have done better in my marriage with Rhonda," he said. "I blame myself." He wasn't giving me a tough-father speech. He was handing me his own regret and trusting me with it. "Don't screw this

up,” he added. “No sir. I won’t.” He told me later the moment he’d actually known I was the one for her: the weekend early on when Hope forgot her ID on a trip to Mississippi, and I got up before light, drove back to Pensacola for it, and drove us straight back.

Outside my own father, Jeff is one of two men who have shown me what faith looks like when it’s lived instead of just spoken. The other is Dave Meyer, my friend since middle school. Different men, same spine. Neither one talks the talk and stops there; both walk it. Neither has ever lost sight of where God is in it. I’ve needed them both as proof that the thing I reached for in a muddy field in Chumuckla holds up across a whole life.

Blessings

When Lou poured coffee that day, he poured it for himself and for Hope. Not for me. I noticed, and I understood it was the closest thing to a blessing he was going to give.

Before any of that, before the wedding, there was the day she met Lou. I was nervous. Not the wrestling-match kind. Not the holding-cell kind. This was precise, like one wrong word, one moment of performance instead of presence, would miss the point.

We drove over together. Lou was sitting when we walked in. He stood when he saw us, not as ceremony, as regard. He shook Hope’s hand, looked her in the eye, and said: “Nice to finally meet you.” Not good to meet you. Finally.

They talked easily. He asked where she was from, what her work involved. He wasn’t screening a résumé. He was watching how she held herself, whether she held his gaze, whether she said what she meant. At one point he said, “Rob’s had a complicated road.” Hope nodded. “I know.” Not I’ve heard. I know. Lou sat with it, then smiled, small and private. He’d been looking for something and found it.

They went into the kitchen together while I stayed in the living room. I could hear drawers opening, plates moving. Not interrogation. He was including her in the daily life of his household. When they came back, he poured the coffee. Two cups, not three. It wasn't an oversight.

Later he looked at me. "You're steady," he said. Then: "She is too." That was it. No formal blessing, no speech. He saw two people steady in the same direction and noted it.

The Proposal

I proposed at Jackson's, my mom and my aunts at the table. The plan was after dinner. But I couldn't wait. Too nervous. "I can't sit through this whole meal," I said. "I'm just going to do this." So I got on a knee, awkwardly, and asked her to marry me. Hope said yes, and the nerves went out of me all at once. What settled in their place was the surest feeling I've ever had about anything. I could finally enjoy the rest of my meal. Right after, we got a Chihuahua together, a little one named Nola. She's eight now. That dog's been with us through everything.

The Wedding

We picked Live Oak Plantation in Beulah, just outside Pensacola. About a hundred family and friends. April 9, 2019. January 9 was the day I got sober. April 9 was the day I got married. I didn't plan that. It just arrived. Watching her come toward me that afternoon, I understood what all of it had been for. I cried at the altar. I didn't try to stop it. Lou was there, seventy-seven, cancer-free since 2015, still in the third row. My mother gave a toast, and in the middle of it she turned to Lou. "It wasn't always easy," she said, "but it was worth it." There was no ill will in it anywhere; whatever the divorce had been, none of it was in that room. Lou raised his fist in pride. It

brought me to tears all over again. The woman who carried us out of Mexico and the man who caught us on the other side, honoring each other out loud.

Chris gave a speech. My brother, my keeper, the one who said the thing that night that worked. He stood in front of all hundred of them and talked about the road I'd been on.

"For years, we wondered whether there was any hope for Rob," he said. Then he looked at my bride. "Now we know there is."

The room laughed, then went quiet, understanding it both ways at once, the woman in white beside me and the other thing, the one he'd watched me climb out of by inches.

Rhonda had rented an old fifties car to take us from the ceremony to the reception, and the driver had to be ninety-five, his reaction time about five seconds behind the road. Hope grabbed my hand and we both started laughing, the silent, wide-eyed kind. We'd just promised each other forever and weren't sure we'd make the reception.

When everything else in my life had sunk, Hope floated.

CHAPTER 27 ## What We Built

*“Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things,
endureth all things.” — 1 Corinthians 13:7*

Pensacola and Raleigh, 2017–2026

We’d been dating about a month when Dave Ramsey’s voice filled the car. Neither of us reached to change it. When the segment ended she said: “I have a hundred thousand dollars in student loans.” Not embarrassed, not defensive. Factual. “We could pay it off,” I said. “We?” That word again. “If this goes where I think it’s going, yeah. The two of us.” “That’s my debt,” she said, “from before I met you.” “If we do this, it’s our debt.” She was quiet a long time. Finally: “I want to be free.” “Then we’ll get free,” I said.

Lou never took to the plan. When he heard us talking budgets and cutting back, something in him bristled. “You gotta enjoy your life,” he said. “You can’t cut everything out.” It came out with a little heat, and the heat wasn’t aimed at us — with Lou it rarely was. A man who tipped twenty dollars on principle was never going to love a budget. He heard frugality and understood deprivation.

Who She Is

Hope’s parents divorced when she was twelve, and she carries some abandonment from it, the quiet kind that doesn’t announce itself. It wasn’t one big leaving, either. She once rode to the movies with friends and got left in the backseat, on the hump, forgotten while

everybody else walked in. Small things like that stack in a person. She needs a plan — the trip, the week, the grocery run — and when something moves the pieces she feels it in her body. At first I tried to talk her out of it. Now I help her rebuild the plan instead. Hope was left once. She needs to know what's coming.

Early on she was a little codependent, and I'll be honest, it felt good. I'd spent my whole life trying to feel chosen, trying to be enough for somebody. Here was a person who needed me. Two people with the same wound from opposite ends, hers being left, mine wondering if I was worth keeping, and for a while we filled each other's empty places. We've both grown past the worst of it. But I understand now why we fit so fast.

When we met she was twenty-nine, just finishing her doctorate, and she had never worked a full-time job in her life. Part of it is that she was a late bloomer, acne all through high school, the kind of pretty nobody spotted until later. A Savage Garden song came on the radio once and she said, quiet, "Nobody asked me to dance." Middle school, the slow songs, a girl waiting at the edge of the gym. Everybody who overlooked her did me the favor of my life. And she can laugh about all of it herself. Somebody once asked her whether Alabama was a good place to raise kids. "Yes," she said, "if you want them sheltered."

The first proof of what that had done to her was small. I brought her leftovers one night. Not flowers, not a reservation, just a container of food I'd thought to set aside for her. She looked at it like I'd done something. "You thought of me," she said. I didn't understand why it landed so hard until I learned how rarely anyone had.

She has watched me leave things undone and start things I don't finish, and she has never once held it over me. Being loved without being graded was new to me. I kept waiting for the bill. It never came.

Our first fight wasn't about money or the future. It was crab meat. We were in Orange Beach, at a seafood and bar place, on our way to a Matchbox Twenty concert. Hope wanted me to try it. I wouldn't take a bite. Not one. It turned into a real argument right there at the table, and it ended with me drawing a line. "Hope, I said no, and I'm not going to bring it up again." She let it go. We've never fought about food since.

The hardest stretch we hit came with the move to Raleigh. We were carrying two mortgages, the East Hill house wouldn't sell until this year, 2026, and money became the thing we kept circling back to. Part of that was on me. Early on I'd make a big decision on my own and tell her after it was already done. For a woman who needs to see the pieces before they move, it was never really about the money. It was about being left out of something that was ours. Hope isn't a fighter, and she didn't yell. She went quiet, and the quiet lasted, which was harder than being yelled at. When she finally came to me she wasn't cruel about it. She said the only thing she needed to: no more impulse decisions. I haven't made one on my own since. The big calls are ours, not mine.

When she gets off work, my phone rings, because she doesn't like the walk to her car alone. I stay on the line until she's in and the doors are locked. It is the smallest job I have. It might be my favorite.

When we first met I was dealing with a health issue. It was private then and it stays private now — a man who has put this much of himself on the page gets to keep one thing off it. What matters is what she did. It could have scared her off early, before she'd invested anything, and I gave her the out without saying so. She didn't take it. "It doesn't faze me," she said. "I'll go to every appointment with you, no matter how much it costs." The woman who tightens at an unexpected expense told me up front she'd spend whatever it took on me, before she had a single reason to. The girl whose family came

apart when she was twelve grew into the woman who refuses to leave.

The first three years we laughed all the time, the real kind that takes her all the way over and pulls the whole room in with her. Then the heavy years came, the ones this book is mostly about, and the laughing got rare without either of us deciding it should. It's coming back, a little more each month. We are safe with each other, and because we're safe we are sometimes harder on each other than we should be. That's the cost of letting your guard all the way down with the one person you're sure won't leave. She is that person.

The Hundred Thousand

In a short time we worked like a team. We paid off over a hundred thousand dollars in student loans and built a life with margin in it instead of debt, a home, a little security I'd never had back when I looked successful. We moved to Raleigh. We never had children, and we never planned to. What we built was the two of us, and a life with room in it for other people. These days that includes Hope's mother. Rhonda lives under our roof now, which is not a sentence anyone says lightly, and getting to know her and love her has been one of the quiet gifts of this stretch. She hasn't had the easiest life. What I didn't see coming was watching Hope and her mom grow close, slowly, over years, until Hope started calling Rhonda her best friend. None of the good things happen overnight. Hope is my rock. It isn't always smooth, no honest marriage is, but she's never stopped believing in what we're building. That's my love story. It started with a stubborn message on Match.com to a girl who told me not to write. Best rule I ever broke.

The Pictures Never Tell the Whole Story

If you look at our Paris photos, we look great. What you can't see is the day before, Hope on her knees in a Brussels hotel room, scraping spilled hair fiber out of my bag so I'd feel okay standing in front of that camera. The trips Hope and I took were some of the best times of my life. They were also a long string of small disasters, and the disasters are where we got strong. We didn't find out what we had when the plan worked. We found out when it fell apart and we were both still standing there, figuring it out.

Europe was four countries in two weeks, one carry-on each. In Paris, Hope had planned a real photo shoot, a professional one, the Eiffel Tower behind us, and she told me to pack a suit. Not a blazer. A suit, dress shoes, a tie. I teased her about hauling it across four countries in half of my one bag, but the truth is I loved what it said about her. She doesn't just take a trip. She plans the memory, puts the effort in ahead of time, and hands you something to keep. All I had to do was put on the suit and stand where she told me. I've done harder things for less.

What she did with that suit is the part I keep. In Brussels my Toppik exploded, the hair fiber powder I used every day on the thin spots, cap off, container cracked, black powder worked into every seam of the bag. My hairline was my one real insecurity, and I figured the shoot was finished. I told her I'd wear a hat pulled low and call it a style. She didn't laugh it off and didn't tell me it was just hair, which never helps anybody. "You could wear the Peaky Blinders hat," she said. "It would look great." Then she got down on the floor and scraped it out of the bag anyway, scooping it back into the container bit by bit. "We'll get enough," she said. "Don't worry." She knew that powder was the one thing that could take me from feeling good to wanting to hide, and instead of arguing me out of it, she fixed it.

Ireland was the one I couldn't fully meet her on. We'd planned it long before, but by the time it came Lou's health was sliding and I had just taken time off work to be with him. Galway, the Cliffs of Moher, towns out of a postcard, and my head was back home in Pensacola the whole time. Hope didn't push. She told me nobody cared that I'd taken the time, that I was allowed to be where I was, and she loved me through a trip I wasn't all the way present for. That is its own way of carrying someone, and she did it without ever making me feel like a burden. In Galway I bought her a Claddagh ring, the little heart held in two hands, and gave it to her as the promise I couldn't say out loud that week.

I think about those trips differently now, not as time I should have spent some other way, but as time I'm grateful we took, every messy minute of it. The pictures never tell the whole story. They can't. They only catch the second we were smiling. Everything that earned the smile happened off camera, and most of it was Hope.

CHAPTER 28

Wonderwoman

*“Her children arise up, and call her blessed.” — Proverbs
31:28*

Lantana and Raleigh, 2017–2026

For most of my life my mother was unbreakable. She got two boys out of Mexico on her own nerve, worked nights without complaint, and still found a way to have a hot meal and a made-up home waiting for me at every turn. Wonderwoman.

Her love never stopped when I grew up. I moved more times than I can count, and every time, she made the new place a home. She’d go to T.J. Maxx, fill a cart, and a bare apartment I had just landed in would turn into somewhere that felt like mine. In college she even bought me a Jenny McCarthy poster and hung it on my wall, because making a place mine meant making it feel like me, right down to the parts a mother would rather not picture.

Years later, coming back from a cruise through Mexico, tanned so deep that in the eyes of United States customs I looked very Mexican, I got pulled aside.

“These papers don’t look official,” a customs officer said, examining them from every angle.

The officers questioned me for an hour before they called the police, who interrogated me for another two hours. Then the FBI arrived.

I never denied I was ethnically Mexican or even born in Mexico. Seven hours off the boat, fourteen different officers, and I provided the same answers every time. They were less interested in who I was than in who they saw.

I wasn't nervous. I had nothing to hide. But I was embarrassed, all the way through. If not for the humiliation, I would have let my anger show. Somewhere around hour five, I wondered if I would spend the rest of my life proving on demand that I was who the paper said I was.

When my mother heard how I'd been detained and questioned, she jumped into action. She went to a New Jersey courthouse, got my official birth certificate, and gave it to me. She made sure that nobody could ever again hold her son for seven hours over the way a document looked.

The first crack I ever saw in her was in Central Park.

About six months in, I brought Hope to meet my mom. Gary, my mom's boyfriend, was there too, one of the good people I've known. We had lunch at Tavern on the Green and walked through Central Park. A good day. Then she stepped over a curb and her leg gave out. Not a stumble you laugh off, her body just quit. I helped her up. She brushed it off. But I saw it. The first time I looked at my mother and saw someone fragile.

Sometime in 2022 she came to visit us in Pensacola. One morning in the kitchen her hand started to shake. She looked down at it. "It's been happening more," she said. Later, alone, Hope said it quietly: your mom has Parkinson's. I welled up. I'd known since Central Park. I told Hope, we can't feel sorry for her anymore, clarity, not coldness. What she needed was encouragement: the exercises, the medication, fight for quality of life. Watching both of

them decline at the same time nearly broke me. My mom's body turning against her. My dad getting weaker. The two people who chose me, both fading. I had watched slow disappearing before: dementia took my nana in pieces, the person still in the room while the line kept dropping, and much later, when I earned my Certified Dementia Practitioner credential, I was thinking of her. My mother came up for Christmas. I watched her get out of the car and knew it would be one of the last trips she made up here. She came anyway. That's my mom. Wonderwoman doesn't stop. We talk every day. The woman who used to call after a long shift to ask if I wanted McDonald's still calls, except now I'm the one asking if she's eaten, if she's up, if she's okay. She is all over this book, every story I ran past her to get right. I couldn't have written a word of it without her.

They have a picture for it in the program. The addict moves through life like a tornado. When the wind finally dies down, he looks around and figures everything is fine. Everyone else is still standing in the wreckage, still shaking, and he is the last one to notice. Getting sober quieted my storm years ago. What it didn't do was repair what the storm did to the people who were standing in it, and my mother stood closest. Writing this book is what finally turned me around to look.

So the other day, on one of our daily calls, I told her the truth it had forced up in me. "Mom," I said, "I'm only now seeing how much I put you through. I'm truly sorry." I meant it as a promise to be better. She didn't make me sit in it. She didn't list the nights, or the money she spent, or the strain it put on everything around her. She said, "I'm just glad you're okay now."

There is one more thing I need to say to her in print, because I don't say it enough out loud. It was my mother who first walked me into a church, who made faith the one thing that wasn't up for debate. The first time it stopped being hers and started being mine, I was thirteen, on a mission trip in Nashville. I don't remember a word

of the preaching. I remember the room, some current moving through all of us, and my fear going quiet for the first time I can recall. That faith became the floor I stood on when everything else gave way. Mom, if it weren't for you, I would not be the person I am today. Not the sober one, not the one who can sit in a stranger's last room, not the one who finally learned how to stay. All of it traces back to you. My mother will be taken care of for the rest of her life. Whatever care she needs, we will provide it. She picked us once. She never stopped.

PART SIX

THE LAST CHAPTER

Presence, repeated, until the end. His, then mine.

CHAPTER 29 ## The Detour

*“My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways
my ways.” — Isaiah 55:8*

Pensacola, 2021

The recognition I’d stopped chasing had a way of finding me anyway. After ten years in home health, one of the reps for the company that sells Ozempic started noticing me in offices, asking around about who’d make a good partner. When a position opened she kept calling. “You want to apply?” “No,” I said, “I’m happy where I’m at.” But a friend told me, “Give it a shot.” So I interviewed, and I got the job. It was hard to leave. Ten years. Brenda Jahn, my manager there, had been amazing. But I saw it as a chance to learn. When I started at Novo Nordisk I didn’t know the difference between type 1 and type 2 diabetes. Through the training and the home study I got good at it. Really good.

Diabetes Dave

They called him Diabetes Dave in Panama City. Not behind his back. To his face. He doesn’t even go to the front door. He goes to the back. Dave was my mentor. He took the time.

I needed that more than I let on. For ten years I’d been the top guy in home health, the one people called, and I’d walked into Novo Nordisk a nobody in an industry I didn’t understand, starting over at

the bottom of the learning curve in my forties. Dave never let me feel it alone. He sat with me, walked me through what I didn't know, and made sure I always had somebody in my corner. I'm not sure I'd have made that jump without him.

About a year in, Dave lost his son. He was twenty-one, working at a pizza shop, and he was riding his bike home through the neighborhood when a car struck him. He didn't make it. People came from all over the company for the funeral, just to be there for Dave. I've never seen someone with as much faith. Coming back at all would have been enough. He did more.

About two years in, we had a national sales convention in Las Vegas. Dave and I had a routine when we traveled, breakfast, a little prayer, a mini Bible study, talk. One morning he started talking about his son. He said, sometimes I wonder. I know he was in the church. I know he had a relationship with Christ. But I worried about whether he was saved. And then he said, one day a bird landed. His son's favorite bird. And he knew. It was a sign. His boy was okay. Later that trip Dave and I went to the Bellagio, played a couple of slot machines, then got ice cream. I got cookie dough, and opened up. I told him about the DUIs, about the path I'd traveled. He shared some of his, and I'll keep that between us. We prayed right there, ice cream melting in the cups, slot machines going off in the distance.

I didn't know then what Christmas would take from me two years later, or what would land on my driver's side mirror two weeks after that. But when it came, I would recognize it. Dave had taught me the language.

The In-Between

The hardest part of leaving Novo wasn't the job. It was leaving that relationship with Dave. We're still close. He'll always hold a special place for me.

I told people I was going to take some time off. Be there for my dad. Be there for my mom. Be present the way I'd spent years telling families to be present, while there was still time. That was the plan. It's not what happened. What happened was I retreated into myself. The time I'd set aside became something else, a depression I didn't see coming and couldn't recognize from the inside. I was grieving what was already happening and what was coming, and it kept me from doing the thing I'd left my career to do. I know the name for it now. The grief showed up before the loss did, and it froze me. I wasn't working. I wasn't fully showing up for my parents. I was stuck in a version of myself that couldn't move in any direction. Hospice, when it came, wasn't a pivot. It was a return, to the rooms I'd been thinking about since the home health years, to the weight I'd learned how to carry. It pulled me out of that in-between place and gave me direction again.

THE DRIVES · III

September 2025. Our car pointed north out of Pensacola, eighteen years of living near him somewhere back in the mirrors. He had told me to go — that was always his way, more concerned that we were okay than that we were close. I didn't know it was the last of the old kind of drive, the kind where he was still at the other end of the road. This time, I drove.

CHAPTER 30 ## Five Weeks

“They shall mount up with wings as eagles.” — Isaiah 40:31

November 11, 2025

Five weeks after I started the hospice job, my father started to die. We moved to Raleigh because life was expanding. Hope had been a pharmacist for eight years. Raleigh made sense: jobs, community, a church that felt like ours. Leaving Pensacola meant leaving roots. Hope never wavered. That’s who she is. Not blindly optimistic; she sees clearly and asks hard questions. But under all of it is a bedrock belief that God has a plan for us to be of service. When the hospice opportunity came, it felt like a room I’d been circling for years with the door finally open. No debate. No spreadsheet. This was where I was most needed.

The Rooms

Hospice didn’t arrive all at once. It came the way hard things usually do, a little at a time, like a knock I kept deciding I hadn’t heard.

I recognized the posture the work required. You don’t rush in. You don’t fill silence with hollow reassurance. You sit, you listen, you stay. A lot of families wait to start hospice. They’re not ready. They can’t let go yet.

For years my mind had rehearsed survival: escape, shame, pressure, fear, control. Then recovery handed me a new script and made me practice it daily. Tell the truth. Ask for help. Go to the

meeting. Call the sponsor. Pray. Stay sober today. Be useful to someone else. Years of that, until the script stopped being practice and started being me. And hospice, it turned out, was the same script translated for sacred rooms. Stay present. Tell the truth gently. Don't run from silence. Don't make dying about your own discomfort. Honor the person. Help the family breathe. The rooms felt familiar because I had been rehearsing for them all along.

I met with a family once. I'll call the daughter Mary. Her mother was ninety-five, couldn't get out of bed, couldn't stand more than thirty seconds. The family had misgivings. They always do. So I didn't lead with information. I led with a question. How is seeing her like this affecting you? The room shifted. One by one they started talking, the hospitalizations, the rehab stays, the hope that kept arriving and retreating, the exhaustion they hadn't given themselves permission to name. At some point we prayed. When we were done the family made the decision together. Someone had finally asked them how they were carrying it.

Another room has stayed with me, and I'll keep it vague out of respect. Two men, and it took about a minute to see that whatever was between them was the deepest thing in either of their lives. But when one of them spoke about the other, the word he used was best friend. They were partners, and they had spent a lifetime keeping a careful distance in public, and even here, even at the end, the habit held. The love was real. The showing of it still had to be hidden. I didn't name it. It wasn't mine to name. What I remember most is the sense that the one who could still leave needed to get home, to the one place the two of them had ever been free to love out loud. I have never forgotten that. Part of this work is noticing the love that has had to live in code, and making room for it without making a thing of it.

In one room I was talking with the patient, an easy back-and-forth, and somewhere in it I told him a little of my own story, the

addiction, the years I lost, the long road back. I've learned that when I open that door even a crack, people walk through it. His wife had come in partway through, and when I finished she went quiet, then asked me something that had nothing to do with her husband and everything to do with what she was actually carrying. Her son was thirty-eight, living at home, drinking himself under. He had a little girl of his own, and his mother lay awake wondering whether he could take care of her. Did rehab work, she wanted to know. What could she do. Was there anything she could do. I gave her what I had, the truth as I'd lived it, no dressing it up. You didn't cause it," I told her. "You can't control it. You can't cure it. What you can do is stay, and help him live long enough to get there. But mostly I understood that I'd walked into that room to sit with a dying man and ended up holding his wife's other grief, the living one. Addiction doesn't wait outside the hospice door. It's already in half the rooms, and because I came back from it, families hand me that fear too. I take it.

And there was a pastor I'll call Melvin, surrounded near the end by his wife, his son, his grandson, all of them knowing he could go at any moment, all of them staying.

I wasn't there for the very end. I saw him close to it, and a single thought went through me that I couldn't take back: I never want to see my own dad like that. I had no idea how few weeks were left before that stopped being a fear and became a choice in front of me.

Five Weeks

The decline wasn't dramatic at first, less energy in his voice on the phone, conversations that used to run long wrapping up faster, with less of the texture that made them his. I knew how to read it. I'd just spent five weeks learning to read exactly this. I was walking into strangers' homes explaining what hospice was and wasn't, and the whole time my own father was crossing the same line I'd been

describing to families all week. I didn't tell them my dad was dying too. I didn't need to.

We Said Everything

The relationship between my father and me was not perfect. Nothing in this story has been. But in the years of my sobriety, the real years, the years of staying, we said everything that needed saying. Not in one conversation. Not in a deathbed scene. In the ordinary: Sunday phone calls, the back porch in Pensacola, the moment at my wedding when my mother's toast reached him and his fist went up, the moment at the business conference when Quint said his name in a room full of leaders. I made amends to him. Not with a speech, Lou would have hated a speech. With years of behavior that said: I know what you did, I know what it cost, I'm not going to waste it. He told me. Four words on a phone call. "I'm proud of you." And somewhere in that last stretch we traded our two lines one more time, the ones we'd been trading since a car ride to Ohio half a lifetime ago. Dad, thank you for saving my life. You saved mine. His answer never changed, not even at the end. We were not unfinished. That is not a small thing.

The Right Place

I want you to see him whole first, because the man who was about to start dying had never stopped living.

Lou was a man of places. He could seem simple if you only caught the surface, but he carried a private map of the world inside him — the best restaurants, the best bagels, the streets worth taking, the shop worth passing twenty other shops to reach. New York wasn't an idea to him. It was muscle memory. He kept returning to the places he'd known since childhood, as if tradition were something you kept alive by visiting it. At Clyde's in Lodi he had a

lemonade rule: two scoops, one always lemon, the other your choice. Flexible inside a fixed tradition — there was room for choice, but only after the lemon was settled. He never wanted to be rushed at a meal. A restaurant wasn't a place to consume food; it was a place to be recognized, to settle in, to let the thing unfold. He liked career waiters, professionals who remembered him and knew their craft, and he tipped twenty dollars like a man paying respect to people who knew how to do their job. He wasn't a picky eater; the food itself almost never lost him. What lost him was bad service, and paying for a meal done badly. It offended the same thing in him that the twenty-dollar tips honored.

Yankee games had their own liturgy. Leave the house at five, catch batting practice, soak in the park. A hot dog or chicken fingers, done the same way every time. He watched almost every game of a season — the blowouts, the lost years, the Septembers that meant nothing in the standings. I asked him once why. "I just enjoy the game," he said. I understand it differently now. He wasn't only watching baseball. He was practicing loyalty — staying with a thing because it was his, not because it was winning.

And he never stopped wanting to be useful. He'd retired on paper and kept working anyway, into his eighties, answering phones and untangling computer problems. The pay was almost nothing, and one day he called me like he'd won a sweepstakes because his boss had doubled it. What I remember isn't the money. It's an eighty-year-old man beaming over a good performance review. At eighty, he did a 5K with Hope and me — beanie, glasses, a finisher's medal — finished dead last, and took home the tortoise award, which somehow made the whole thing better. After the 2015 surgery — they took about half of his esophagus and half of his stomach — he ate less, weighed less, took his vitamins, saw his holistic doctor. He won himself years. He spent them wanting things. Strength. Respect.

A good review. Proof he wasn't finished. There is dignity in still wanting, and my father had it to the last.

Vigils

Lou was diagnosed with stomach and esophageal cancer in the spring of 2015. He was seventy-three. He called me on a Tuesday, no preamble. "Got some news," he said. "Surgery. And holistic stuff. No chemo. I'm not doing chemo." I knew better than to argue. "Okay," I said, which meant, I hear you, and I'll show up for whatever comes next. The surgery was brutal. Donna was there every day. I believe it's because of Donna that my father lived another ten years. She was a nurse; she understood his body in ways the rest of us didn't. She loved him completely and he loved her. He told me straight, more than once: Donna was the love of his life. My relationship with Donna was always centered on my dad. She was good to me, always. She's a complex person, with a controlling nature expressed in the sweetest, most Southern way imaginable. I don't mean that as criticism. Who she is was exactly what Lou needed. The season ahead will be hard for her, because her life was organized entirely around his. I worry about her. I pray for her.

Lou came through the surgery. By December the scans were clean. The cancer stayed away for eight years — one scare in 2018, something on his liver, and nothing was ever done about it; it held. He was at my wedding in April 2019. Years that looked, from the inside, like a permanent gift. They weren't.

In January 2024 the cancer came back. Stage 4. Lungs and lymph nodes. Lou was eighty-two. He told Donna. He told Lisa. He told no one else. I noticed it before I knew what I was noticing, his mood a little off, something in the quality of him I couldn't name. Chris was getting married in February, and Lou had decided, quietly and completely, that his son's wedding wasn't going to be about his

diagnosis. So he showed up. He danced. He celebrated. Nisha's father had passed the year before, and the wedding was a big Indian celebration in Fort Lauderdale, joyful and carrying grief as well as love. Lou understood that. He held it inside and let the day be what it was supposed to be. My mother was there too, her Parkinson's flaring hard that month. She'd taken a fall in the days before and came anyway, patched with a Band-Aid that wasn't fooling anybody. At the end of the night she found Lou and said, "Don't go dying on me." And my father — the cancer already back inside him, the secret already sealed — looked at her and said, "You don't go dying on me." She didn't know what he was carrying. He did. He kept the secret until March or April. The cancer's back," he said. "January. I didn't want to say anything because of Chris's wedding. And in July 2025, a year and a half into the fight, he was there when Chris and Nisha's daughter, Priya, was born. He held her.

Lisa and I talked. We knew he had to do something. Chris was the one who got through to him, researched, found a surgeon in Birmingham using connections from a previous job, got him an appointment. The surgeon looked at him and said, stage 4, your age, no surgeon is going to operate on you. We were distraught. Surgery had worked the first time; we thought it was the answer again. Immunotherapy came up, usually not as hard on the body as chemo or radiation, we were told. Lou agreed to try. He was choosing to try. Not for himself. For us.

The Treatment

The immunotherapy started in summer 2024. At first, impossibly, it worked. The tumor in his lung nearly dissolved. The oncologist used the word encouraging. Then the side effects came, rashes all over his body. Lou never complained. His heart rate and blood pressure started going off and he ended up in the hospital. I was there when

they put the pacemaker in. He was upbeat about it, ready to keep fighting. A pacemaker at eighty-three and he came out looking for the next round. He did a second round of immunotherapy, then a third, trying to clear the lymph nodes. The third round was what finally took a toll. He got weak. By mid-2025 the phone calls had changed, and he stopped asking about my work. Not because he didn't care. Because asking took focus that was going to the basic maintenance of existing.

He Wouldn't Say Pain

Lou would not say he was in pain. He came up in a world where pain wasn't something men announced. You swallowed it, walked it off, worked through it, or hid it badly enough that everyone around you had to become a detective. His discomfort came out sideways — restlessness instead of language, a man who couldn't settle in a chair he'd sat in for twenty years.

It was Hope who found the doorway. "Are you in pain?" got a flat no, every time. Then she tried it another way. "Are you uncomfortable in this area?" Yes. That question gave him a way to tell the truth without feeling like he'd surrendered something. Hospice taught me that words matter. Lou taught me that pride matters too. Sometimes care isn't forcing someone to admit what hurts. Sometimes care is learning the doorway a person is willing to walk through.

I respected the toughness. I also saw the loneliness inside it. It kept him going. It also kept us from helping him.

There was a stretch in late 2024, about a year before the end, when I was sure we were losing him. He could barely walk. He was barely coherent, and he was in a lot of pain. I called the family and told everyone they needed to come to town. I didn't think he was going to make it. Joel flew in, and I picked him up at the airport. He

told me he didn't know how to do this, how to be in the room with our father like that, with all of it right there on the surface. Joel wears his humor like armor; he's the funny one. Seeing him without it was something else entirely. "Just grab his hand," I told him, "and tell him you love him." That's all. Two grown men in an airport pickup lane, working out how to go say goodbye to our dad. Lou rallied after that. He gave us most of another year. But that was the first time I rehearsed losing him.

That spring, Hope and I told him we were moving to Raleigh. I could tell he was disappointed. I'd lived close to him in Pensacola for eighteen years, almost nineteen. But he understood, and he told me to go. That was always his way, even at the end, more concerned about whether we were okay than whether we were close. The last time I saw him before the move we went to McGuire's. He looked fine. He said he wasn't worried, said as long as Donna was there he was okay. Part of me looks back and wonders if I should have stayed longer. I couldn't have known that five weeks into my new job he'd take a turn and go downhill fast.

After the move, Hope and I went down for a visit. We went to church that morning and ate with Dad before the drive back up to Raleigh. There was an opening in hospice, at a company I had already given ten years to, and at the table that morning Dad told me what he always told me. "Listen to your boss. Work hard." He had put that in me a long time ago, and he said it again like it was the first time. With him, miracles had started to feel ordinary.

He got pneumonia on December 23. His immune system had nothing left to fight with. Donna had been calling, and I could hear in her voice what she was trying to tell me without saying it. My mother was in Raleigh visiting. She'd made the trip from Lantana, where she'd lived since 2019, with Parkinson's making every mile harder than it used to be. So I did the math the way I'd done it for ten years. He had come back from the surgery. He had come back from

the pacemaker, from three rounds of immunotherapy, from the year we all flew in because I was sure we were losing him. He always came back. We would drive down Friday, I told myself, and I would have a day with my mother first, and he would still be there.

My father died on Christmas Day, 2025. A Thursday.

CHAPTER 31 ## The Days After

*“Jesus wept.” — John 11:35***December 28, 2025**

Something in me shut down before he was gone. I couldn't pick up when my stepmom called. I went somewhere I had gone as a little boy when I was scared, that same quiet, far-off place, the dissociation I had learned before I had a word for it.

Part of it was that my mother was in town. She has Parkinson's now, and getting to me had cost her every ounce of energy she had. Part of it was simpler, and harder to admit. I did not want my last memory of my father to be tubes in his nose. He had been bigger than two cancers and a scare. I couldn't let the man in that bed become the last picture I kept of him.

It was selfish. I'm sorry it was that way. But I can only tell you the truth of it. The week before, I had told my sponsor that I'd said everything to my dad that needed saying. I had. There was no unfinished sentence between us. And it still didn't spare me what came next.

The night before Christmas, they put him on a morphine drip. He was in the hospital, on comfort care — not hospice; it went that fast. I knew what the drip meant — it's my work. Morphine at the end doesn't take anyone. It eases the pain and the hunger for air while the dying does what it was already doing. The drip didn't tell me what was coming. It told me where he already was. Comfort was the

assignment now. Christmas morning, I didn't need anyone to tell me. The texting had stopped, and the silence had a shape. Then the phone rang. Chris, confirming what I already knew. Our father was gone.

I didn't feel guilty at first, and that's the truth. I had been at his bedside every other time — the surgeries, the pacemaker — and I had lived close to him for eighteen years. The guilt came later, and it came from outside: people in the family who love me and who gave me a very hard time about not being there. I understand it. Grief needs somewhere to go. But the conversation with my sponsor still rings true, and I hold it like a railing: I said everything that needed to be said. Being absent from the last hour is not the same as being absent from the life.

There's more to that week than I've told you. It's still too painful to talk about, and I'm not going to pretend otherwise. Maybe someday, further down this road, I'll be able to write it. For now, this is what I can give you, and every word of it is true.

When he was gone, something landed on me that I had never felt before, not over anyone. I had lost people I loved before him. Nothing came close to this. I had been around death for years — I knew the word. I did not know the thing. Now I did. Grief. People think it's a constant, a gray you live under. It isn't. It's an overwhelming sadness that comes and goes through the day, and beneath all of it, all the time, a deep heartache that never fully lifts. What took me a while to understand about mine: underneath, it wasn't guilt. It was simpler and heavier than that. The most amazing man I've ever known wasn't alive anymore, and I wanted him here. That's what I carry.

I went back to work almost immediately. I don't know how to explain that except to say the body keeps doing what it knows how to do.

When the time came, Hope and I made the drive to Pensacola. We talked the whole way about Lou, not the saint version, the real

one. The complicated man. The hard parts and the funny parts and the parts only family knows. By the time we got there I had cried and laughed and gone quiet a dozen times. That's grief too. Hope let me cry, and she cried some herself, partly for Lou, mostly for the pain she knew I was in.

The days in between blurred together. Then it was January 3, 2026, the service, at Harper-Morris Memorial Chapel.

We pulled up to the funeral home, and there was the truck, parked right out front, NJERZ on the Florida plates. Joel had driven it over. A man who moved all the way to the Gulf and still made his truck say Jersey. That's what undid me, not the building, not the door. The plates. I lost it. I couldn't hold the tears back, and I didn't try.

It was an odd feeling, being there, in the place where my father's body was. Now my last memory of him would be here, like this. But I had to see him. I couldn't not. So I went in.

The funeral home was small. A lobby at the entrance, a family waiting area off to the left, and to the right a little room with pews and a writing station, where even now people were being asked to sign their names. I sat with Chris and Nisha, with Joel and Jon and their families, with Hope. And somewhere in that hour it landed on me that we were not all grieving the same man. The room was full of different Lous. Some had known him as an older father figure, some as a younger one. Some as a friend. Some as a coworker. Some as a complicated old wound. Some only as the man he became at the end, softened and slowed. Jon once told me his Lou had felt more like a friend than a father — they were closer in age, they went out together, they traded texts about the Yankee games. Mine was the rescuer. Some sons need instruction. Some need warmth. Some need a hand on the shoulder because they're already carrying more than they can name. Some need to be pulled out of an apartment in West Palm Beach. Lou seemed to know which of us needed which, and he showed up accordingly. I lost the man who chose me, rescued me,

and left me with a promise. Everyone else in those pews lost somebody else.

Pastor Levi Gardner officiated. He had been Dad's pastor for years, and he opened by praying that Lou, raised with Christ, would know the strength of His presence and rejoice in His glory. Then he read the 23rd Psalm, the whole thing. The Lord is my shepherd. I had heard those words at a lot of bedsides over the years. I had never once heard them land on me the way they did that day.

Two of my brothers stood up to speak, Chris and Joel. I did not. I wanted to honor my father, but I couldn't have gotten through two sentences without collapsing. So Chris did what brothers do when one of them can't carry the thing alone. He carried it for both of us. He gave the eulogy, and it was spot on, the right words, the right respect, no more and no less. He talked about a father who was steady and present, a man who never needed to say out loud that he was proud of you. You just knew.

Chris told the one about Fargo. Years back, Dad got in the car and drove alone from New Jersey to Fargo, North Dakota, to watch Chris finish a national wrestling tournament. If it mattered to one of his kids, he showed up, no matter how far. And Chris shared the phrase the two of them had kept between them for years. After the big moments they would say it quietly to each other. Hey Dad, we made it. Five words that held all the early mornings and long drives, all the nights it would have been easier to quit. Sitting there, I thought about how many of us had our own version of that with him, and how we were all going to have to learn to say it now without him there to answer.

Then Joel spoke, and he painted the other side of the man, the one whose name opened rooms. Dad knew everyone, and he made everyone feel known: the cooks, the maître d's, the bartenders, the doorman at the club. Joel said you could still walk into a place downtown, say the name, and watch a stranger's face light up.

Louie's your dad? Going somewhere with Dad was never only about the place. He brought you into his world and made you feel the magic of it.

Joel talked about the work, too, the part of Lou we only half understood as kids. He ran a landscaping business, fifty lawns a week, while working an IT night shift from eleven at night to seven in the morning. He would come home, sleep an hour and a half, meet his crew on the road, work the lawns, come back for a few hours, then head into the city again for the night. Our standing job as kids: make sure Dad woke up in time for his eleven o'clock shift. Every single night. He never stopped, and he never complained. He chose all of it, for us.

And when it came time to pass the landscaping business down, he didn't. He sold it. Joel quoted him. I don't want you to work hard like I did. I don't want you to work physically like I did. You're going to college. He sent every one of his kids to college and made it feel like the only road there was. He would drive thirty-five minutes for the right ice cream and into Little Italy for the right cannoli, because the best of a thing was always worth the drive. Always be the best-dressed person in the room, he told us. It stuck.

Chris credited Donna, too, called her the reason Dad got his strength and his joy back in the last stretch of his life. It was true. She had given him good years, and she had been there for every one of the hard ones. I was grateful for what she had been to him.

And Chris said one more thing that stayed with me. He was the one who had talked Dad into the immunotherapy, and he said that knowing everything — the rashes, the pacemaker, the third round that finally took its toll — he would choose it again, because it bought the time in which Dad held his granddaughter. That sentence did something to me.

Chris had carried Dad's pride his whole life — the golden child, in the best sense of it, the son who stayed close and never forgot

where he came from. I had carried something else. Chris carried his pride. I carried his rescue. Dad knew the difference, and he loved us each in the way we needed. I think he saw me as a little more fragile — not weaker, exactly, but breakable in places I didn't always know how to name. He was right.

Then I stood at the casket. I looked down at my father, and it wasn't him anymore. The body was there, but he wasn't. I knew his soul had already gone on ahead. I had watched that line get crossed in other people's rooms more times than I can count, and I knew it the moment I saw it. It still didn't stop the feeling. I stood there and loved him, for everything he was, and everything he wasn't.

The patriarch was gone, and nothing seemed to flow the same. Lou had been the one everything quietly organized itself around, the center a family doesn't notice until it's gone and the whole thing loosens. Nobody said it out loud. We all felt it.

We drove home the way we had come, still talking about him — the truck that said Jersey in a Florida parking lot, all of it. The grief rode with us. It rides with me still. I've stopped wishing it away. It's the weight of having been loved like that, and I'd rather carry it than have nothing to carry.

The Conversation I Never Had

There are things I never asked my father while he was alive.

I knew he had fallen out with his brother, a brother close to him in age. I knew some of the background. What I never asked was whether he missed him. I never asked enough about his own father, either — the man who sold produce and died around fifty. I wanted to know what that loss did to him, whether it shaped the way he held on or pulled back, whether becoming my father had anything to do with the father he lost too soon. And near the end I wanted to ask what he wanted done with everything after he was gone. I never did.

Lou drew hard boundaries around certain subjects, and if there's not an opening, you can't really push. Hospice taught me that. So did being his son.

I sit with families for a living and hand them the questions I never handed him. Ask now, I tell them. This is the right day. I believe every word of it, and I also know what it is to stand outside a door a man has decided to keep shut, and to love him enough to leave it that way. Both things are true. I spent my life being saved by my father. At the end, I had to learn that loving him didn't mean saving him back.

Who Stays. Who Goes.

It wasn't a fight. No big moment, no explosion. Just a quiet realization that I couldn't be around certain people anymore. They didn't do anything terrible. They just didn't know how to sit in it, and I didn't have the energy to explain it.

Grief changed my tolerance. Comments that used to roll past me landed wrong now. I hadn't gotten softer. I'd gotten honest. After Lou died there were conversations I'd leave early, rooms I'd step out of, people I'd stop calling back. Not out of anger. Out of survival.

I sat in my car one afternoon thinking, am I becoming someone else? The answer came back quiet. No. You're becoming someone who can't pretend anymore.

In January we went through his things. His gray suit was hanging on the right side of the closet, between two work shirts. Always be the best-dressed person in the room. I pulled it off the rack and held it up, and I couldn't put it back. I took it home in a garment bag with no plan. It hangs in my closet now, next to mine. It isn't my size and it isn't my style and I will never wear it. But some mornings I open the closet door and it's there, and I know what it is, and I know who wore it, and I leave it alone. I tell families sometimes, when they're

clearing out a closet of their own: keep one thing. You'll know which one. It will tell you.

CHAPTER 32 ## The First Honest Mile

“Blessed are they that mourn: for they shall be comforted.”
— Matthew 5:4

Raleigh, 2026

I took one day off after my father died, then put on a tie and went back. He’d worn one for forty years, and he’d have gone back the next day, so I did too. Not to avoid the grief. Because the next thing he’d have done was show up, and so would I. The tie was the same idea.

The tie made it look like I was fine. I wasn’t.

I never wanted a drink. That’s the truth, and it surprised me. What I wanted was to be gone. I let the routines slip. The gym went first. I let the phone ring, sat in rooms without being in them. I’d get in the car and drive with no destination, park somewhere and cry, then drive some more. Sometimes I’d end up asleep on a couch in the lobby of a hotel where I wasn’t a guest. Numb. When I wasn’t driving the car I was working on it, hours at a time, jobs it didn’t need. What I needed, I kept telling myself, was to be alone. I’d write some and sleep. Some of the pages in this book come from those weeks, and I look back at them now and I’m not sure how I managed any of it. These chapters were the hardest for me to write. I was there, and it was so painful that writing it meant living it twice. The hospice job was still new, I was still learning it, and I kept going to it anyway through all of this. I couldn’t tell you how. Hope never knew

where I was. When I came home she'd ask, and the honest answer was nowhere. Disappearing, on a woman whose oldest wound is being left.

She watched it get worse before I did. I got into a couple of fender benders, my head somewhere else at stop signs and in parking lots. Then I hit a guardrail. Twenty-two thousand dollars of damage. Hope and her mom were worried, and said so. I got defensive. I didn't want to look weak. They were right, which was the part I couldn't stand. It was like cutting weight again. You're starving, you won't eat, and nobody at the table understands why, because from the inside it makes perfect sense. Hope started watching me the way you watch someone after a fall, and finally asked, seriously, whether I might have a concussion. That's what grief looked like on me. Enough like a head injury that the person who knows me best couldn't tell the difference. Then she said the thing that cut through. "I have you here, but I feel like you don't care. Like you're not here." She wasn't wrong. The body was in the house. The rest of me was out on those roads somewhere.

And I was mean. That scared me more than a craving would have. I lashed out at the people carrying the same loss I was, short and sharp over nothing, hearing myself do it and doing it anyway. Part of it was this book. I was writing my way through the loss, and in that fog it felt like the family didn't believe in what I was doing, didn't want the story told, and I used that as a reason to push them further away. Looking back, I don't think it was fair to them. Grief reads indifference into everything. At the time it felt like proof.

Seventeen years sober, and I had hit a rock bottom again, an emotional one this time. The disease doesn't need a bottle to run the old plays: isolation, anger, the closed door. The difference was that this time I had to feel it all the way through. And this time I knew what to do with a bottom. I went back to meetings, more of them than I'd been to in years. I got a therapist. The morning calls with

Mager got longer. I said out loud, in the rooms and on the phone, that I was not okay. I went back to the people I'd been sharp with and said sorry, plainly. Seventeen years in, I was back on the first honest mile.

CHAPTER 33 ## What Grief Taught the Job

“Weeping may endure for a night, but joy cometh in the morning.” — Psalm 30:5

Raleigh, 2026

Before I lost him, I was good at this job, but there was a gap in it, one I can only admit now. I would sit with a family and say the right things, nod at the right moments, and look like a man who understood exactly what they were feeling. Inside, I didn't. I hadn't lost the one I loved most yet. I was fluent in the words and a step removed from the weight. Losing my dad closed that gap. Now when I walk into a room where someone is losing the person they love most, I'm not performing understanding. I have it. I know the specific shape of it. It made me more compassionate, and it made me better at the work, which is a hard thing to be grateful for, and I am grateful for it anyway.

Families would say, I'm terrified I won't be there when it happens. What I offered was what I knew to be true: presence is cumulative. You build it in the ordinary. Lou gave me everything I needed for the rooms I walk into now, and in those rooms, with the silences that need holding rather than filling, I carry him.

I could tell you a hundred versions of the same room. The details change. The room doesn't. A husband answering every question directed at his wife, because he has been her voice since the diagnosis, going quiet only when I ask what he'll do with his

mornings. A daughter who flew in from three time zones away and won't sit down, because sitting down feels like agreeing to it. A Bible on the nightstand with a rubber band around it, fat with decades of funeral programs pressed inside. And at some point, out in the hallway, the question underneath every other question: how long? What they're really asking is how long they have to say the thing they've been saving. I used to point them to the nurses and the ranges. Now I answer the real question. Don't wait. Then I go back into the room with them, and we stay.

The mechanics of it are simple. The first thing I do in any room is pull a chair up close, because distance reads as hurry and I am never in a hurry there. I remember an older woman with one framed photograph beside her bed, her daughter, a whole life narrowed down to the one face she wanted near her. I remember a man who told me his single regret, and there was nothing material in it. Nobody at the end talks about the things they bought. He wished he had traveled outside the country, just once. That was the whole confession. A woman with dementia once asked me to go to prom with her. People ask how I can stand this work. Some days the work asks you to prom. And once, after my father died, I sat with a man who reminded me so much of Lou that when he passed I had to step out of the room and stand there awhile before I could be useful to anybody. People ask what those rooms smell like, too, expecting something terrible. They smell clean. Hospital clean. That scrubbed-blank smell is to me now what rubber and sweat were to the wrestling room.

Put one of those rooms together and it goes like this. A living room with a hospital bed where the dining table used to be. The husband's chair has been turned to face the bed. Three grown kids: one on the couch, one standing in the kitchen doorway, one who flew in last night and hasn't taken her coat off. The television is on with the sound down. Nobody has eaten. I introduce myself, and nobody

really hears the name, because to them I'm not a name. I'm the word hospice, standing in their mother's living room in a tie.

The one in the doorway says it before I can sit down. We're not ready to give up on her.

I don't argue. Arguing with that sentence is how you lose the room, and I'm not there to win. I sit down where the husband can see me and ask the only question I ever open with. Tell me about her. Not the diagnosis. Her.

The room changes. The husband starts talking, and the daughter in the coat finally sits down. Somebody laughs at a thing their mother said forty years ago, and somebody else cries at the same sentence. For twenty minutes the woman in the bed is not a diagnosis. She is the reason everyone in that room exists. And somewhere in those twenty minutes, hospice stops meaning giving up and starts meaning the way her people intend to love her through what's coming.

They don't sign anything that day. Sometimes they don't. But when I stand to go, the husband walks me to the door, which costs him something with his knees, and shakes my hand at the threshold. That's how I know. Not ready isn't a no. It's a doorway, and somebody has to be willing to stand in it first.

And some rooms stay with me whole. There was a couple I'll call Ed and Eva. Ed sold medical equipment. Eva was a respiratory therapist. Between the two of them, healthcare was not a foreign language. They knew the words, the systems, what illness looked like from the professional side. And Ed was twelve years sober, a man who had already done the hardest thing most people can imagine, one day at a time, for over a decade. Recovery had taught him how to live. It had not taught him how to let go. I sat with them near the end. He understood medicine, but medicine did not tell him how to say goodbye. She had spent her working life at other people's bedsides, and it did not make her less human in her own. Ed loved

Eva. That was never in question. Love just needed help becoming a plan: who speaks when she cannot, what comfort means now, what matters most today. Ed and Eva taught me that knowing medicine is not the same as having peace. The room did not feel good at the end. It wasn't supposed to. But Ed stayed in it, and the two of them got through it together. I watched them do it.

My father always made a big deal of my sobriety anniversary. Every January 9. My first year, he came to Gulf Breeze Hospital to hear me speak, sat in that room and listened to his son talk about staying sober for one year. He told me once, quietly, that whenever he mentioned my name to someone who knew me, they'd say the same thing: "He's the best." That's what he built. Lou spent eighty-four years showing up without needing to know exactly where he was going. I'm trying to do the same.

CHAPTER 34 ## The Table

“Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies.” — Psalm 23:5

Raleigh, January 2026

A few days after we buried my father, grief caught me somewhere I didn't expect it. You never know when it's going to hit, or who's going to be standing there when it does.

That morning I walked into one of the assisted-living communities I call on for a routine visit. Linda was at the round table near the nurses' station. She'd been a nurse a long time. You could see it in how she carried herself. Compassionate, but not someone who let everybody in. A steadiness I recognized. We started talking. She was from the Buffalo area, upstate New York. We joked. It felt easy in a way things hadn't in days.

Then I told her we had buried my dad on Saturday. Her face changed. You could tell she felt it. She just sat there with me. And I let myself go. I wouldn't call it a breakdown, but I cried at that table, that raw, in front of someone I barely knew, and I don't know whether you're supposed to cry in front of a nurse you just met at a facility you're calling on for work. But in that moment I felt something I can only call spiritual, a sense that God had put this person in my path. Not for referrals or business. For this.

It was no longer about work. Two people at a round table, one of them grieving and the other choosing to stay in the room for it. We

hugged. I gave her a kiss on the cheek. From that day on I've looked forward to the days I get to see Linda. For the person, not the place. The other staff joke about it, oh, you always come in and kiss Linda on the cheek. They don't know the background, don't know what was shared at that table the Wednesday after we buried my father. That's fine. Not every connection needs an audience. As a rep, I'm the one who's supposed to bring the chocolate and the goodies. When I go see Linda, I'm the one who feels taken care of. She gives me cookies. She checks in. The relationship runs backwards from the job description. Linda gave me a moment, three workdays after the funeral, at a round table, to stop holding it together. I'll carry that.

Lisa's Table

My father was the gravity that held the family together. When he died, that gravity went with him, and I waited for everything to fly apart. We haven't. The reason is my sister Lisa, and a table she has been setting for as long as I can remember.

A stranger had set a place for me at one table. There was another, older one waiting back home. Lisa has Thanksgiving at her house every year. Every year. She sets the table, cooks the meal, opens the door, the way my nana did it, same recipes, same dishes. There's a stubbornness required to keep a tradition alive when the person who started it is gone.

Hope and I can't make it every year. We come from two divorced families, and splitting the holidays is brutal. But the table is always there. That's Lisa.

That table has seen every version of me. For years, in active addiction, I'd show up to Thanksgiving and end up passed out on her couch, dead to the world, sprawled across the whole thing so nobody else could lie down. It turned into a running joke that outlived the using, get to the couch before Rob does. I can laugh at it now

because of how she handled it then. Lisa never shamed me for it. She set a plate for the worst version of me and loved me anyway, no lecture, just a place at the table and a couch I'd hog. She always told me I had a place to come to, no matter what. In those years there weren't many people left in my corner. She was one of them. She stayed proud to call me her brother long before I could see why. I've been back plenty of sober years since, no passing out, but the joke stuck, the way the good ones do.

And every year there was the Turkey Bowl, Auburn against Alabama, her house split right down the middle, a room full of people who loved each other hollering at the same screen for opposite reasons. That was the table too.

It wasn't only Lisa's table. In our family, nobody said love out loud. They cooked it. My mother outside the weigh-ins with Wendy's chicken sandwiches the second I made weight. Nancey in Boca Raton, keeping whipped cream in the house because banana cream pie was my favorite, making me chicken parm for no occasion at all, feeding a nephew who'd shown up at her door with nowhere better to go and not asking him anything a pie couldn't answer. I have eaten my way back to belonging at more tables than I can count, and not one of them ever handed me a bill.

The first Thanksgiving without him hasn't come yet. When it does, I know whose house it will be at, and I know the table will be set.

I think about a night long ago when she cooked meatloaf for two boys who didn't make it easy. She's still standing at the counter. Still opening the door. The last time I was there for Thanksgiving, my father was still alive. I stood in her kitchen a minute before we sat down. I didn't say anything. I just watched, and thought about how the people who hold families together don't usually get thanked for it. They just keep doing it. Year after year. We sat down. Someone

said grace. The food was passed. And for a few hours everything had a center. Lisa made sure of that.

The Floor

Almost every morning for fifteen years, my phone has rung early and it's Mager, or I've called him first, and we pray. A few plain sentences to start the day pointed the right way. Nothing eloquent. Two sober men on a phone line, saying thank you, asking for help, hanging up, going to work. People ask me where God was in all of it, and the honest answer is that He was never the one who left. I was. I still can't explain God on paper, and I've stopped trying. What I can tell you is that every time I hit the bottom of myself, something I had not put there was holding the floor. Today my faith doesn't look like certainty. It looks like that morning call. A red bird on a mirror. Walking into a dying stranger's room with nothing useful in my hands and trusting that presence is its own kind of prayer. I stopped needing the theology airtight. I just needed to stay in the room, and to let myself be shown up for. That, as much as anything, is what got me here.

EPILOGUE: THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

*“You will surely meet some of us as you trudge the Road of
Happy Destiny.” — Bill Wilson, Alcoholics Anonymous*

A cardinal lands on the driver's side mirror of my car.

Close. So close I can see individual feathers. It looks at me through the glass like it arrived with a purpose and is content to wait. It doesn't move. Bright red against the gray.

Let me tell you how I got to this parking lot.

January 9, 2026. Seventeen years sober to the day, and fifteen days after my father died. I'm in my car in the parking lot of a skilled nursing facility in Raleigh, coffee in my hand, just out of a visit with a family still deciding whether to start hospice for their mother. I'd sat with them, answered their questions, stayed until the staying was done. A gray January morning, the coffee going cold, the space between one call and the next.

And then it lands, the cardinal, on the mirror, close enough to touch through the glass.

Seventeen years from West Palm Beach, from the apartment with the blinds drawn and the extension cord running to the hallway, from

the morning I opened the door and found Lou standing there. Seventeen, the age I was when I won the county championship. He'd been in the third row that day. He was always in the third row.

Dad, I say out loud. Alone in the car. Just his name. And then the words he and I mostly lived instead of spoke. I love you. Not because it went unsaid between us — it didn't. Before the end he'd looked at me and told me, Rob, don't worry about me. We're good. When my father said we're good, that was the whole of it: I love you, and I have closure with you. He never needed the sentence. But you don't run out of wanting to say it to a man you can't call anymore. I love you. The cardinal doesn't move. Dad, I love you. I know you're watching out for me.

It sits there. Turns its head slightly. Still looking. I don't know how long we stay like that. The parking lot goes away. Just me and the cardinal. Just me and Lou. Tears running down my face, not sobbing, the kind that comes from grief and relief colliding. Dad is gone. Dad is here.

I pull out my phone, slow and careful. I think I'm recording video. I press the button. The cardinal sits. Two minutes, maybe less, maybe more. Finally I say, Dad, I have to go. And it flies, not startled, not sudden. Lifts off the mirror to a nearby tree, sits a moment, then is gone.

I stand in the parking lot, phone in my hand, tears on my face, and feel peace. Not the absence of grief. Grief is still there, always will be. But peace underneath it. I look at my phone. The camera had been in photo mode. One picture. The cardinal on the mirror. I send it to Hope. To Chris. To Jon, Lisa, Joel. To Donna. The text: Dad came to see me. I told him I loved him.

The cardinal wasn't a miracle. What I believe is simpler. The message had been delivered my whole life, in wrestling rooms and church basements and holding cells and U-Hauls, in boundaries that felt harsh and second chances I hadn't earned and ordinary Tuesday

afternoons nobody wrote down. The cardinal was a reminder that the message is still being sent. That Lou, in whatever form love takes when the person carrying it is gone, is still here, in the work I do in his name without ever saying his name, in the steadiness I bring to someone else's hardest day that was built by his hands.

The cardinal flew off into the gray. It has never landed on my car again. The promise remains. It was never in the bird. It was in what Lou built in me, across forty years of chosen love and stubborn presence. Now it's my turn. Keep showing up. Keep choosing love.

FOR THOSE WALKING THIS ROAD

The story ends with the cardinal. What follows are extended reflections for the road still ahead — for anyone loving an addict, anyone sitting with someone near the end, and anyone learning how to stay. Take what serves you. Leave the rest.

If you're the one in the fight and nobody is coming for you: the rooms are full of men like Lou. Mine found me there. Walk in and let yours find you.

If you're reading this in recovery, from addiction, from loss, from a version of yourself that no longer serves the life you're trying to build, the broken parts of your story don't disqualify you from purpose. They prepare you for it. If you're grieving someone you lost: if the important things were said before the end required them, you were present. And if you're sitting with an aging parent right now, putting off the hard conversation, waiting for a better time: there's no better time. Say the great things while they can still hear you. On a Tuesday. At dinner. On a phone call that feels ordinary. Presence is built across years.

A NOTE TO THE ONE WHO LOVES AN ADDICT

If you picked up this book because you love someone who is using, or you lost someone who did, I want to say something to you now that the story is done.

It isn't your fault.

There's an old line they teach in the rooms where families go, and only from the other side of it did I see how true it is. You didn't cause it. You can't control it. You can't cure it. Three sentences, every one of them a mercy, because all three say the same thing: this was never yours to fix.

I know you've tried. I know you've lain awake turning someone else's life over and over, looking for the thing you missed. I was the person on the other end of those nights. My mother wired me money she told herself was for rent. My father drove a truck across the state to haul me home. None of it made me stop. Not because they failed. Because it wasn't theirs to win. But hear the other half, because it's just as true: none of it was wasted either. Every one of those rescues bought time, and time was the only thing that could still help me. You cannot make them stop. You can help them live until they do.

I have been on both sides of this. I did not understand addiction as a disease at first. I understood it as a disappearance. One day the person you love is still there, sitting across from you, using the same voice, wearing the same face, and somehow already slipping away. You keep reaching for the version of them you remember. You keep thinking love should be enough. Then life teaches you, slowly and brutally, that love is not a cure. It won't make them stop. What it does is keep you from leaving.

Years later I would learn that this is also the whole of hospice. You cannot cure the thing in the room. You can only refuse to leave it.

What you can do is stay. Not fix, not control, not cure. Stay. Set the boundary that keeps you whole, leave the door open a crack, and be there in the ways that don't cost you your own life. If you are not safe, the boundary is distance — my mother saved two boys by leaving.

So now you know how I know. One promise was all I had to offer — to tell you the truth the whole way through — and I've kept it as well as I know how. There's one more page, and it belongs to the rooms.

THE ROOMS

For Dale Perkins, and for Cardascia

When I moved out of my father's house I needed somewhere to live where I could still save. Dale Perkins rented me a room for five hundred a month, utilities included. That was the whole arrangement, and it explains nothing about what came after.

Dale is a licensed clinical therapist and an alcoholic, and he is the least judgmental man I have ever met. He was built to do that job. Nothing I brought him made him flinch. I lived in that house about three years, until the Mirador. We fished. We went to meetings. We watched *The Walking Dead* like it was appointment television.

Back in 2011 he had a cough that wouldn't quit. They told him it was allergies.

I got the call last week. Dale is on hospice with mesothelioma, and they don't think he has a month. It knocked me down, and not because of what he did for me. Because of who he is.

I called him. I cried, and I told him I loved him, and he said it back. That's the power of the program.

There's another seat in those rooms. Cardascia and I had been friends since we were seventeen years old. He lost his fight with

addiction last year. He never quit trying, and that's the part I won't let anyone forget. The disease tells you a man who goes back out is a failure. The rooms know better. He kept walking back in, every time, wanting to stop. That's not weakness. That's a fighter losing to something that kills fighters.

I'm seventeen years sober and I'm not one bit safer than he was. None of us are. The only difference between his seat and mine is one day at a time.

One chair is empty and one won't be for long, and the only thing any of us can do about either is what the two of them did: show up. Go to a meeting this week, even if you're good. Especially if you're not. Call somebody. If today's got you scared, say it out loud to one of us. That's what the rooms are for.

Rest easy, Cardascia. We'll keep the seat warm and the coffee bad.

LOU'S WAY

Not things he said. Things he did, distilled. If you asked me what Lou knew, this is it.

He showed up before he explained.

He helped without keeping score.

He believed love was proven in repetition.

He never confused disappointment with abandonment.

He respected people who knew how to do their job.

He could enjoy the game even when the season was lost.

He still wanted to be useful, all the way to the end.

He found the doorway you were willing to walk through.

He stayed.

AFTERWORD

There is a kind of wisdom that can only be earned by living through what most people spend their lives trying to avoid. Rob Brizzi has that kind of wisdom, and this book is the evidence of it.

I have known Rob for thirty-five years, and a friendship like that gives you a long view of a man's life. Over those years we bonded over faith, character, and a shared belief in showing up and doing right by people. I knew him long before this book, long before the wisdom in these pages had taken shape, long enough to remember the younger version of him, full of energy and loyalty, the guy who hauled a buddy's Jeep doors around Long Beach Island in ninety-five-degree heat, no shade, just because somebody needed help moving. That was Rob being Rob. He has a servant's heart, and he has had it from the beginning. What I did not know back then was everything going on underneath: the battles he was fighting, the identity he was trying to find, the long road that would bring him to the writing of this book.

Rob was a serious competitor. As a wrestler in high school and college he learned something most people never do, that at the highest levels the physical is only the beginning, and the real contest

is internal. He learned that hard work separates the people who merely want something from the people willing to pay the price for it. Formation like that does not leave a man. It shapes the way he meets every challenge that comes after.

And the challenges kept coming. Rob spent years in business, where his success came from his authenticity and his ability to become an expert in whatever he was doing. He learned to listen for what people need beneath what they say they want. Those skills are foundational to this book.

The credential that mattered most is the one that cost him the most to earn. Rob walked through the valley himself. He battled addiction. He knows what it is to be lost, to reach for something that promises relief and gives you nothing back, to hit the bottom that forces a man to look honestly at who he is. He came through that fire transformed. He stopped trying to build his worth on performance, and what he found on the other side was steadier, a deeper sense of who he was and what mattered.

When I reconnected with Rob, it was as if no time had passed. Within minutes our conversation left both of us in tears. As I heard him talk about his father, I understood that this man has an irreplaceable calling. For years Rob has been of service to those in recovery, and he has continued that service through his work in hospice. He sits with families in what he calls the last chapter. He has been there for people in their most vulnerable moments, guiding families through conversations most of us spend a lifetime avoiding, and he does it with the full weight of his own experience as a son who was himself guided through the darkness by the steady, unconditional presence of a father who was all in.

Lou was a father like that. He hit a hundred fly balls at Finch Park in Ramsey, drove Rob and his brother Chris to wrestling practice three nights a week, and leaned in at every turn because he wanted his boys to be the best version of themselves in every part of

life. That love left a mark on Rob, and he carries it forward now, offering families the same presence his father once gave him.

This book was written to honor that legacy. It connects Rob's father's story to the larger story of how we live, how we love, and how we face the end of life with honesty and grace. It takes on the conversations most people find too painful to begin, and it does so with the earned authority of a man who has had those conversations hundreds of times, with real families, at the hardest moments of a human life.

You can trust what you have just read. Every page of this book sounds like the man I know. Rob does not have a long list of titles after his name, and he has never needed one. He has done the harder thing. He has lived it. He has wrestled, literally and figuratively, with the hardest questions of identity, suffering, and meaning. He has served in the places most people are afraid to go, and he has come out of them with something worth saying.

So here is the invitation Rob extends to you in these pages. What would it look like if your life were not just for yourself? What would it look like to give your life to the people around you, especially in their hardest moments? This is not a call to perfection. It is a call to show up for the people who are yours to love, with everything you have. Rob is the first to tell you he is a work in progress, moving closer every day to the man he wants to be.

This book will help you do exactly that. I am grateful it exists, and I am grateful you are holding it.

Sincerely,

Dave Meyer, former Virginia Tech captain and NFL quarterback

AUTHOR'S NOTE

For most of my life I wore a mask. Moving as much as I did as a kid — Mexico to New Jersey, town to town, later across the country — taught me one trick I used everywhere: read the room, become what it wanted, and hope that version got to stay. I got good at it. I performed a life that looked like success and kept the real inventory hidden. Even sober, even happy, I managed a careful image, online and off, and I called it protection.

Writing this book took the mask off. Putting these years on the page, the parts I was proud of and the parts I'd spent decades hiding, I found there was nothing left to protect. The fear I'd built my whole life around — that if people saw the real thing, they'd turn away — was the lie. What replaced it is quieter than relief. It's peace. For the first time, I'm not performing Rob Brizzi. I'm just him. That is what writing this cost me, and what it gave back.

This is a true story, told from memory. Dialogue has been reconstructed as faithfully as memory allows; it keeps the substance of what was said, if not always the exact words. Some names and identifying details have been changed to protect privacy, above all those of the patients and families I served in home health and

hospice, whose hardest days deserve protection, not exposure. Where the sober men and women of the rooms appear by their real names, it is with their permission; others have been renamed. A few of the rooms I describe from my work are composites of many rooms, for the same reason. Nothing in these pages was invented to sharpen the story. My mother, who is all over this book, checked more of these memories than anyone. Whatever I still got wrong is mine.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Hope. You tilted your head, said “We?” and never stopped meaning it. You read every page of this book and told me you were proud of me. That’s the only review I’ll ever need.

My mother, who carried two boys out of Mexico City and then checked more of these memories than anyone. This book is half hers.

Chris. My brother, my keeper. You know what you said to me that night. It worked.

Jon, Lisa, and Joel — we shared him. I know what we lost.

The men God put in front of me: Andy, Bob, Mager, Matt, and Quint. You walked into the room. So did I.

Dave Meyer, for thirty-five years of friendship and for the words that close this book.

Brenda Jahn, one of the best managers I ever worked for. She believed in me and pushed me, and it prepared me for everything that came after.

Dr. Huet, and every nurse, aide, chaplain, and social worker I get to stand beside in the last chapter. You taught me what showing up looks like when it’s a profession.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Scott, my editor, who made these pages better and let them stay mine.

Grace Nobrega, for the cover design.

The rooms, and the people in them, who keep teaching me that the door only had to open once.

And Dad. I kept the promise.

A READER'S GUIDE

Questions for book clubs, recovery groups, and anyone reading with someone else.

1.

Rob calls Lou “the man who didn’t have to.” Where in your own life have you seen chosen love outlast obligated love — and what made it hold?

2.

The book gives us two fathers, and its verdict is: “One father kept calling. The other one kept coming.” How did your feelings about Horacio shift as you read, and which moment moved them most?

3.

When eight-year-old Claudio becomes Robert, it feels like “erasing me.” Years later, Rob deliberately calls his birth father Horacio — not Papa, not Dad. What is the book saying about names, and who gets to give them?

4.

On the mat, when Rob’s body wanted to quit, he learned to tell it no. Where does that lesson save him later — and where does the same drive nearly destroy him?

5.

Lou almost never explains himself: he drives to Cooperstown, buys the Walkman, sleeps on the floor of a wrecked apartment, sets out a sesame bagel. Which of his silent gestures stayed with you, and why do you think the book gives him so few speeches?

6.

“The rescue didn’t get me sober. It kept me alive.” What is the difference, in this book, between rescuing someone and saving them — and who else lives inside that difference?

7.

Rob’s mother wired money she told herself was for rent. “The lie I lived was letting her believe her money was keeping her son fed.” Where is the line between loving an addict and enabling one? Did the book change where you’d draw it?

8.

After seventeen years sober, grief drove Rob into an emotional rock bottom, the first one he ever had to feel all the way through. How is the sober breakdown after Lou’s death different from his using-era bottoms? How is it the same?

9.

Hope’s oldest wound is being left; Rob’s is wondering whether he was worth keeping. How do those two wounds fit together in their marriage — and when does the fit help, and when does it hurt?

10.

In the hospice room, “Not ready isn’t a no. It’s a doorway.” Whose room in your own life needs someone willing to stand in that doorway — and what would your version of “Tell me about her” be?

11.

“Do I have closure? I don’t know.” Why do you think the book refuses a tidy ending with Horacio? What does it offer in place of closure?

12.

Rob writes that the cardinal “wasn’t a miracle... the message is still being sent.” What do you make of signs after loss? Has the book changed how you would receive one?

13.

The book ends with instructions: keep showing up, say the great things while they can still hear you, walk in and let yours find you. Which instruction is yours — and when will you follow it?

RESOURCES

This book argues that there is a solution. Here is where to find help putting it into practice. These are the organizations I trust and point people to. All of it is free or low cost.

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. Call or text 988. Twenty-four hours a day, free and confidential. For anyone reading this in a dark place — the addiction pages, the grief pages, any of it.

If You or Someone You Love Is Struggling With Addiction

SAMHSA National Helpline. 1-800-662-HELP (4357). Free, confidential, twenty-four hours a day, 365 days a year, in English and Spanish. Treatment referrals and information for people and families facing substance use or mental health disorders. TTY 1-800-487-4889. Or text your ZIP code to 435748 (HELP4U). samhsa.gov/find-help

Alcoholics Anonymous. aa.org. Meetings, in person and online, almost everywhere. The chapter that gave this book its spine is called “There Is a Solution.” It is the second chapter of the book they call the Big Book.

Al-Anon Family Groups. al-anon.org. For the families and friends of alcoholics. If you love someone who drinks, this one is for you, whether or not they ever get help themselves.

If Someone You Love Is Near the End of Life

National Alliance for Care at Home. allianceforcareathome.org. The national organization for home health, hospice, and palliative care, formed from the two older bodies many people still know as NAHC and NHPCO. Its Find a Provider tool lists more than ten thousand agencies.

CaringInfo. caringinfo.org. A free program of the Alliance. Plain-language guides to hospice and palliative care, caregiving, and grief, plus advance directive forms for every state in English and Spanish. The place to start when you do not know where to start.

Hospice Foundation of America. hospicefoundation.org. 1-800-854-3402. Help understanding hospice, starting the conversation, and finding grief support after a loss.

Get Palliative Care. getpalliativecare.org. From the Center to Advance Palliative Care. It explains palliative care, which is not the same thing as hospice, and helps you find it near you.

Medicare Care Compare. medicare.gov/care-compare. Compare hospice providers in your area, including quality measures and family feedback.

Further Reading

Atul Gawande, *Being Mortal: Medicine and What Matters in the End*.

Ira Byock, *The Four Things That Matter Most*.

RESOURCES

A Note on These Resources

The phone numbers and web addresses were current when this book went to press. Organizations change. If a number stops working, search the name. None of this is medical or legal advice. It is a place to begin. One caution: stopping alcohol suddenly after heavy, steady drinking can be medically dangerous. Withdrawal can bring seizures. Let a doctor or a detox program supervise it.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Rob Brizzi is a hospice liaison and Certified Dementia Practitioner. Born in Mexico City and raised in New Jersey, he is in long-term recovery and has made it his mission to serve others, sitting with families in their hardest rooms and helping them show up for the people they love. He lives in Raleigh, North Carolina, with his wife, Hope. *The Cardinal's Promise* is his first book.

A powerful true story of addiction, redemption, adoption, immigration, and the promises that carry us through our darkest nights. Rob Brizzi's journey is one of painful lessons, unlikely rescue, and the unwavering love of a man who never gave up on him. From the wrestling mats of New Jersey to the hallways of hospice care, this is a story about hope, second chances, and the cardinals that remind us we are never alone.



ROB BRIZZI is a recovering addict and a Certified Dementia Practitioner (CDP) who works as a hospice liaison. Born in Mexico City and raised in New Jersey, he lives in Raleigh, North Carolina, with his wife, Hope.